

JM Financial

Powering India's Growth.

46 Marquee Transactions across Capital Markets and Corporate Advisory since January 2026

Capital Markets

NSE

NSE

₹ 22,562 Cr

IPO

KNOWLEDGE REALTY TRUST

Knowledge Realty Trust

₹ 12,107 Cr

OFS

SBI FUNDS MANAGEMENT LIMITED

SBI Funds Management

₹ 11,675 Cr

IPO + Pre-IPO

JSW Infrastructure

JSW Infrastructure

₹ 7,503 Cr

QIP

CUBE HIGHWAYS TRUST

Cube Highways Trust

₹ 5,963 Cr

InvIT IPO + Block + Bulk

Coal India

Coal India

₹ 5,511 Cr

OFS

Altius

Altius InvIT

₹ 3,656 Cr

Block + Bulk

BAGMANE

Bagmane REIT

₹ 3,405 Cr

REIT IPO

VI

Vodafone Idea

₹ 3,300 Cr

Structured syndicated financing

LEAP

LEAP India

₹ 2,851 Cr

IPO + Pre-IPO

BIRET

Brookfield REIT

₹ 2,600 Cr

QIP

HORIZON INDUSTRIAL PARKS

Horizon Industrial Parks

₹ 2,600 Cr

IPO

SYMBIOTEC

Symbiotec

₹ 2,455 Cr

IPO + Pre-IPO

ELEVATE

Elevate Campuses

₹ 2,100 Cr

IPO

Piramal Finance

Piramal Finance

₹ 2,100 Cr

QIP

MILKYMIST

Milky Mist

₹ 2,035 Cr

IPO + Pre-IPO

SHADOWFAX

Shadowfax

₹ 1,907 Cr

IPO

JUNIPER Green Energy

Juniper

₹ 1,800 Cr

IPO

Shiprocket

Shiprocket

₹ 1,617 Cr

IPO

AYE

Aye Finance

₹ 1,010 Cr

IPO

HERO

Hero Motors

₹ 1,000 Cr

IPO

kissht

Kissht

₹ 926 Cr

IPO

turtlemint

Turtlemint

₹ 883 Cr

IPO

IK

Karamtara Engineering

₹ 875 Cr

IPO

AUGMONT

Augmont

₹ 825 Cr

IPO

Arcil

ARCIL

₹ 788 Cr

IPO + Pre-IPO

VARMORA

Varmora

₹ 708 Cr

IPO

LUMINO

Lumino Industries

₹ 700 Cr

IPO

TEMPSENS

Tempsens

₹ 650 Cr

IPO

GAJA CAPITAL

Gaja Capital

₹ 550 Cr

IPO

IdeaForge

IdeaForge

₹ 500 Cr

QIP

BRND ME

Mensa Brands Technologies

₹ 300 Cr

Refinancing of venture debt lenders

Source: Prime Database | OFS executed by subsidiary of JM Financial Ltd.

Corporate Advisory

NEUP BUILDCON LIMITED

Financial Advisor for stake sale in 1,363 MW solar power portfolio to Alpha Alternatives

₹ 6,829 Cr¹

happiest minds

Financial Advisor to Happiest Minds and its Promoter on their stake sale and merger with ITC Infotech

₹ 6,133 Cr

JSW Steel

Fairness Opinion for amalgamation of BMM Ispat into JSW Steel

Sequent

Financial Advisor for the merger of Viyash Life Sciences into SeQuant

₹ 3,872 Cr

Century

Financial Advisor for sale of Century Pulp & Paper to ITC

₹ 3,498 Cr¹

GABRIEL

Financial Advisor for acquisition of stakes in HL Mando Anand and HL Klemove India

₹ 3,166 Cr

NEUP BUILDCON LIMITED

Financial Advisor for stake sale in Transmission asset (470 ckm) to Alpha Alternatives

₹ 2,914 Cr¹

GABRIEL

Financial Advisor for acquisition of auto-comps business and investments

₹ 2,155 Cr

FOSECO

Financial Advisor and Manager to Open Offer for acquisition of controlling stake in Morganite Crucible India

₹ 872 Cr²

SURYA

Financial Advisor to Surya Children's Medicare and SeaLink Capital Partners on fundraising from Novo Holdings

TVSCREDIT

Fairness Opinion for amalgamation of STPL, Home Credit and TVS Housing Finance into TVS Credit

JK PAPER LTD.

Financial Advisor for consolidation of its paper and packaging business

UPL

Financial Advisor for creating a focused crop protection platform involving India & global business

BELRISE INDUSTRIES

Fairness Opinion for amalgamation of Badve Autocomps and Eximius Infra Tech into Belrise

Source: JM Financial internal database and Mergermarket | Note: 1– Announced value 2 – Including Open Offer

JM Financial Limited

Corporate Identity Number: L67120MH1986PLC038784 | SEBI Registration Number: INM000010361 (Merchant Banker) | Registered Office: 7th Floor, Cnergy, Appasaheb Marathe Marg, Prabhadevi, Mumbai - 400 025.
Tel: +91 22 6630 3030 | Fax: +91 22 6630 3223 | Web: www.jmfl.com

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प्रथम तल, कॉमशिल कॉम्प्लेक्स, पी-2, सेक्टर-ओवेगा-1, ग्रेटर नोएडा, जनपद गौतमबुद्ध नगर, 201308 (उ.प्र.)
Toll Free No. 18001808296 वेबसाइट: www.yamunaexpresswayauthority.com

पत्रांक : वाई.ई.ए./भूलेख(ओ0एस0डी0)/202/2026 दिनांक : 25.09.2026

सार्वजनिक सूचना

निम्नलिखित भूमि यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण द्वारा आपसी सहमति के आधार पर वर्तमान में प्रचलित दर के अनुसार काशतकारों से भूमि क्रय किया जाना प्रस्तावित है-

ग्राम कादरपुर सेक्टर-24 के अन्तर्गत 45 मी0 चौड़ी सड़क व भूखण्ड संख्या-1बी, 02 व 03 के अन्तर्गत

क्रमांक	खाता संख्या	खसरा संख्या	खसरे का कुल क्षेत्रफल (हे०में)	खातेदार का नाम व पता	तहसील से प्राप्त रिपोर्ट के आधार पर काशतकार का हिस्सा (हे० में)	काशतकार का विक्रय हेतु क्षेत्रफल (हे० में)
1	228 237	193अ 193ब	1.9400 0.0170	श्री रोहताश पुत्र रामचन्द्र नि० ग्राम	0.3542 0.0034	0.3542 0.0034
2	228 237	193अ 193ब	1.9400 0.0170	श्री राजेन्द्र पुत्र रामचन्द्र नि० ग्राम	0.3542 0.0034	0.3542 0.0034

उपरोक्त भूमि क्रय किये जाने में यदि किसी व्यक्ति को कोई आपत्ति है तो वह लिखित रूप में 15 दिन के अंदर विशेष कार्याधिकारी, यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औ० नि० प्राधिकरण के कार्यालय में अपनी आपत्ति प्रस्तुत कर सकता है।

विशेष कार्याधिकारी
यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औ० नि० प्राधिकरण

यमुना एक्सप्रेसवे औद्योगिक विकास प्राधिकरण के अधिसूचित क्षेत्र में प्राधिकरण द्वारा स्वीकृत मास्टर प्लान के अतिरिक्त प्लॉटिंग / हाउसिंग / कॉलोनी या किसी भी प्रकार का अन्य निर्माण पूरी तरह से अवैध है। सामान्यजन इस प्रकार की खरीदफरोख्त से पूर्णतः सचेत रहें तथा कॉलोनाइजर के भ्रामक विज्ञापनों से बचें। अधिक जानकारी के लिए प्राधिकरण की वेबसाइट www.yamunaexpresswayauthority.com देखें।

EASTERN RAILWAY
Inviting e-Tender against Open Tender
Notice No. : 67-SDSTE-ASN-2026-27,
Dated: 28.09.2026 by Senior Divisional
Signal & Telecom Engineer, Eastern
Railway, Asansol Division, Station Road,
Asansol, Pin-713301 for the following
work. **Name of Work / Location :**
"Asansol Division Provision of CCTV
surveillance system at NI LC Gates in
Asansol Division"; **Tender Value :**
₹ 1,95,14,877.46/-; **Earnest Money :**
₹ 3,90,300.00/-; **Completion period of
the work :** 18 months from the date of
issue of LOA; **Date & Time of
Closing of the Tender :** 22.10.2026
at 14.00 hrs.; **Website Particulars :**
<http://www.ireps.gov.in>
ASN-273/2026-27
Tender Notice is also available at websites :
www.er.indianrailways.gov.in / www.ireps.gov.in
Follow us at :  @EasternRailway
 @easternrailwayheadquarter

**Canara HSBC Life Insurance Company Limited**
139, Sector - 44, Gurugram-122003, Haryana (India)
Tel: 0124-4535500, Email: procurement@canarahsbcclife.in
NOTICE INVITING BIDS/OFFERS
Open Tender is invited against RFP for Operations Outsourcing dated 30th Sept'26
Above tender has been uploaded on <https://www.canarahsbcclife.com/tenders-notices.html>.
website of Canara HSBC Life Insurance Company Ltd. All prospective bidders are advised to
visit the aforesaid website for downloading the RFP.

**Canara HSBC Life Insurance Company Limited**
139, Sector - 44, Gurugram-122003, Haryana (India)
Tel: 0124-4535500, Email: procurement@canarahsbcclife.in
NOTICE INVITING BIDS/OFFERS
Open Tender is invited against RFP for Onboarding Agency for Brand Campaign Digital Media
dated 30th September'26.
Above tender has been uploaded on <https://www.canarahsbcclife.com/tenders-notices.html>.
website of Canara HSBC Life Insurance Company Ltd. All prospective bidders are advised to
visit the aforesaid website for downloading the RFP.

**जयपुर जिला दुग्ध उत्पादक सहकारी संघ लि.**
गांधी नगर रेल्वे स्टेशन के पास, जयपुर-302015, ईपीएलईएक्स: 0141-2713866-69
E-Mail: jaipurdairy@jaipurdairy.com website: www.jaipurdairy.com
निविदा / ई-निविदा / पंजीकरण-सूचना
जयपुर लि.दु.उ.सं.स. लि. जयपुर विभागीय एरिया नं. 116, 133 पर सस्य दुध उत्पाद सलाई कार्य/बूथों,
एजेंसियों एवं पालर्स पर सस्य द्वारा पेट्रिंग का कार्य/बी.एम.सी., डी.सी.एस. एवं उपकेन्द्रों पर ची परिवहन का
कार्य/विज्ञान सामग्री आपूर्ति कार्य/क्वक वॉशिंग दूध नं. 8101, 8106, 8111, 8112, 8114, 8115 एवं
8123 पर जीज पर सस्य उत्पाद विक्री कार्य काय निम्न पालर्स नं. 162 दूधन नं. 510-511, इन्दा बाजार
जयपुर/ पालर्स नं. 186 आरसीडीएफ परस्पर स्थित पर मासिक लीज पर सस्य दूध एवं दुग्ध उत्पाद विक्री करने का
कार्य की ई-निविदाएं <http://eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in> पर आमंत्रित की जाती है।
ई-निविदाएं एवं समस्त शर्तें डाउनलोड करने एवं अवलोक करने की अन्तिम तिथियां एवं ईपक्की/फीस इत्यादि का
पूर्ण विवरण <http://eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in> एवं www.jaipurdairy.com एवं sppp.rajjasthan.gov.in पर भी देखा
जा सकता है।
NIB Code : CDF2627A0764 जीवन में भरे रास - हमारा प्यारा  प्रबन्ध संचालक

भरतपुर विकास प्राधिकरण, भरतपुर
क्रमांक - सेवा/न.वि.प्र./2026-27/13429 - 43 दिनांक - 24/09/2026
ऑनलाईन निविदा सूचना सं. 45/2026-27
राजस्थान के राज्यपाल महोदय की ओर से भरतपुर विकास प्राधिकरण, में उपयुक्त श्रेणी
एवं विभिन्न विभागों में ए एवं एए श्रेणी में पंजीकृत संवेदकों से निर्धारित प्रपत्र में ई-प्रोक्योरमेंट
प्रक्रिया से कुल 01 कार्य हेतु ऑनलाईन निविदाएं आमंत्रित की जाती है।
उक्त कार्य का विस्तृत विवरण, निविदा शर्तें, अनुमानित लागत राशि, निविदा बेचने, प्राप्त
करने एवं खोलने की दिनांक आदि सम्पूर्ण विवरण वेबसाइट
bdabharatpur@rajasthan.gov.in एवं <http://sppp.raj.nic.in> portal पर देखा जा
सकता है। निविदा से संबंधित किसी भी प्रकार का संशोधन <http://eproc.rajjasthan.gov.in>
एवं <http://sppp.raj.nic.in> portal का अवलोकन करें।
UBN विवरण :-WAQ2627WSRC00118 अधिराणी अनिरात
रत्न खवार/बी/26/10885 भरतपुर विकास प्राधिकरण, भरतपुर

**MADHYA PRADESH TOURISM BOARD**
6th Floor, Lily Trade Wing, Jehangirabad, Bhopal
Madhya Pradesh, India, Pin code - 462008
Website : www.tourism.mp.gov.in
(CIN) : U75302MP2017NPL043078
**REQUEST FOR PROPOSAL FOR ENGAGEMENT OF
AGENCY FOR DIGITAL MEDIA MANAGEMENT**
NIT No. : 5432/2026/MPTB 29 September 2026
System No. : 2026. MPTB. 536176
Bids are invited for Engagement of Agency for Digital Media
Management. The detailed terms & conditions can be
downloaded from website <https://www.mptenders.gov.in/>
www.tourism.mp.gov.in For any other information, contact
+91-9407057416 or email on cs.mptb@mp.gov.in contact
No. 0755-2780600 or email on : neelam.rawat@mp.gov.in.
Last date and Time for online submission is 12.11.2026- 03:00
PM.
M.P. Madhyam/128285/2026 **MANAGING DIRECTOR**

**New Okhla Industrial Development Authority**
Administrative Building, Sector-96, Noida, G.B. Nagar (U.P.)
Website : www.noidaauthorityonline.in
E-TENDER NOTICE
E-Tender are invited from firms/contractors registered with
UPLC Lucknow for the following jobs against which bids can be
uploaded and same shall be opened/downloaded as per
schedule mentioned. The details and conditions of all tenders
are available on NOIDA Authority's official website:
www.noidaauthorityonline.com & <http://etender.up.nic.in>.
Please ensure to see these websites for any changes/
amendments & corrigendum etc.
1. **75/S.M.(JAL)-I/E.T./2026-27**, Village Development and
Maintenance(Construction of R.C.C. Under Ground
Reservoir Capacity of 1500 KL in Village-Bishanpura),
Noida. Cost Rs. 330.45 Lacs
2. **16/S.M. (GANGAJAL)/E.T./2026-27**, Strengthening of
Gangajal (Supply and Erection of 400 KVA, 250 KVA and
63 KVA Transformers in standby provision at different
Gangajal UGRs and Fixing High Mast light and LED Lights
at Gangajal UGRs in Sector-65, 47, 83, 35, 62, 51, 72, 69
(M2 and M3), 118 (M1), 132 and137), Noida. Cost
Rs. 133.21 Lacs
Which can be uploaded by date: 06.10.2026 upto 5.00 PM.
Pre-qualification shall be opened/downloaded on date :-
07.10.2026 at 11.00 AM. General Manager (Jal)
Office: Sec - 5 NOIDA
CLEAN, GREEN, SAFE & SECURE NOIDA

**भारतीय रिजर्व बैंक**
RESERVE BANK OF INDIA
www.rbi.org.in
**Auction of Government of India Dated Securities
for ₹33,000 crore on October 01, 2026**
Government of India has announced the sale (re-issue) of following dated
securities:

Sr. No	Nomenclature	Notified amount Nominal (in ₹Crore)	Earmarked for Retail Investors (in ₹Crore)
1.	6.20% GS 2029	9,000	450
2.	6.57% GS 2033	12,000	600
3.	7.63% GS 2056	9,000	450
4.	7.50% GOI SGRB 2056	3,000	150

The securities will be sold through Reserve Bank of India, Mumbai
Office, Fort, Mumbai - 400001, as per the terms and conditions spelt out
in the General Notification F.No.4(2)-B(W&M)/2018, dated March 26,
2025 and the Specific Notification issued in this regard.

The auction will be conducted using **multiple price method on October
01, 2026 (Thursday)**. The result will be announced on the same day
and payment by successful bidders will have to be made on **October
05, 2026 (Monday)**.

Retail investors can participate in the auction on a non-competitive
basis as per the Scheme for non-competitive bidding facility. Individual
investors can also place bids through the Retail Direct portal
(<https://rbiretaildirect.org.in>).

For further details, please see press release dated **September 28,
2026** on RBI website (www.rbi.org.in).

Government Stock offers safety, liquidity and attractive returns for long duration.
"Don't get cheated by E-mails/SMSs/Calls promising you money."

**CLASSIFIEDS**

MATRIMONIALS

GROOMS WANTED

AGARWAL

BISA AGARWAL

ENGINEER

BRAHMIN

DIVORCEE/WIDOW

COSMOPOLITAN

KAYASHTHA

RAJPUT

HINDU

SIKH

SIKH

AGARWAL

ENGINEER

DIVORCEE/WIDOW

COSMOPOLITAN

KAYASHTHA

RAJPUT

HINDU

SIKH

MATCH FOR SIKH KHATRI GIRL 31 yrs, 5'5", Bangalore-based, B.Arch from CSIT, Secunderabad & BIM Professional Course for Architects. Working as Senior Architect with a Design Consultancy in Bangalore. Twin sisters, Educated, cultured & family-oriented. Father MBA, formerly with Asian Paints; mother retired teacher. Seeking well-educated, professionally settled Sikh Khatri boy from a respectable family.
9849640921, 8008506394
contact.khannarishte@yahoo.com

DELHI NCR based Match for Slim, b'tul, Very Fair Bansal girl, 33 / 5'4", Assistant Professor Delhi University, Master in Economics from D.S.E., I-less divorcee. WhatApp: 971787704

SUITABLE MATCH for brahmin UM girl 5'6" / 14.07.86, 2.45 PM, Ghaziabad / MBA & working, Caste No Bar, Call & WhatsApp: 9818434007, E-mail: pkvashishtha@gmail.com

SM 4 Gaur Brahmin July 1994 born, 5'6" working in UN Organization 12 Lpa. Tall, Smart, Teetotaler, working Room required. M Number: 9910024660

MATCH FOR Hindu Kayastha girl, 5'4", born 26.11.1996 at 02:05 AM in New Delhi, Professor in University, LLB, LL.M, NET, PHD, Upper Caste Also Invite. Contact: 981115044

WANTED HANDSOME, age below 65, SBHK HIG Flat in Gurgaon, normal Class-I income. Own Car, well-settled Person for V.Beautiful good looking, height 5'5 Retd. Officer MoD Brahmin Hindu vegetarian Girl, Urgent Engage-ment. Please Contact: 7428441654.

MATCH FOR SIKH KHATRI GIRL 31 yrs, 5'5", Bangalore-based, MSc & MPhil in Clinical Psychology, working as Clinical Psychologist with reputed hospital in Bangalore. Twin sister, Educated, cultured & family-oriented. Father MBA, formerly with Asian Paints; mother retired teacher. Seeking well-educated, professionally settled Sikh Khatri boy from a respectable family.
9849640921, 8008506394
contact.khannarishte@yahoo.com

POM, PREFERABLY, Doctor, for Sikh Saluja Doctor Girl, DM Neonatology, Doing Government Job, Delhi, Feb 93, Contact 9336233633

DHALLA KHATRI PB Boy 28.5.1994 / 1:00 AM / Kuru Khethra / 6'2" / M.5 Civil Engineering, Seeks Canada Based Qualified Girl. Contact: 999194000

ALLIANCE FOR Arora Boy 28/6/1" B.tech, MBA 22 LPA Own House in GK-I New Delhi, Mother Teacher, Father Businessman, Early Marriage. Call 9818898097, 9810002103

1982- BORN Sachdeva, divorced boy seeks homely divorced/widow girl. No dowry. Poor family also welcome. Contact: 9990456965

Hindustan Times FIRST VOICE. LAST WORD.

Don't Just Follow Culture. Understand It

Culture isn't just what's trending.

It's the ideas changing how we live. The conversations shaping what we watch, read, wear, eat, create and care about. Every Saturday, HT Brunch goes beyond what's new to explore what's next—and why it matters. Because understanding culture is always more rewarding than simply following it.



Wednesday, September 30, 2026

mint

Think Ahead. Think Growth.

mint primer

Kerala HC order: A boost for govt on drug prices?

BY KRISHNA YADAV & JESSICA JANI

The Kerala high court on 28 September gave the Centre a legal route to intervene when patented life-saving medicines become unaffordable, holding that the government can invoke Section 100 of the Patents Act, 1970, to use a patented drug for public health purposes. *Mint* explains:



1 What is the Kerala high court ruling?

A breast cancer patient moved the court in June 2022, seeking state intervention to make ribociclib, a patented Novartis AG drug costing ₹75,000 a month, affordable. Though she died in September 2022, the court continued the matter as a suo motu proceeding, treating it as a broader public health issue. It expanded the case to include Eli Lilly's abemaciclib, also used to treat breast cancer. It has asked the Centre to collect data on how many patients need these drugs, how many cannot afford them, and whether subsidies and price-control norms are effective. But high costs alone do not warrant government intervention.

MINT

2 What's the Patent Act's Section 100?

It allows patented inventions to be used for government purposes. The court held that the provision is broad enough to let the Centre, or a person authorized by it, to supply a patented drug to patients on a non-commercial basis. It linked this power to the state's duty to protect public health under Article 47, as well as to the public health principles set out in Section 83 of the Patents Act. At present, the Centre can allow a third party to make, use or sell a patented invention without the patent holder's consent through "compulsory licensing". India has issued such a licence once, in 2012, to Natco Pharma for Bayer's Nexavar.

3 How does the Kerala HC ruling benefit patients?

Access to treatments for cancers and rare diseases remains a challenge in India. A 2022 study by the Tata Memorial Centre found that fewer than 3% of patients had access to immunotherapies. Experts believe this judgement could have wider implications, extending to other life saving drugs, but its lack of a direct ruling or timeline leaves uncertainty.

4 How does this impact companies?

The Indian market accounts for a small share of global pharmaceutical companies' revenues. But the judgement highlights a "policy tension" between innovators and access to life-saving drugs, said Tushar Gulati, associate partner, Dentons Link Legal. Pharmaceutical firms rely on predictable patent protection to incentivize research and development, he said, but patent exclusivity can create access problems when life-saving drugs are unaffordable for many patients.

5 How do experts see the judgement?

Lawyers said the ruling seeks to balance patent protection with public health needs, but may deter pharmaceutical firms from investing in India. "The judgment is calibrated to preserve patent sanctity, not erode it," said Gitika Suri, director-patents at Cyril Amarchand Mangaldas. Amit Panigrahi, partner at Kochhar & Co., said it could nevertheless create regulatory uncertainty and make companies more cautious about investing in or launching expensive patented medicines in the country.

QUICK EDIT

Tata rejig proposal

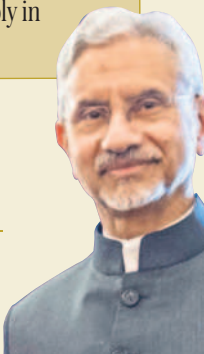
Have the trusts that own 66% of Tata Sons found an escape hatch from regulatory pressure to take the company public? In Tata Trusts' view, a merger of Tata Sons with two operating firms, Tata Electronics Systems Solutions Pvt Ltd (TESS) and Tata Consulting Engineers (TCE), would rejig the combine's revenues and assets in a way that will enable the group's holding company to drop its 'financial' tag along with a tick-box that required it to give up private ownership. While both TESS and TCE are currently subsidiaries of Tata Sons, the idea represents a wager on the future stability of such a union's balance-sheet math. This plan would also need the approval of India's central bank, Tata Sons' regulator, apart from a nod from a board of directors in open rebellion against the will of the Trusts. So it's a proposal that may or may not see the light of day. Yet, no matter what the argument is for listing Tata Sons, with the question of what serves the Indian economy best at the crux of it, its owner must retain agency over its destiny. Ownership rights, let's not forget, have not just been the key divide between capitalism and communism, they shape long-term economic outcomes.

QUOTE OF THE DAY

We are today looking at a situation where some of the major grain exporters will not be able to send out their shipments, particularly out to the Black Sea... there is going to be a major food crisis probably in the coming months.

S. JAISHANKAR
EXTERNAL AFFAIRS
MINISTER

He was speaking at an event in the US about the food situation amid raging global conflicts.



INSIDE

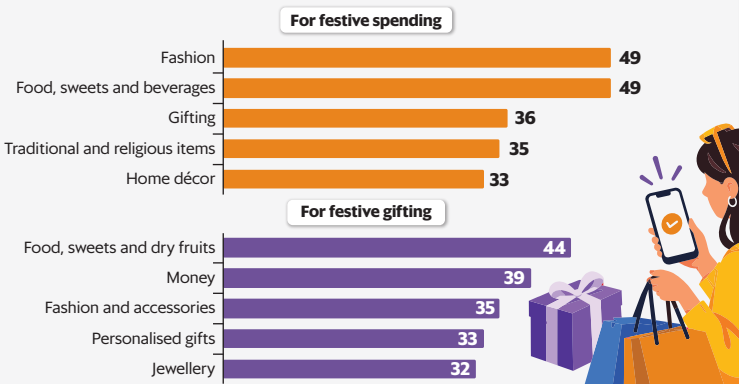
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mint | DATA BITES

HOW GEN Z SPENDS DURING FESTIVE SEASON

Fashion and food top Gen Z's festive spending, with 49% picking each among their top five categories. Food, sweets and dry fruits are also the most popular gifts, chosen by 44%, followed by cash or money at 39%.

Share of respondents who included each category among their top five choices (in %)



The survey, conducted via YouGov, covered 4,002 individuals aged 18-29 years across 18 states. Around 51% of respondents were men and 49% were women.

Data: Rupanjal Chauhan
Graphic: Prateek Kumar

Source: Rukam Capital

COLUMNS



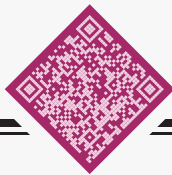
KAUSHIK BASU
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Deep Mukherjee
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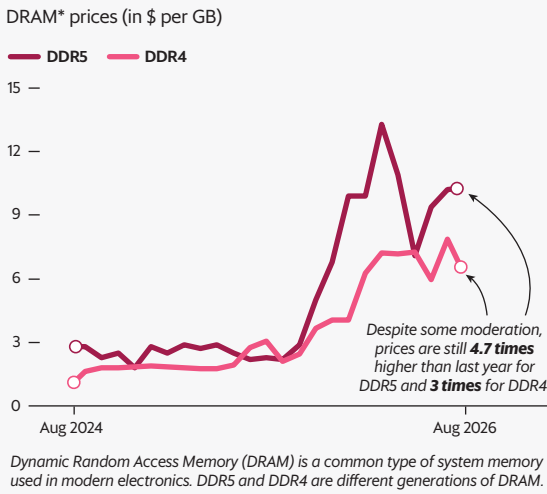


HOW CHIPFLATION HAS PUSHED COSTS IN INDIA

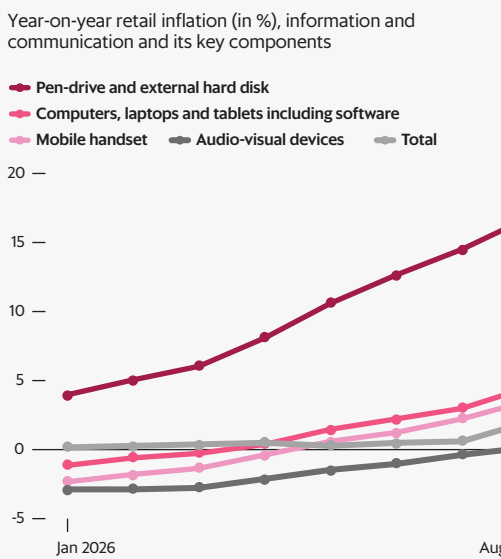
BY RUPANJAL CHAUHAN | rupanjal.chauhan@livemint.com

Rising global memory chip costs are driving up India's tech import bill and consumer device prices, though low inflation weightage keeps the broader economic impact contained.

AI demand has sent memory chip prices skyrocketing in the past year

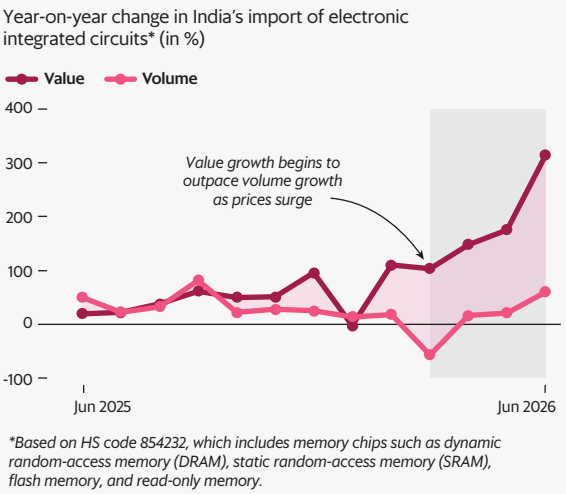


Chipflation has begun showing up in India's retail inflation basket

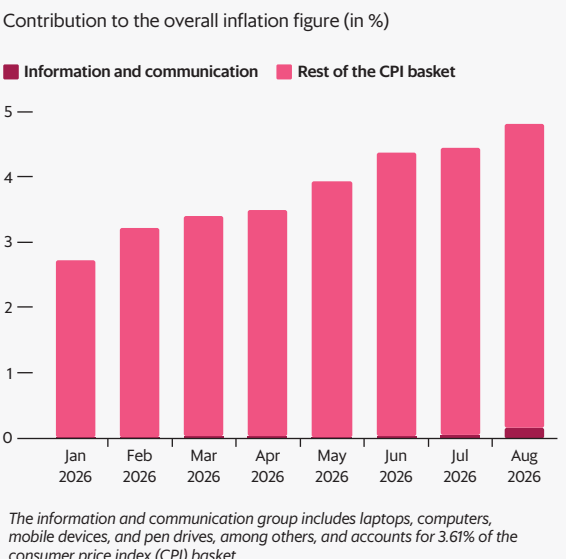


Source: Stanford University, Commerce ministry, CMIE, Mint calculations

Soaring memory-chip prices have ballooned India's import bill in the last few months



AI-led prices are pushing inflation up, but their contribution is tiny



PRATEEK KUMAR/MINT

The surge in memory chip prices is beginning to leave a trail across India's economic data. It first shows up in the country's import bill, where the value of electronic integrated circuits used as memories is rising as much as five times faster than the volume being imported. From there, higher chip prices are making their way through the electronics supply chain, raising costs for manufacturers and, eventually, the prices paid by consumers. Globally, this phenomenon is known as 'chipflation'. In India, from pen drives to mobile handsets and laptops, the signs of chipflation are becoming harder to miss. For now, however, its contribution to overall inflation remains tiny because of the low weight of these products in the consumer price index (CPI) basket. The impact, therefore, is unlikely to be felt in a generalized manner across India, but will be more visible to consumers buying these products.

THE TRADE-OFF

India is a large consumer as well as assembler of electronic products, which means its dependence on imports for input goods is high. As a result, the first sign of chipflation shows up in India's import bill.

The AI boom and hyperscalers investing billions of dollars in data centres around the world have created unprecedented demand for memory chips, outstripping supply. AI data centres require large quantities of high-performance memory, particularly high-bandwidth memory (HBM) and server-grade dynamic random access memory (DRAM). As chipmakers have directed more capacity towards these higher-value products, supplies of conventional memory used in consumer electronics have tightened, pushing prices higher.

Prices of DRAM—the main system memory used in laptops, smartphones, smart TVs and other electronic products—serve as a benchmark and a bellwether for the storage and electronics market. These prices have skyrocketed in the past year, rising over 400% between August 2025 and March 2026, before moderating since then. The prices were still 4.7 times the level in August compared to a year ago.

When it comes to India's import bill, one way to identify price pressures is to see the difference between value and volume growth. Until January 2026, year-on-year growth in both value and volume terms for electronic integrated circuits used as memories—the group that includes memory chips such as DRAM, static random-access memory (SRAM), flash memory, and read-only memory, among others—moved closely. This changed from February, when value growth shot up to 110%, while volume growth was 18%. By June, this divergence had widened further: import value surged 314% y-o-y, compared with a 60% increase in volume.

"It can be indicative of either price increases, or imports of higher-end chips," said Anubhuti Sahay, India economics research head at Standard Chartered Bank. "Our view is that most of it is likely to be driven by chip price increases, a global theme."

To be sure, electronic integrated circuits used as memories were only 12% of India's total electronic imports, but the price rises are visible across other AI-linked segments as well. According to an analysis by Standard Chartered Bank, the 12-month rolling trade deficit in AI-enabling products—advanced semiconductors, processors, memory chips, data-processing units—and networking hardware—rose to 2.0% of GDP in July 2026 from 1.5% a year earlier. The deficit was marginally higher than India's gold trade deficit of 1.9% of GDP.

PRICE PINCH

Similarly, inflation in the information and communica-

AT A GLANCE

- Driven by AI data centre investments, benchmark DRAM memory prices jumped over 400% in the past year, leaving chipmakers scrambling.
- Price shock first showed up in import bill. As reliance on imported inputs collided with global price rises, chip costs rose over 300% y-o-y, far outstripping actual volume growth.
- This rising tide of chipflation has expanded the trade gap for AI-enabling tech to 2% of GDP, eclipsing India's huge gold import deficit, Standard Chartered's analysis showed.
- Consumers feel a pinch as storage device inflation rose 16%, but since electronics carry a small weight in CPI, overall inflation saw a modest 0.12 percentage point hit in August.

tions segment, which includes electronic items such as pen drives, laptops, and mobile devices, is picking up gradually.

The sharpest rise has been in pen drives and external hard disks, where inflation jumped from 3.9% in January to 16.8% in August.

Pen drives use NAND flash memory, whose supply is being squeezed as memory makers shift capacity and investment towards higher-value products.

The supply squeeze is therefore feeding into storage-device prices. External hard disks are also seeing higher prices, as demand for high-capacity storage has risen faster than manufacturers have been able to expand supply.

Mobile handsets, meanwhile, moved from deflation to inflation during the same period.

Prices fell 2.3% year-on-year in January, but handset inflation rose above 3.5% in August, the highest since at least January.

Mobile phones primarily use Low Power Double Data Rate (LPDDR) memory, which has also become more expensive amid the broader memory-supply squeeze.

While Indians planning to purchase any of these electronic goods will feel the price pinch, chipflation is unlikely to be felt in a more generalized manner because of its low weightage.

The information and communication segment, which also includes mobile tariffs and streaming costs, has a total weightage of 3.61% in the CPI basket.

Pen drives and external hard disks account for just 0.01% weight in the CPI basket; mobile handsets 0.56%, and computers, laptops, tablets account for 0.04%.

Rising costs have started adding to headline inflation, but their contribution remained limited to just 0.12 percentage points in the latest print of 4.8% overall inflation, including the impact of a sharp rise in mobile tariffs.

According to Gaura Sengupta, chief economist at IDFC FIRST Bank, inflation in this segment will be gradual and contained to urban upper-income segment, which is more exposed to high-end electronic devices.

"Since CPI represents our entire country, and nearly 70% of our country lives in rural areas, the impact of AI cost pressures on headline CPI will remain contained," Sengupta added.

Cooling valuations open new avenues

However, low multiples can signal weak prospects for stocks

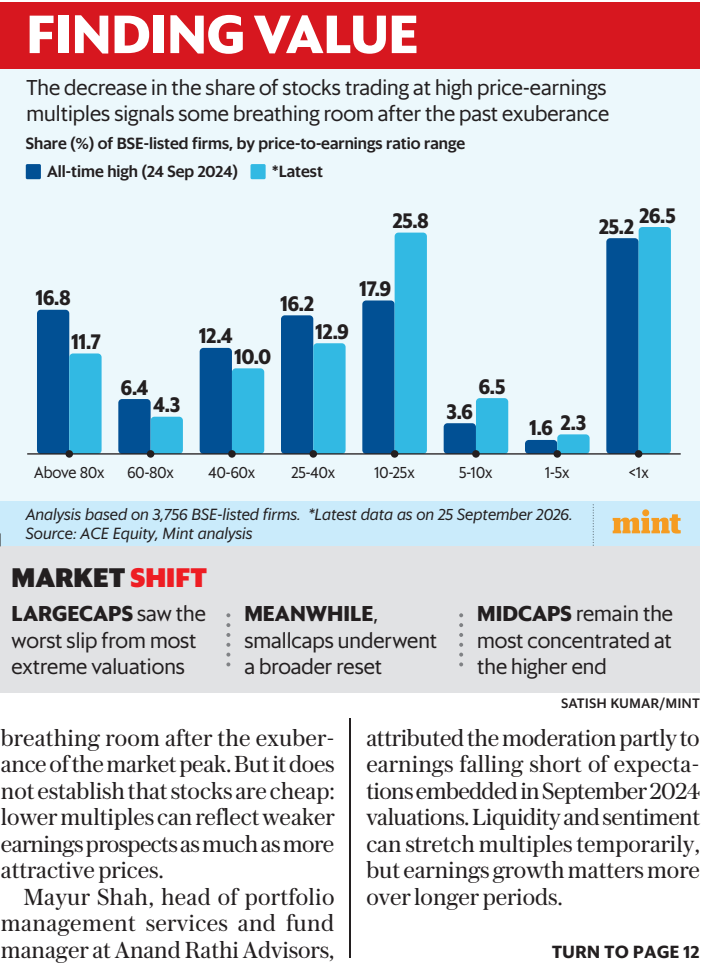
Mayur Bhalariao
mayur.bhalariao@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Two years after Indian equities scaled a peak, with the BSE Sensex hitting its all-time high in September 2024, investors now have more stocks to choose from at lower valuations. Finding value, however, still requires looking beyond the price tag.

The sharpest retreat from the most extreme valuations—above 80 times earnings—has been in large-caps. Smallcaps, meanwhile, have undergone a broader reset across the expensive valuation bands. Midcaps remain the most concentrated at the higher end, with expectations of stronger growth helping to sustain their premiums.

A Mint analysis of 3,756 BSE-listed companies based on ACE Equity data as of 25 September captures this shift. The share of stocks trading above the price-to-earnings ratio (P/E) of 40 fell to 26% from 36% in September 2024—from more than one in three companies to roughly one in four. The proportion trading at 10-25 times earnings rose to 26% from 18%.

The change offers investors some



Legacy AMC's show resilience amid a volatile market

Apoorva Ajith
apoorva.ajith@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Established mutual fund houses have outperformed newer rivals in several categories over the past year, braving market volatility with deeper performance track records, stickier investor money and greater access to initial public offerings (IPOs).

A Mint analysis of six mutual fund categories shows legacy fund houses outperformed newer asset management companies (AMCs) in four. In the large- and mid-cap fund category, legacy AMCs delivered an average return of 3.2% between September 2025 and September 2026, compared with 0.8% for fund houses launched over the past decade, based on data from investment research firm Value Research.

The gap was narrower in multi-asset allocation funds, where legacy AMCs delivered an average return of 11.07%, compared with 8.7% for newer players. In arbitrage funds, established fund houses delivered an average return of 6.6%, against 6.4% for their newer counterparts.

The divergence comes as fund managers navigate tur-



Established MF houses have outperformed newer rivals. AP

bulent markets. The Nifty 50 has fallen 8.4% since the US-Iran war began on 28 February, touching 22,331.4 on 30 March, its lowest close since then. The uncertainty, however, hasn't deterred investors, with mutual fund assets under management (AUM) growing about 16% year-on-year to ₹87.08 trillion as of August, according to the Association of Mutual Funds in India.

Mint selected the top 10 legacy AMCs by AUM and new AMCs with one-year return data. AMCs launched in the past decade are classified as new, while older fund houses are classified as legacy.

How Trusts picked 2 cos to merge with Tata Sons

Nehal Chaliawala & Shouvik Das
MUMBAI/NEW DELHI

Tata Trusts' proposal to merge Tata Consulting Engineers (TCE) and Tata Electronics Systems Solutions Pvt. Ltd (TESS) into Tata Sons is centred on the two companies' clean shareholding structures and significant revenues—factors that could help the holding company potentially avoid classification as a non-banking financial company (NBFC) without altering its shareholding structure, according to experts.

Both companies are wholly owned within the Tata Sons structure, meaning the proposed mergers would not bring in additional shareholders. TCE is a 100% direct subsidiary of Tata Sons, while TESS is wholly owned by Tata Electronics, which in turn is wholly-owned by Tata Sons. That structure also makes the two companies easier to merge than listed subsidiaries, which have minority shareholders to account for.

"Both are unlisted companies and are also wholly owned subsidiary companies; hence, procedurally, it would be con-



Nifty hits weakest monthly expiry since Mar as yields soar

The Nifty 50 stock index slid to its weakest monthly expiry in six months on Tuesday amid surging bond yields induced by persistently high crude oil prices. The bellwether index closed at 22,716.20 on Tuesday.

P4

Govt may hike outlay under two key tax refund schemes

With exporters facing global headwinds, India is considering substantially raising the tax refund outlay to almost ₹2 trillion over the next five years under its two main programmes—the RoDTEP and the RoSCTL.

P2

Essar unit Mesabi bets \$18 billion on US steel facility

President Donald Trump announced Essar-backed Mesabi Metallica's \$18 billion investment to build a fully integrated American steel company, including what he called the "largest steel plant in American history" in Iowa.

P5

NOTE TO READERS The 36-page Mint media marketing magazine, 'Mint Catalyst', being carried with this issue is the equivalent of a paid-for advertisement, and no Mint journalist was involved in creating it. Readers would do well to treat it as an advertisement.

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The bank strike scheduled from 28–30 September was put off conditionally.

IBA forms panel to discuss bankers' demands

Harsh Kumar
harsh.kumar@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

The Indian Banks' Association (IBA) has constituted a high-level committee with representatives of bank unions to hold discussions on the implementation of a five-day banking week, according to a communication issued on Tuesday.

The move follows an agreement reached between the IBA's negotiating committee and the United Forum of Bank Unions (UFBU) at their meeting on 27 September, the IBA said in its letter.

The committee will be chaired by Rajneesh Karnata, managing director and chief executive officer of Bank of India.

Ashok Chandra, MD and CEO of Punjab National Bank, has been appointed alternate chairman. Binod Kumar, MD and CEO of Indian Bank; Rakesh Sharma, MD and CEO of IDBI Bank; and G.S. Rana, deputy managing director (HR & CDO) at State Bank of India, will be members of the committee.

The UFBU will be represented by the general secretaries of its seven constituent unions—C.H. Venkatachalam of the All India Bank Employees' Association (AIBE), Rupam Roy of the All India Bank Officers' Confederation (AIBOC), L. Chandrasekhar of the National Confederation of Bank Employees (NCBE), Sanjay Khan of the All India Bank Officers' Association (AIBOA), Debashish B. Choudhary of the Bank Employees' Federation of India (BEFI), Prem Makkar of the Indian National Bank Officers' Congress (INBOC), and O.P. Sharma of the Indian National Bank Employees' Federation (INBEF).

The development comes two days after the UFBU deferred its proposed three-day nationwide bank strike scheduled for 28–30 September following late-night discussions with the IBA.

Queries emailed to the finance ministry and IBA on Tuesday late evening remained unanswered till the time of going to press.

Govt may hike outlay under two key tax refund schemes

The outlay for the tax refund schemes for exporters is to be raised to ₹2 trillion over five years

Bankinkar Pattanayak
bankinkar.pattanayak@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

With exporters facing global headwinds, India is considering substantially raising the tax refund outlay to almost ₹2 trillion over the next five years under its two main programmes—the Remission of Duties and Taxes on Exported Products (RoDTEP) and the Rebate of State and Central Taxes and Levies (RoSCTL).

The plan is to ease exporters' liquidity woes and partly cushion them from geopolitical conflicts, three people aware of the deliberations told *Mint*.

As part of the proposals, the commerce and industry ministry is seeking a RoDTEP corpus of more than ₹1.3 trillion, up over 70% from the previous five years through FY26, and the textiles ministry is asking for a near 50% increase in RoSCTL to ₹65,000 crore, the people said.

The finance ministry has examined the proposals of the commerce and textiles ministries, which will likely be placed before the Cabinet for approval within a month, they said.

The move assumes significance given that exporters, especially small and medium-sized units from labour-intensive sectors, are grappling with higher logistics costs and supply

Easing woes

The Centre plans to ease exporters' liquidity woes and cushion them from the effects of war by raising the tax refund outlay under RoDTEP and RoSCTL.

Expenditure on RoDTEP and RoSCTL (in ₹ crore)

	RoDTEP	RoSCTL
FY22	12,017	9,176
FY23	13,175	7,659
FY24	15,019	8,033
FY25	18,313	8,565
FY26*	18,233	10,010
FY27**	10,000	5,000

RoDTEP: Remission of Duties and Taxes on Exported Products.

RoSCTL: Rebate of State and Central Taxes and Levies.

*Revised estimate. **Budgeted and to rise once validity of the schemes is extended beyond 30 September.

Source: Budget documents

PRATEEK KUMAR/MINT

chain disruptions in the wake of a flare-up in the war in West Asia.

The demand for higher allocation comes as the ministries also expect exporters to ramp up dispatches in the coming years, taking

advantage of recent free trade agreements (FTAs) with economies including the UAE, the UK and the EU once the West Asia conflict abates, said the people cited above.

The objective is to keep exports zero-rated, in sync with global best practices, where exports are not supposed to carry domestic taxes. Eligible exporters receive refunds ranging from

0.3% to about 4.5% of the freight-on-board value of consignments under RoDTEP, and from 1.7% to 8.2% under RoSCTL, depending on the products, according to industry executives.

Queries emailed to the ministries of commerce, textiles and finance on Monday, remained unanswered until press time on Tuesday.

Through these two schemes, the government refunds hidden central and local taxes, such as fuel, electricity, stamp duty, and agricultural fees, spent on producing exported goods.

While RoDTEP covers a wide swathe

of sectors, including exporters operating out of special economic zones and bonded warehouses, the RoSCTL programme is meant for only the textiles and garments sector. *Mint* on Monday reported that the Centre is preparing to seek the Cabinet's approval to extend about a dozen flagship welfare and development schemes, including RoSCTL.

Export bodies have been asking for more predictable and enhanced rates under the two schemes to help them price contracts more effectively.

As remission rates are often revised downwards when budget allocations fall short, this creates uncertainty, senior industry executives said. A larger, committed outlay for five years would give visibility and predictability of refunds while preventing interim cuts.

"The continuation of both the schemes with adequate allocation for another five years would be extremely important, as it signals policy stability at a very challenging time for exporters," said Ajay Sahai,

director-general and chief executive of the Federation of Indian Export Organisations (FIEO). While refunds will not increase exporters' profitability, they will enhance their competitiveness in global markets by reimbursing taxes they are not required to pay, Sahai added.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

India foodgrain target set below last year's output

Vijay C Roy
vijay.roy@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

India has set a foodgrain production target of 373.93 million tonnes (mt) for the 2026–27 crop year, slightly below the record output for 2025–26, as the government factors in weather risks such as El Nino and patchy rainfall.

The target, announced by agriculture and farmers' welfare minister Shivraj Singh Chouhan, is below the actual production of 376.56mt in 2025–26. The lower target is largely driven by subdued expectations for rice and maize production.

The government has set a rabi season target of 177.72mt against 171.14mt estimated for 2025–26. Chouhan said crop plans have been drawn up keeping in view the water status of reservoirs, groundwater levels, and soil moisture.

The lower full-year target shows concerns over the impact of uneven monsoon rainfall, and drought-like conditions in some states on the kharif crop.

Farmers had sown 110.39 million hectares (mn ha.) of kharif crops as of 18 September, around 1.5mn ha. lower than last year, according to agriculture ministry data. The headline figure obscures declines in key crops such as rice, maize, sugarcane and cotton, which are crucial to India's food and fibre supplies.



India set an output target of 373.93 mt for 2026–27

Rice acreage fell 3.7% year-on-year to 42.9mn ha. Pulses offered some support, with acreage rising 1.4% to 11.9 mn ha., led by gains in Uttar Pradesh, Jharkhand, Telangana, Rajasthan, Madhya Pradesh and Andhra Pradesh. Apart from this, maize, soya bean and cotton areas have also registered a slight decline.

Chouhan said the increase in acreage under pulses, oilseeds and coarse cereals such as urad, bajra, jowar, sesame, sunflower and tur was encouraging.

Preliminary reports indicate crop damage across about 611,000 hectares in Karnataka, Maharashtra, Tamil Nadu, Telangana, Andhra Pradesh, Rajasthan and Gujarat due to heavy rains, floods or droughts, Chouhan said. A detailed scientific assessment is underway.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Uruguay follows Argentina's lead to tap India's edible oil demand

Ramita Mishra & Vijay C. Roy
NEW DELHI

Uruguay is taking a leaf out of Argentina's playbook and developing its edible-oil seeds sector with an eye on the Indian market as it seeks to diversify agricultural exports, said Alberto Antonio Guani Amarilla, the South American nation's ambassador.

"We are developing the production of oil, but it's very low. We are doing it in the sense of having India on the horizon as a future market," Amarilla said in an interview. "So, we are trying to learn from the Argentinians how to produce that oil. We're trying to see that this is a monumental market that we need to have enough capability to satisfy the needs of India."

Argentina leads Malaysia and Indonesia in selling edible oil to India. Argentina exported \$3.66 billion of edible oil to India in FY26, followed by Indonesia with \$3.48 billion and Malaysia with \$2.94 billion, according to data from the commerce ministry. Uruguay's focus will be on soya bean and sunflower oils.



Alberto Antonio Guani Amarilla, Uruguay's ambassador to India.

"We have a great area of expansion with India, especially in what has to do, for example, with sunflower oil. We also will start producing oil from soya, which is very much consumed in India," the ambassador said.

India's edible oil demand is about 26 million tonnes (mt) annually, valuing the domestic market at \$34.75 billion, according to the Solvent Extractors' Association of India (SEA), a trade body. With domestic production meeting only up to 40% of this require-

ment, India imports soybean oil from Argentina and Brazil, palm oil from Indonesia and Malaysia, and sunflower oil from Ukraine and Russia.

Prices of major edible oils, including mustard, groundnut, soybean, palm and sunflower oil, have risen by ₹14–31 per kg over the past year, according to government data. India's palm oil imports rose 12% to \$9.6 billion in FY26, while soybean oil imports jumped 23% to \$6.2 billion.

"While Uruguay's current soybean oil production is much smaller than India's, there is significant scope if the country expands its oilseed cultivation and processing capacity," said B.V. Mehta, executive director of the SEA.

Queries to spokespersons of Uruguay's livestock, agriculture, and fishing ministry, India's agriculture and commerce ministries, and the food and public distribution department remained unanswered till publishing time.

ramita.mishra@livemint.com

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Subhash Narayan
subhash.narayan@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

Ten of the 19 subsectors tracked by India's new Index of Services Production (ISP) recorded double-digit growth in July 2026 from a year earlier, while seven others also expanded, signalling sustained momentum in formal-sector services despite mixed signals from manufacturing and external trade.

The data was part of the fourth trial release of the ISP, unveiled by the government on Tuesday with 2024–25 as the base year. The index marks a significant overhaul of India's economic statistics and provides policymakers with a long-awaited monthly measure of activity in the services sector, which accounts for more than half of the economy.

The 19 sectors account for about 60% of the services economy. A composite ISP will be released later, after assessing the stability and resilience of the sub-sectoral indices and improving their coverage, the ministry of statistics and programme implementation (MoSPI) said in a statement. The monthly series is expected



Top subsectors showing continued strong growth in July include retail trade (18.5%) and accommodation and food (12.6%).

to improve short-term gross domestic product (GDP) forecasting, help the central bank better gauge demand conditions while framing monetary policy and provide businesses with an additional tool to monitor sectoral trends.

Among the subsectors reporting continued strong growth in July were administrative and support services (20.9%), retail trade (18.5%), real estate (14.4%), accommodation

and food services (12.6%), banking (12.3%), and wholesale trade (12.1%).

Air transport services con-

tracted 8.4% from a year earlier in July as the West Asia war drove energy prices higher. Repair services also contracted, shrinking 5% during the month. Postal and courier as well as

and information and broadcasting services that were in the negative zone in earlier months expanded by 8.7% and 10%,

respectively, in July.

According to the MoSPI data, road transport services grew by 9.9%, water transport 7.7% and rail transport 7.5%. Wholesale trade grew 7.7%. Telecommunication, banking and insurance sectors expanded by 11%, 12.3% and 8.9%, respectively.

Information technology and computer-related services rose 10.7%, professional, scientific and technical services, including research and development, expanded 10.4%, administrative and support services 20.9% and arts, entertainment and recreation services 1.7%.

The ISP covers the formal services economy, including wholesale and retail trade, transport, banking, insurance, telecommunications, hotels and restaurants, real estate, information technology, professional services, administrative support services and arts and entertainment. Private health and education services will be incorporated later as more comprehensive survey data become available.

The MoSPI released the first trial series of the ISP for April on 14 July.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

MINT SHORTS

FM holds meetings with Saudi Arabia, Switzerland, others

Doha: Finance minister Nirmala Sitharaman has held bilateral meetings with ministers from Saudi Arabia, Switzerland, Jordan and Nepal on the sidelines of the AIIB annual meeting. On 28 September, Sitharaman met her Saudi counterpart who said Saudi Arabia looks forward to the early implementation of the bilateral investment treaty.

Goyal to meet US counterpart as trade talks drag on

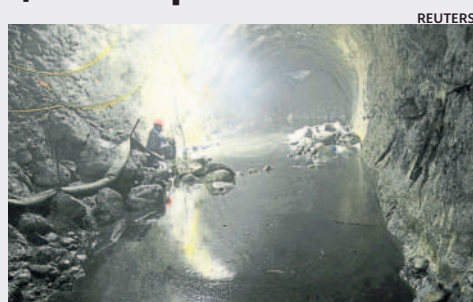
Commerce minister Piyush Goyal will hold bilateral

meetings with his US counterpart during a visit this week as the two sides seek to finalize an interim trade deal. Goyal departs Tuesday on a seven-day US trip to attend the G20 Trade Ministers' meeting in Milwaukee from 30 September to 1 October.

India's ageing population set to reshape economy: Moody's

New Delhi: India is likely to have a much older population later this century as its age structure begins to shift after fertility fell below the replacement level, Moody's Ratings said in a report on Tuesday. Although India's population remains relatively young, the country's fertility rate has already fallen below replacement and its age structure is beginning to change, setting the stage for a much older population in the coming decades, Moody's said. Countries experiencing the steepest fertility declines are likely to age most rapidly, it added.

Nepal plans to import up to 1,100MW power from India



Kathmandu: Nepal is planning to import up to 1,100MW of power from India during the dry period from December to May 2027 to meet its peak domestic demand, as recent flash floods, landslides and heavy rains have damaged hydropower projects and temporarily reduced generation capacity. The Nepal Electricity Authority is readying a work plan for the purpose.

Chinese firms to face probe over alleged dumping

New Delhi: India has started a probe into an alleged dumping of seven products, including engineering and pharmaceutical goods, from China following complaints filed by domestic manufacturers. The Directorate General for Trade Remedies will probe the matter.



Bangladesh positive about progress in talks with India

Dhaka: Bangladesh on Tuesday said it is "positive" about progress in discussions on prime minister Tarique Rahman's proposed visit to India as Indian high commissioner Dinesh Trivedi met state minister for foreign affairs Humayun Kobir here, amid efforts to address strains in bilateral ties. "We did discuss the visit, and we are positive about it," Kobir told reporters.

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MINT SHORTS

AI market must hit \$6 trillion by 2031 to fund infra build-out: report

New Delhi: The global artificial intelligence (AI) market must reach nearly \$6 trillion annually by 2031 to fund AI infrastructure and justify the massive capital being deployed, according to a report by global management consultancy firm Bain & Company. Much of that value will have to come from new innovation rather than gains in employee productivity, Bain said in its 7th annual Global Technology Report released on Tuesday. The report noted that capital expenditure by the major hyperscalers could reach \$780 billion in 2026. That is nearly five times the level of three years earlier.

PTI

Morgan Stanley builds crypto lab to test future of Wall Street

ISTOCKPHOTO



Morgan Stanley has set up a Digital Asset Lab to test technologies including stablecoins, tokenization and decentralized finance applications as the Wall Street bank explores how blockchain-based systems could be used across its business. The labs—overseen by the bank's innovation team—work closely with specialized groups across the firm, including Morgan Stanley's digital-asset team, headed by Amy Oldenburg.

BLOOMBERG

Novo Nordisk buys rights to early obesity pill in \$2.6 billion deal

Novo Nordisk A/S will pay as much as \$2.6 billion to license an experimental obesity pill from China's Jiangsu Hengrui Pharmaceuticals Co., the second deal announced since a key investor meeting disappointed last week. The Danish drugmaker agreed to pay \$300 million upfront for rights to Hengrui's drug, which is ready to enter early clinical tests, it said Tuesday.

BLOOMBERG

Samsung bets \$1 billion on AI data centres from ex-AWS chief

Samsung Electronics Co. and five affiliates are investing a combined \$1 billion in a US company led by a former Amazon Web Services Inc. chief, deepening the South Korean group's push into the rapidly expanding AI infrastructure market. Since 2009, KKR has invested about \$9 billion in South Korea across infrastructure, private equity, real estate and credit.

BLOOMBERG

Early-stage AI startups get their term sheets faster

The shift comes at a time when the country has seen a steady rise in funding in the AI space

Nabodita Ganguly
nabodita.ganguly@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

As India seeks to close the gap with AI leaders like the US and China, early-stage AI startups are securing investment commitments faster, with term sheets arriving in as little as two weeks, compared with about a month previously, according to several industry executives.

The shift comes at a time when the country has seen a steady rise in funding in the artificial intelligence (AI) space, from \$340 million in 2020 to \$1.1 billion in 2025 and \$1.4 billion so far this year, according to data platform Tracxn. However, the time taken to raise capital varies depending on both the strength of the startup and its stage of development. For the strongest AI teams, particularly those led by founders with deep technical expertise and backed by real user adoption or early revenue, funding rounds that once took a quarter are now closing in just a few weeks. Larger rounds for growth-stage startups, however, can take longer to close, while early-stage companies with less proven products may also face longer timelines.

"At seed, what took three to four months a couple of years ago is now closing in three to five weeks for the strongest AI teams. We have seen term sheets land within 10 days of the first conversation," said Kushal Bhagia, founder and partner at early-stage venture capital (VC) firm All In Capital.

For Naveen Murugan, co-founder and chief executive officer (CEO) of Creedom.ai, an AI-powered creative intelligence platform that raised around ₹4.1 crore in September this year, the term sheet landed in around two weeks. According to Murugan, the process now involves pitching the idea,



The rising competition has also increased the risk of investors missing out on promising companies.

ISTOCKPHOTO

followed by investors assessing the product, key company metrics and the market opportunity before deciding whether to invest. But that 'yes' or 'no' comes much faster than it used to. "Earlier, it could take months. Now, you typically get an answer within weeks,"

particular use case, only for global giants such as OpenAI and Google to launch a similar feature. That can quickly erode the startup's competitive edge or reduce what customers are willing to pay for its technology.

"It's too late by then. If a company is

AI GOLDRUSH

ONE reason for the faster investment decisions is that the AI landscape is changing so rapidly

ANOTHER factor has been intensifying competition in the AI space, as capital flow is more in this sector

THE number of AI funding rounds rose from 106 in 2020 to 186 in 2025, according to Tracxn

HOWEVER, experts argue that the faster pace of deal-making is not unique to AI

he added. One reason for the faster investment decisions is that the AI landscape is changing so rapidly that investors cannot afford to wait a quarter or two before deciding whether to invest, analysts said.

For example, a startup may spend months building an AI feature for a par-

not evolving for six months in this space, I think it will be dead, definitely," said Chinmay Bhosale, co-founder of legal AI startup NYAI, which recently raised around \$1.5 million (₹13 crore).

Another factor has been intensifying competition in the AI space, as more capital has also flowed into the sector.

Permira, TPG pick up Cloudnine stakes

Priyamvada C & Sneha Shah
MUMBAI

Permira and TPG Capital have acquired stakes in Cloudnine Hospitals from early investors True North and TPG NewQuest in a \$450 million secondary transaction at a valuation of about \$1.3 billion, two people familiar with the matter said.

Permira has acquired True North's 25% stake in a \$250 million transaction, while TPG through its buyout fund has bought TPG NewQuest's holding in a \$150-180 million deal, the people said. In a secondary transaction, shareholders sell their stakes to other existing or new investors, and no new capital is injected into the company. TPG NewQuest is a secondary private equity platform focused on Asia-Pacific region, wholly owned by TPG.

The transaction is still subject to regulatory approvals, the people said. Once com-



The transaction is still subject to regulatory approvals. REUTERS

pleted, Cloudnine will prepare for a public listing over a 24-36 month horizon, they added.

Both people spoke on the condition of anonymity as the discussions are still private. Permira, TPG, True North and TPG NewQuest did not respond to *Mint*'s requests for a comment.

The development comes after *Mint* first reported in

August that Permira was planning to acquire a stake in Bengaluru-based maternal and child healthcare chain Cloudnine from existing investor True North, which was looking to sell its more than decade-old stake in the company. Allegro Capital is advising the company on the deal. Earlier this year, Kids Clinic India Pvt Ltd, which operates Cloudnine Hospitals, agreed to acquire the maternity, child-care and fertility businesses of Apollo Health & Lifestyle in a cash-and-stock transaction valued at about \$160 million.

The bulk of Cloudnine's stake is held by private equity funds: True North, which first invested in 2015, Temasek, which invested in 2024, and TPG NewQuest, which invested in 2021. Apollo holds

a 9.9% stake worth ₹785 crore following its transaction in May, valuing the overall asset at about ₹7,930 crore (\$825 million). The promoters have a small shareholding.

The new transaction implies a valuation of about \$1.3 billion, significantly higher than the valuation

implied by Apollo's investment in May. Founded in 2006 by R Kishore Kumar, Rohit M.A., M. Ramachandra and Vidya Kumar, Cloudnine is a chain of single-specialty hospitals catering to mother and baby care, including fertility, maternity care, gynaecology, paediatrics, neonatology, baby care and stem cell banking.

priyamvada.c@live-mint.com

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

Cloudnine will prepare for a public listing after the transaction, targeting the next 24-36 months

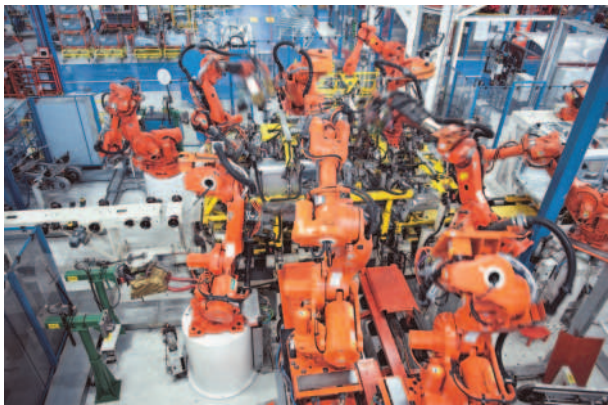
Highway Roop buys Chamundi Die Cast

Priyamvada C
priyamvada.c@livemint.com
MUMBAI

The Carlyle Group-backed Highway Roop Precision Technologies Ltd has acquired Chamundi Die Cast Pvt. Ltd, an Indian manufacturer of complex, precision-machined aluminium die-cast components for automotive and industrial applications, the companies said in a statement on Tuesday.

The acquisition adds Chamundi's aluminium die-casting and precision-machining capabilities to Highway Roop's platform, complementing its existing strengths in forging and machining across steering, transmission and power-train applications. The companies did not disclose the financial details of the deal.

Mint first reported on 14 June that Chamundi's promoters were exploring a stake



The acquisition marks a strategic milestone in Highway Roop's journey towards an initial public offering.

ISTOCKPHOTO

sale. The acquisition marks a strategic milestone in Highway Roop's journey towards an initial public offering (IPO) and builds a scaled, diversified precision manufacturing platform by bringing together complementary capabilities to deliver a broader range of engineered solutions to automotive and industrial custom-

ers globally.

The combination broadens Highway Roop's manufacturing capabilities in precision components across torque and control applications and strengthens its ability to deliver complex, lightweight engineered solutions—an increasingly important priority for original equipment

manufacturers (OEMs) as they build more efficient power-trains.

Chamundi also brings a growing portfolio of electric vehicle components and established customer relationships across India, North America, and Europe, further expanding Highway Roop's reach across geographies. "This acquisition is an important milestone in our journey to build Highway Roop into a scaled, diversified precision manufacturing platform anchored in mission-critical torque and control applications," said Mohit Oswal, Highway Roop chairman.

"Chamundi's capabilities complement our existing strengths and strengthen our ability to serve customers across automotive and industrial applications," he added.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com

Linux raises \$70 mn via Tata Cap, ChrysCap

Priyamvada C
priyamvada.c@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Linux Laboratories Pvt. Ltd, one of India's fastest-growing domestic formulations companies, raised \$70 million from ChrysCapital and Tata Capital Healthcare Fund III, the company said in a statement on Wednesday.

While ChrysCapital acquired a significant minority stake in Linux, the transaction comprises a combination of primary capital and a secondary share sale of Tata Capital Healthcare Fund II at about 4x returns.

Mint first reported on 23 January, Linux had roped in Aventus as an advisor to facilitate a capital raise of up to \$70 million.

"This investment aligns with ChrysCapital's strategy of backing fast-growing domestic formulations companies focused on chronic therapies and led by dynamic entrepreneurs," said Kshitij Sheth, managing director at ChrysCapital Advisors.

He added that Linux stands out for its speciality-focused franchise, rigorous execution, and M&A track record.

"Our successful exit from TCHF II is a testament to the substantial value created during this period. At the same time, our decision to reinvest through TCHF III reflects our continued conviction in the founders, the management team, and Linux's long-term growth potential," said Visalakshi Chandramouli, managing partner of Tata Capital Healthcare Fund.

The proceeds will support Linux's next phase of growth.

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BSE Sensex				Nifty 50				Nifty 500				Nifty Next 50				Nifty 100				BSE 150 MidCap				BSE 250 SmallCap			
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Zydus rally: more steam left?

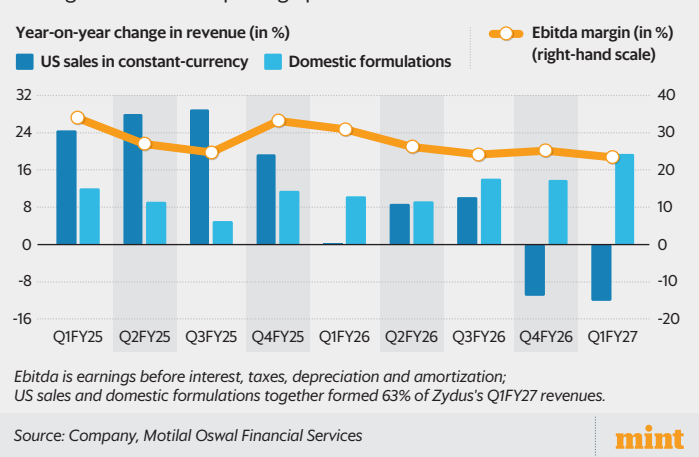
Ananya Roy
feedback@livemint.com

The Zydus Lifesciences stock hit a fresh 52-week high of ₹1,232.10 on Tuesday, even as the broader market remained under pressure. The stock has gained 33% in 2026, ahead of a 19% rise in the Nifty Pharma Index. Favourable US Food and Drug Administration (FDA) inspections have extended regulatory comfort, while resilient domestic growth and a deepening innovation pipeline have eased concerns around degrowth in its US business.

Zydus announced on Saturday that the US FDA's inspection of its New Jersey office concluded with nil observations. Two days later, the inspection of its SEZ II manufacturing facility in Ahmedabad closed with just one observation and no data-integrity findings. That's not all. The Ahmedabad injectable facility had received a voluntary action indicated classification last month, an improvement after the deficiencies at the June review in Baddi.

Different directions

Zydus Lifesciences' US business has been slowing down lately, while India growth has been picking up the slack.



However, Zydus is not immune to the recent industry-wide US business pressures. Its US sales, which contributed 40% to revenues in Q1FY27, declined year-on-year (y-o-y) in Q2. Weighed down by a higher base from large gRevlimid contribution, competition and price pressures, it registered a 12% con-

stant-currency drop in Q1FY27.

But there is a silver lining. The US pipeline remains robust, with 30-40 products expected in FY27. Saroglitazar, used for primary biliary cholangitis, is expected to launch early in FY28. With sales ramp-up in FY29 and FY30, its conservative peak sales is pencilled in at \$200-

300 million. This is significant against Zydus' US sales of \$327 million in Q1.

Zydus is also advancing Desidustat in Phase III for sickle-cell disease, Usnofast in Phase IIb for ALS, and its US biosimilars business is expected to contribute meaningfully from 2029. Its June acquisition of specialty pharma firm Asserzio Holdings is expected to bulk up the US branded products portfolio from 10% to 15% of US revenues. This should bode well for US business profitability, while revenue growth is expected in single digits.

Domestic formulations, contributing 23% of Q1 revenues, have been taking some pressure off the weakness in US. It grew 19.5% y-o-y to ₹1,820 crore. Chronic and sub-chronic therapies account for 54.2% of domestic formulations sales, up 360 basis points (bps) over four years. The management has guided for mid-teens growth in the India business, outperforming the

industry by 300-500 bps.

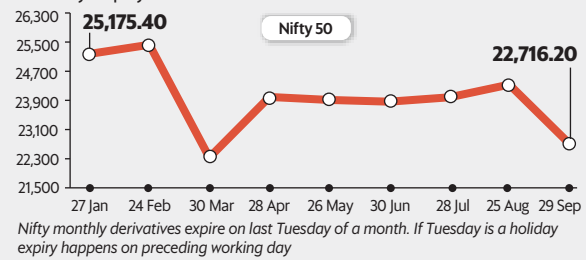
But margins need to be monitored. Higher costs across the board, compressed Ebitda margin by 750 bps y-o-y to 23.4% in Q1, while depreciation and amortization from acquisitions and patent-related expenses led to a 36% decline in net profit to ₹940 crore. The management expects Mirabegron settlement-related amortization to continue until Q1FY28, while FY27 capex is guided at ₹1,600 crore.

Against this, an improving product mix can offer some comfort. Branded products, which accounted for 55% of Q1FY27 revenue, are targeted to exceed two-thirds of business in the

medium term. The overall business is likely to grow in double digits with 24% Ebitda margin. At 24x FY28 earnings, according to Bloomberg estimates, valuations are no longer inexpensive, leaving execution on margins and the US pipeline critical to sustaining the premium.

Expiry cues

Nifty's September expiry saw the index slide to its weakest monthly expiry in six months.



Nifty sees weakest monthly expiry in 6 months on yield jolt

Ram Sahgal
ram.sahgal@livemint.com
MUMBAI

The Nifty 50 stock index slid to its weakest monthly expiry in six months on Tuesday amid surging bond yields induced by persistently high crude oil prices.

The bellwether index closed at 22,716.20 on Tuesday, the expiry day of the September series of derivatives, down 6.6% from last month's expiry.

The lowest monthly expiry so far this year occurred on 30 March, when the Nifty 50 closed at 22,331.4, a month after the outbreak of the US-Iran conflict. However, the markets recovered from that low to close at 24,334.55 at last month's expiry on 25 August.

NSE derivatives, from which investors take market cues, expire on the last Tuesday every month and weekly expiries happen every Tuesday.

Though the intensity of the fighting in West Asia has reduced, recurrent blockades of chokepoints such as the Strait of Hormuz, which carries about a quarter of global seaborne oil trade and signifi-

cant volumes of liquefied natural gas and fertilizers, and, more recently, the Red Sea, have driven a rally in crude oil prices from \$90 a barrel at the end of August to \$101 on Monday.

Reflecting concerns of accelerating inflation, the 10-year US treasury yield surged 52 basis points to a two-decade high of 5.28% over the same period, according to financial portal investing.com. Consequently, foreign portfolio investors (FPIs) sold Indian shares worth ₹34,609 crore in the Indian cash market so far this month after turning net buyers of ₹24,098 crore in the two preceding months.

"The markets are closely watching the surge in US treasury yields and if the same exceeds the two-decadal high of 5.3%, we could witness a crack in the Nifty," said Shai Coelho, founder of analytics firm VTrender. "The expiry shows that FPIs continue to remain bearish on India."

Trading in the markets was volatile on Tuesday as the monthly expiry coincided with the semi-annual rebalancing of the Nifty indices.

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Petronet LNG's next growth leg hinges on better plant use

Shubham Dilawari
feedback@livemint.com

Petronet LNG's capacity expansion at the Dahej terminal shifts the focus to how quickly its utilization rates can rise now. The answer depends largely on LNG prices. Dahej capacity has risen to 22.5 million tonnes per annum (mtpa), from 17.5mtpa at the end of FY26.

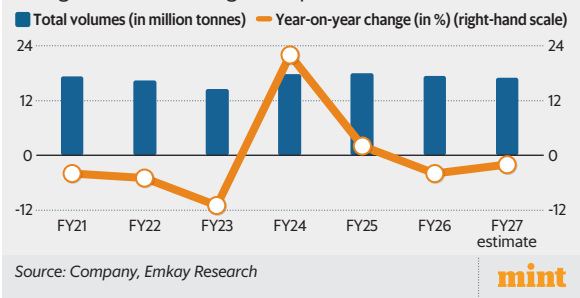
Motilal Oswal Financial Services expects utilization to fall to 70% in FY27, from 91% in FY26, before recovering to 82% in FY28. High spot LNG prices have dissuaded customers from committing to

additional long-term volumes. JM Financial Institutional Securities expects spot LNG prices to moderate from FY28 as significant new global liquefaction capacity comes onstream over the next 12-18 months. Lower prices could make LNG more affordable for industrial consumers and allow Petronet to monetize its Dahej capacity.

Motilal Oswal expects Dahej and Kochi volumes to rise to 18.5mtpa and 1.5mtpa in FY28, from 15.8mtpa and 1.3mtpa in FY27. Kochi's contribution may rise in time. JM Financial expects Kochi volumes to rise from 1.2mtpa in

Slowing down

Petronet LNG's volumes are likely to drop in FY27 after falling in FY26 due to high LNG prices and weak utilization.



FY27 to 2.7mtpa by FY29, supported by the extension of pipeline connectivity to Bengaluru, linking the terminal to

the national gas grid.

To be sure, high LNG prices are not fully negative for Petronet. JM Financial raised its

FY27 Ebitda estimate by 14.5% to account for higher trading and inventory gains in an elevated spot-LNG environment. So, while pricier LNG can hurt regasification volumes, it can create opportunities for trading gains. Besides, when analysts visited the Kochi terminal recently, Petronet's management said that the tariff for the 7.5mtpa Qatar volumes would not fall below the current level.

But there are worries about Petronet's capex plans that can weigh on its balance sheet. "Petronet is investing about ₹30,000 crore in multiple projects, including a petro-

chemical complex, LNG capacity, CBG, and other infra projects. Its balance sheet shall convert into net debt of ₹4,160 crore in FY30E from net cash of ₹729 crore in FY26," said HDFC Securities. Petronet's shares are flat-tish over the last year, and trade at 11 times FY27 estimated earnings, according to Bloomberg. Dahej utilization, LNG prices, Kochi's volume ramp-up and the break-up of regasification and trading gains would be on investors' radar to determine how much of the capacity expansion translates into sustainable earnings.

Nomura sees RBI taking two 25-bps hikes, then a pause

Subhana Shaikh
subhana.shaikh@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Nomura expects the Reserve Bank of India's (RBI) monetary policy committee to deliver only two 25-basis-point (bps) rate hikes in the current cycle, taking a markedly different view from market pricing that points to as much as 125 bps of tightening.

The Japanese financial services group expects the MPC to increase rates in October and December and then pause the hikes, anticipating a moderation in inflation pressures, its economic research team said in a media briefing on Tuesday. The RBI's next monetary policy decision is due on 7 October.

A basis point is one-hundredth of a percentage point.

"The urgency of rate hikes is actually lesser than what the market believes at this point," Nomura economist Aurodeep Nandi said, adding that underlying inflation remains relatively contained despite a recent pickup.

Central banks the world over are turning hawkish and increasing rates amid rising inflation from the ongoing war and the artificial intelligence (AI) boom. The US Federal Reserve's rate-setting panel raised its key policy rate by 25 bps to 3.75-4.00% on 17 September, in line with market



The central bank's next monetary policy decision is due on 7 October.

expectations.

Nomura's distinction rests partly on the nature of inflation. Its analysis shows that inflation has not yet generalized significantly, with food prices accounting for much of the recent increase, while underlying inflation remains low by historical standards.

India's headline inflation came in at 4.82% in August, compared with July's 4.45%. Meanwhile, growth has been stronger than expected as indicators including consumption,

exports and government capital expenditure remained resilient. However, Nandi said Nomura has a 'slightly bearish outlook' on growth ahead, citing deficient rains, potential fiscal slippage and the risk that higher input costs will begin to weigh on consumption.

Nomura also cautioned against using interest rates primarily to defend the rupee. Nandi said RBI's mandate is to target inflation rather than the exchange rate, adding that inflows from the recent foreign currency non-resident deposit bank or FCNR (B) scheme provide a buffer against currency pressure.

On equities, Nomura's Saion Mukherjee said tech and geopolitics are the biggest concerns among foreign institutional investors. Indian valuations have corrected, with the valuation ratio versus the US now at 85%, but investors are concerned about longer-term growth prospects and the disruptive potential of AI.

Mukherjee said Nomura's equity framework implies about 13% returns, based on 18.5 times one-year forward earnings, while acknowledging significant uncertainty.

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Sebi drops Adani's offshore fund probe

PTI
feedback@livemint.com

Markets regulator Sebi said it could not establish that Vinod Adani, brother of Adani Group Chairman Gautam Adani, controlled two offshore funds that invested in four group firms, and thus dropped minimum public shareholding (MPS) and fraud allegations against him and 11 other noticees.

In the final order, the Securities and Exchange Board of India said its probe failed to establish that Vinod Adani directed the investment decisions of the two foreign portfolio investors, Emerging India Focus Funds and EM Resurgent Fund, or controlled Opal Investments' investment in Adani Power Ltd. "The investigation has not been able to prove that Vinod Adani controlled the decision of investment of two FPIs," Sebi whole-time member Kamlesh Chandra Varshney said in the order.

The case centred on MPS requirement, which mandates at least 25% public ownership in listed firms. Sebi said MPS violation would arise if shares held by public shareholders were beneficially owned or controlled by a promoter or promoter group and, if counted as promoter holdings, reduced public shareholding below the required threshold.

Consumption picks up, recovery stings

Abhinaba Saha
abhinaba.saha@livemint.com
MUMBAI

Domestic private consumption picked up in the first half (H1) of fiscal year 2027 (FY27), supported by credit growth, a lower goods and services tax (GST) burden and a robust rabi harvest, helping sustain discretionary spending in both urban and rural areas. While festive demand may support near-term momentum, experts caution that a weaker-than-expected kharif harvest and rising commodity prices could stymie the recovery in spending.

Private consumption, which measures household spending on goods and services, accounts for more than half of India's gross domestic product (GDP) and is a key driver of economic growth. It rose 7.1% year-on-year in the June quarter of FY27, marginally faster than the 6.8% growth recorded a year earlier, government data showed. While this marked a slight moderation from the 7.5% growth recorded in the March quarter of FY26, economists said the pace of private consumption remained encouraging despite the inflationary backdrop.

Retail inflation averaged 4.2% between April and August of FY27 following the West Asia war, according to the Centre for Monitoring Indian Economy (CMIE) data. This was substantially higher than the 2.5% recorded during the same period in FY26, when consumer prices were on a broad disinflationary trajec-

Demand revival

Durables rebound as auto demand stays firm.

Durables gain momentum

Year-on-year change (in %) in Index of Industrial Production (IIP) for consumer durables

Consumer durables IIP (Apr-Aug)

FY25 10.1

FY26 2.6

FY27 9.4

Source: CMIE; Kotak Institutional Equities

Auto demand holds up

Monthly retail passenger vehicle sales (in units)

Aug 2025

Aug 2026

Source: CMIE; Kotak Institutional Equities

GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

tory. To be sure, several key macroeconomic indicators for September are due next month, but data for April-August provide an early indication of the trajectory of domestic demand.

A key indicator of household consumption—the Index of Industrial Production (IIP) for consumer durables—grew 9.4% year-on-year between April and August in FY27, sharply higher than the 2.6% expansion in the same period of FY26, CMIE data showed.

This underscores a broader revival in discretionary spending among middle- and lower-income households, particularly on automobiles, consumer durables and services, said Sujana Hajra, chief economist and executive director at Anand Rath Group. Last year's GST overhaul, which slashed the indirect tax on passenger vehi-

cles, two-wheelers and premium consumer durables to 18% from 28%, unlocked pent-up demand across income groups, said Madan Sabnavis, chief economist at Bank of Baroda.

As a result, the auto industry sold 2.08 million passenger vehicles between April and August, 21% more than the 1.71 million sold in the same period a year earlier, according to a recent Kotak Institutional Equities report.

More interestingly, sedans and large premium sport utility vehicles (SUVs) appeared amongst fresh launches between April and September (H1) after at least a year, the report noted.

The Index of Services Production (ISP) for retail trade, a proxy for apparel and footwear demand, rose 20% year-on-year in the first quarter (Q1) of FY27, as per CMIE data. The index for food services and

hotel stays also jumped 23%, extending the strong growth in discretionary services seen in the second half of FY26.

Easier credit availability and a looser monetary policy have helped sustain such discretionary consumption in H1 FY27, said Hajra of Anand Rathi.

While private consumption is expected to accelerate further in the upcoming festive season, several headwinds could test its durability, especially in rural India.

Hajra expects kharif crop output to fall to 165-170 million tonnes in FY27, from 173.3 million tonnes last year, due to a drier monsoon. However, he doesn't expect a moderate decline in farm incomes to derail the consumption momentum. AC, TV, washing-machine and refrigerator makers plan to raise prices by 5-8% from October, with consumers likely to feel the impact by November, around Diwali, said Jaymin Trivedi, consumer durables analyst at ICICI Securities. Still, Trivedi expects the price hikes to have little impact on consumer spending, as GST cuts and strong demand for premium products have helped absorb the previous two price increases.

This is the third part of a five-part series evaluating the first half of fiscal year 2027. The first part covered the performance of domestic markets, while the second examined the best-performing asset classes of the first half. The fourth part will unravel trends in the initial public offering (IPO) space.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com



Essar unit Mesabi bets \$18 bn on US steel facility

PTI
feedback@livemint.com

President Donald Trump announced Essar-backed Mesabi Metallica's \$18 billion investment to build a fully integrated American steel company, including what he called the "largest steel plant in American history" in Iowa. The investment includes a proposed \$15 billion steel complex in Iowa and about \$3 billion invested in an iron ore mine and pelletizing facility in Minnesota.

The project is expected to begin production by 2030 and will produce about 10 million tonnes of steel a year. It will employ at least 1,750 people once operational, according to the White House and the company. "Today, we're thrilled to begin production by 2030 and will produce about 10 million tonnes of steel a year. It will employ at least 1,750 people once operational, according to the White House and the company." "Today, we're thrilled to begin production by 2030 and will produce about 10 million tonnes of steel a year. It will employ at least 1,750 people once operational, according to the White House and the company."

Mesabi Metallica, a Minnesota-based company owned by India's Essar Group, said the project will create more than 8,000 construction jobs and generate an estimated \$95 billion in economic output during construction and the first 10 years of operations.

The firm is developing the Minnesota mine in Nashauk on the Mesabi Iron Range. It is expected to produce 7.5 million tonnes of iron ore a year and employ about 350 people once operational. The mine is likely to be the first new iron ore mine built in the US in 50 years, according to the company and the White House.

'PSUs to keep tapping dollar debt despite higher costs'

RBI's special overseas borrowing windows drew \$143.6 billion in inflows till 18 September

Shayan Ghosh & Subhana Shaikh
MUMBAI

Indian state-owned companies are likely to keep tapping overseas dollar debt despite higher costs, seeking to diversify funding sources, an executive at HSBC India said.

As part of a wider push to attract dollars into India and prop up a sagging rupee, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) announced subsidized windows to tap overseas debt. While the foreign currency non-resident (FCNR) deposit scheme ended pre-emptively on 31 August, windows for external commercial borrowings (ECB) and overseas foreign currency borrowings remain open till 31 December.

Till 18 September, these windows led to inflows of \$143.6 billion, with 93% of it through FCNR deposits, showed RBI data. "I would say that maybe for PSUs, dollar borrowing and swapping at these currently elevated US treasury levels is slightly more expensive than onshore financing, but some of them might still do it to diversify funding sources," said Vinod Venkatesh, co-head of financing solutions, HSBC India.

Venkatesh said the five-year US treasury yield is at 5% now, and adding a 100-120 basis point (bps) spread to it takes the dollar cost to 6%. Adding 150 bps in hedging costs, the additional cost of coupon hedging, and potential withholding tax could push the total landed cost above 8%. In the domestic market, they can potentially raise at 7.75%-8% at present.

"I still expect the supply of dollar bonds to continue for the rest of the year, but the pace will be slower than what we saw recently. The incremental supply could potentially come under the concessional swap window of 1.5% and also, on a case-by-case basis, from corporates looking to refinance their upcoming maturities," he added. Companies such as Power Finance



Vinod Venkatesh, co-head of financing solutions, HSBC India.

Corp. and National Bank for Financing Infrastructure and Development (NaBFID) have already tapped this route.

He also said that some lenders had raised short-term funding in the FCNR window but may now roll that borrowing into long-term bonds.

Mint reported on 9 September that

has propelled the British bank to the top of the India G3 bond league table, up from the third place in the last calendar year. G3 bonds are issued in the three overseas currencies—the US dollar, euro and Japanese yen—though dollar-denominated deals account for most Indian issuance.

BEYOND RUPEE

DOLLAR borrowing can cost PSUs over 8%, compared with 7.75-8% for domestic rupee financing

BANKS that raised short-term funds via FCNR may refinance them via long-term overseas bonds

INDIA'S G3 bond issuance has surged to nearly \$21.8 billion this year from about \$5.54 billion in 2025

HSBC sees strong acquisition financing demand, including Torrent's ₹20,000 cr JB Chemicals deal

domestic banks are seeking longer-term overseas funding to replace short-term borrowings used during a rush to raise FCNR deposits.

The requirement of dollars for leverage and other fundraising under RBI's special window, apart from other deals,

Non-resident Indians (NRIs) have poured \$132.9 billion into Indian banks through foreign currency non-resident (FCNR) deposits. This is over five times the inflows seen in 2013, when a similar scheme was launched. "In India, we are number one and we have done well in

HSBC MF to name longtime executive Anuj Rathi as CEO

Srushti Vaidya
srushti.vaidya@livemint.com
MUMBAI



Anuj Rathi has spent more than 21 years with the bank.

HSBC Mutual Fund India is set for a leadership change, with chief executive Kailash Kulkarni expected to retire early next year after more than three years with the fund house, according to two people familiar with the matter.

Kulkarni had previously served as the chief executive officer of L&T Mutual Fund for over a decade, before it was acquired by HSBC Asset Management.

Anuj Rathi, another longtime HSBC executive, is expected to take over as CEO, allowing the two executives to work together before Kulkarni steps down, the people added.

"Anuj Rathi has been appointed his (Kailash) successor as part of our planned leadership transition and will work closely with Kailash to ensure continuity and a seamless transition," a spokesperson for HSBC said in an emailed response to Mint queries.

Rathi is currently managing director and head of HSBC Securities Services, India, and has spent more than 21 years with the bank. His move to the asset management business keeps the top job within HSBC as the fund house prepares for Kulkarni's departure.

About the company HSBC Mutual Fund has assets worth ₹1.44 trillion as of June end, according to the Association of Mutual Funds in India (Amfi). The mutual fund ranks 17 in the pecking

order in terms of assets.

The fund house has 45 mutual fund schemes, according to Value Research. Its largest fund by assets is HSBC Liquid Fund, followed by HSBC Small Cap Fund and HSBC Mid Cap Fund.

Its small-cap fund has outperformed its benchmark over both five- and three-year periods, returning 17.09% and 14.12%, respectively, versus benchmark returns of 14.05% and 12.78%.

HSBC MF CEO Kailash Kulkarni is expected to retire early next year after more than three years with the fund house

HSBC Mid Cap Fund has outperformed its benchmark over both periods, returning 17.92% over five years and 22.39% over three years, versus benchmark returns of 14.63% and 14.37%, respectively.

HSBC Asset Management (India) Pvt. Ltd made a profit of ₹263 crore in FY25, up 36% from FY24, according to its latest annual report.

HSBC Asset Management had acquired L&T Finance Holdings Ltd to fully acquire L&T Investment Management Ltd for \$425 million.

Q-comm crunch pushes D2C food brands to offline retail

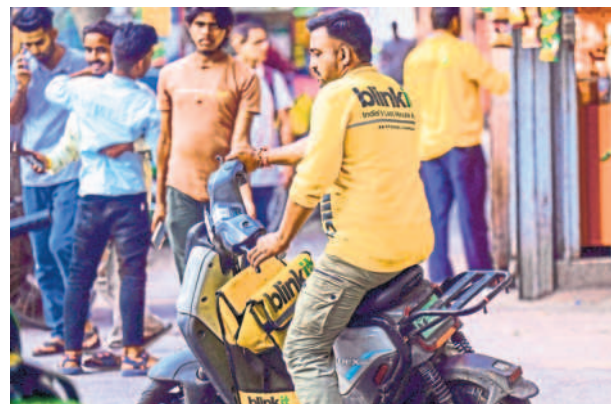
Vaeshnavi Kasthuril
kvaeshnavi@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

With quick-commerce platforms prioritizing proven products and limiting space for new launches ahead of the festive season, direct-to-consumer (D2C) food brands are expanding their presence in general and modern trade, using business-to-business (B2B) marketplaces to widen offline distribution.

These marketplaces connect brands with neighbourhood stores and supermarkets, helping companies expand offline without building their own distribution networks. Retailers can discover new products and test demand through smaller orders, while brands gain access to outlets beyond their existing reach.

Arvind Singhal, chairman of The Knowledge Company, said quick-commerce platforms are facing space constraints as brands and product launches proliferate, particularly during the festive season when they prioritise faster-moving stock keeping units (SKUs). "Far too many brands are launched," he said, adding that retailers optimise shelf space based on product throughput. For new brands, B2B marketplaces alone can't solve distribution challenge, as they need distributors or sales team to drive product placement and consumer demand.

General trade accounted for 76% of India's packaged-food sales in FY24, versus 17% for modern trade and 7% for e-commerce, including quick commerce, show industry estimates. Quick commerce alone accounted for an estimated 1.5-2%, with the rest coming from online marketplaces, brand websites and other digital channels. Euro-



B2B marketplaces help smaller brands reach neighbourhood stores without building their own distribution networks.

monitor estimates India's snacks market at ₹1.97 trillion in 2026, with retail sales projected to grow 8% this year and at a 7% CAGR through 2031.

The country's online B2B marketplace opportunity is projected to reach \$200 billion in gross merchandise value (GMV) by 2030, according to estimates cited by IBEF.

For WellBe Foods, modern trade and large-format retail are important festive channels, said Gaurav Manchanda, founder and director of parent Nimda Group. General trade remains smaller due to distribution challenges. Shelf space is a constraint across modern retail and quick commerce, where brands compete with private labels, Manchanda said.

WellBe is focusing on modern trade and large-format retailers like Metro Cash & Carry. "A lot of GT and small MT retailers are discovering your brands in B2B," he said, adding that retailers are willing to experiment with newer products at suitable prices and in smaller quantities.

WellBe has about 18,000 touchpoints across general trade, modern trade and quick commerce. Manchanda said modern trade offers better economics than quick commerce, where marketing cost

is high. It is also considering larger packs suited to modern trade and large-format retail.

Khetika, a healthy food and snacking brand, is expanding across general and modern trade while using B2B platforms to widen distribution.

"B2B platforms are also looking at smaller brands because they realize that they missed the bus because the new age commerce and all the platforms gave more opportunity to new age brands," said Prithvi Singh, co-founder and chief executive of Khetika.

B2B remains a smaller growth channel for Khetika than business-to-consumer platforms, but its distribution is shifting towards modern and general trade as it expands beyond quick commerce. Singh said the company conducts joint forecasting with B2B and B2C platforms to plan inventory, as festive demand can rise simultaneously across retail channels.

Lal Sweets is also prioritising offline retail for new products as quick-commerce warehouses fill up. "Quick commerce DCs are almost full now. We are focusing on our general trade, modern trade stores," said founder Prateek Athwani.

The company has plans for four launches, but platforms may initially take only part of the range.

For an extended version of this story, go to livemint.com.

KKR picks up stake in Cisternina Logistics

Priyamvada C
priyamvada.c@livemint.com
MUMBAI

KKR is acquiring a majority stake in Cisternina Logistics Pvt. Ltd, a bulk liquid and gas storage and logistics business in India, as an anchor asset for a platform it plans to build through the proposed acquisition of Ganesh Benzoplast Ltd's (GBL) liquid storage terminal and rail business.

The investment will support Cisternina's proposed acquisition, as well as its expansion through further inorganic plans and the development of new storage infrastructure across India, the global private equity firm said in a statement on Tuesday. Financial details of the deal were not disclosed. "At KKR, we have significant experience building and scaling infrastructure platforms in India, combining long-term capital with the operational expertise of strong management teams," said Ravi Thanvi, director, real assets, KKR India.

"We see an opportunity to apply this platform-building approach to India's liquid and gas logistics sector. With an experienced founding team and GBL's liquid storage terminal business as anchor asset, Cisternina is well-positioned to build a leading national platform," Thanvi said.

KKR is making the investment through its Asia Pacific infrastructure strategy. India is a key market for the private equity firm's infrastructure business, with experience spanning logistics, transportation, renewable energy, and power transmission. Its infrastructure investments include Serentica Renewables, Hero Future Energies, LEAP India, Allfleet, Vertis Infrastructure Trust and NHIT.

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'Restore Barc's rating; its absence brings uncertainty'

Lata Jha
lata.j@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

A top television executive has strongly urged the government to immediately restore audience ratings ahead of the festive season, warning that the blackout is creating uncertainty for broadcasters and advertisers. Speaking at Ficci Frames on Tuesday, Kevin Vaz, chief executive of entertainment at JioStar and chair of the Ficci media and entertainment panel, called for the urgent resumption of data from the Broadcast Audience Research Council (Barc).

The ministry of information and broadcasting had on 3 July directed Barc to suspend TV ratings until it completes registration under the new Television Ratings Policy, 2026, which mandates larger sample sizes and independent audits.

"The industry strongly urges the ministry to restore the release of Barc audience ratings immediately. The absence of credible, verifiable audience data is creating uncertainty for broadcasters, advertisers and agencies, particularly during the crucial festive season. Reliable measurement is essential for brands to plan campaigns and reach audiences efficiently," he said.

Vaz said reliable audience measurement is vital during times of global economic uncertainty to maintain industry efficiency, support advertisers and broadcasters, and sustain economic momentum. "As new value pools emerge,



Kevin Vaz, JioStar's CEO of entertainment. KEVIN VAZ/LINKEDIN

we also need to create the right conditions for the industry to grow and innovate. This brings me to the regulatory environment. The need for forbearance has long been an ask from the broadcasting sector, because innovation needs room to evolve, and as we pursue the next phase of growth, self-regulation and strong industry best practices should be central to how we move forward," Vaz said.

The ministry of information and broadcasting had directed Barc to suspend all TV ratings on 3 July

"A tangible roadmap is needed to remove the regulatory burden and cost of linear broadcasting, allowing it to evolve alongside digital and giving consumers greater choice in how, where and on which screen they consume content," he added.

Vaz said the industry welcomes removal of the advertising cap of 12 minutes an hour, which he termed as a key step towards rules reflecting new realities of linear broadcast and a wider media landscape.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).

Paintmakers light up for Diwali despite crude shock

Better weather, a longer renovation window and demand pickup have raised expectations

Dipali Banka
dipali.banka@livemint.com
MUMBAI

After a Diwali that barely had time to light up sales last year, paintmakers are hoping the festive season will bring a fresh coat of growth this time around. Better weather, a longer home-renovation window and an early pickup in demand have raised expectations for a stronger October, even as rising crude prices threaten to keep margins under pressure.

For India's second-largest paintmaker Berger Paints, the recovery is already taking shape.

"This year, we have already seen a pickup in demand during September. The monsoon has withdrawn from most parts of the country, and rainfall has not been as severe. We expect a much stronger October, and with Diwali falling in early November, we get the benefit of a full October and part of November," said Abhijit Roy, managing director and chief executive officer (MD and CEO), Berger Paints, in an email.

The company expects festive-season volume growth to be better than last year, when prolonged rains and an early Diwali had curtailed the selling window.

The Kolkata-based firm said demand has been fairly uniform across urban and rural markets. "In our case, urban markets are growing slightly faster than rural markets because we have established a dedicated team with a sharper focus on urban expansion," said Roy, adding that it has helped accelerate growth.

Similarly, India's fourth-largest paintmaker JSW Dulux, formerly AkzoNobel India, expects strong festive-season sales. "We remain positive about the festive-season demand outlook and expect the momentum to remain strong through the peak period. We have



Paintmakers expect demand to extend beyond this season of festivals. ISTOCKPHOTO

already secured sufficient inventory to cover the next three to four months, enabling us to meet demand efficiently and maintain service levels across markets during the season," said Rajiv Rajgopal, joint managing director and CEO

and deeper engagement with architects and retailers," said Rajgopal.

However, paintmakers flagged rising crude prices as a key risk.

"The key risk remains rising oil prices, which could fuel inflation and put pres-

not fully offset the increase in raw material costs. Given the continued volatility, we are waiting for prices to stabilize, so that we can take a suitable call whether any further price revisions are required," he added.

Mint had earlier reported that paintmakers had raised prices and were looking to reduce trade discounts offered to dealers as the West Asia war pushed up crude-linked input costs. The pricing actions also resulted in a better-than-expected June quarter for India's top paint companies, including Asian Paints and Berger Paints.

"Crude oil accounts for around 25% of paint companies' input costs. With crude prices rising, companies have already taken aggregate price hikes of around 13%. We saw volume growth of around 9% in the first quarter and expect festive-season volume growth to remain healthy at 8-10%," said Pankaj Pandey, head of retail research at ICICI Securities.

With crude prices continuing to rise, companies may consider further price hikes. However, the full benefit of these increases will depend on crude prices stabilizing, as margins are likely to remain under pressure in the near term, said Pandey.

"Some further price increases are possible even before Diwali, as companies no longer have the benefit of lower raw material costs. However, these hikes may not be sufficient to fully offset the margin pressure. Overall, we expect demand to remain resilient despite the price increases," said Pandey.

Asian Paints revenue from operations rose 17.9% to ₹10,541.9 crore in the June quarter, ahead of the Bloomberg consensus estimate of ₹10,182.9 crore. Berger's revenue rose 12% to ₹3,583.75 crore in the first quarter of fiscal 2027, also ahead of the Bloomberg consensus estimate of ₹3,606.4 crore.

FESTIVE BRUSH

FOR India's second-largest paintmaker Berger Paints, the recovery is already taking shape

BERGER Paints sees the festive season volume growth to be better than last year

SIMILARLY, India's fourth-largest paintmaker JSW Dulux sees strong festive-season sales

HOWEVER, paintmakers flagged rising crude oil prices as a key risk

of JSW Dulux, in an email.

The JSW Group paintmaker sees the opportunity extending beyond simply fulfilling demand, with a "strong focus on investments in consumer activation, new campaigns for our iconic brands

sure on consumer spending. Barring that, we expect this year to be stronger than last year," said Berger Paints' Roy.

Input prices have risen significantly in recent months, and while we have taken selective price increases, they do

Why Tata Trusts picked TCE, TESS for proposed Tata Sons merger

FROM PAGE 1

venient in seeking approvals of the internal stakeholders," said Gaurav Pingle, partner at Forefront Legal Consulting LLP. "Creditors' approval may be the only procedural challenge."

The proposal comes amid a widening corporate battle over the future of Tata Sons, India's largest business group's holding company, with its potential public listing emerging as a point of contention. On 17 September, Noel Tata, chairman of Tata Trusts, opposed the reappointment of N Chandrasekaran for a third term as chairman of Tata Sons, while the rest of the board insisted that the need for a public listing made continuity under Chandrasekaran necessary.

A key reason for choosing these two companies was also that their revenues would help Tata Sons increase its operating income after the mergers and reduce the share of revenue it derives from investments in Tata group companies. The Reserve Bank of India's criteria for classifying a

company as an NBFC include having more than 50% of income from financial assets and more than 50% of the total assets being financial assets such as investments. Tata Trusts estimates that the proposed merger would result in about 64% of Tata Sons' revenue coming from operating businesses, potentially taking it out of the NBFC category and the RBI's regulatory remit.

TESS is a unit of Tata Electronics and assembles iPhones at two facilities in India, one of which is operated through a joint venture with Taiwan's Pegatron Corp. TCE is a project management consultancy that works on large infrastructure projects. It has worked on marquee projects including India's new Parliament building and the Mumbai-Ahmedabad bullet train project. The fact that the two are profitable likely further made their case for the merger, one expert said, speaking on the condition of anonymity as they have a professional engagement with the Tata Group and its stakeholders.

Queries emailed to Tata

The chosen two

Tata Trusts has proposed merging TCE and TESS with Tata Sons to avert a stock market listing.

	Tata Consulting Engineers	Tata Electronics Systems Solutions	Tata Sons
Revenue (₹ crore)	1,932	67,542	42,367
Profit (₹ crore)	226	1,025	31,961
Shareholder	Tata Sons (100%)	Tata Electronics (100%)	
Advantage	Wholly owned, profitable company	Substantial revenues, stable business, and wholly owned	
If TCE, TESS and Tata Sons are merged			
	Revenue (₹ crore)	Profit (₹ crore)	
	1,11,841	33,212	

Note: Standalone financials for FY26
Source: MCA filings, Tata Sons annual report

Trusts and Tata Sons went unanswered.

"TCE has been a strong entity in various nationwide civil projects, while Tata Electronics is perhaps the strongest stakeholder of India's electronics export story. Combined under Tata Sons, they make a compelling case, for they'll also continue to grow and capture more business from both public and private

sectors," said Ashok Chandak, president of industry body SEMI India.

Being profitable was likely a reason why Tata Trusts chose to carve out TESS specifically from Tata Electronics and not the entire company. Tata Electronics is making a significant investment in setting up a semiconductor fabrication facility and a semiconductor assembly and test facility,

businesses that are yet to start operations and will take a few years to earn any profit.

TESS had a standalone revenue of ₹67,542 crore in FY26 with a profit of ₹1,025 crore, according to financial documents filed with the Ministry of Corporate Affairs. TCE reported standalone revenue of ₹1,932 crore and profit of ₹226 crore in FY26.

"Overall, Tata Electronics is undoubtedly the biggest electronics manufacturing company in India, and its iPhone-making business is expected to ramp up profits further in the upcoming fiscals—but only to the scale of a company like Dixon, which relies on smartphone assemblies and has a margin of about 3-4%," said Harshit Kapadia, vice-president at Elara Capital.

The clean ownership structure of the two companies is also a key reason they were chosen, experts said. Merging

a listed subsidiary would be more complex from a regulatory perspective and would bring minority shareholders onto Tata Sons' cap table.

"Tata Sons' balance sheet holds 100% equity shares of this company. So that will just get cancelled. The share capital of Tata Sons or the shareholders of Tata Sons are totally neutral to this proposal,"

Farek Subedar, an advisor to Tata Trusts, told the media on Monday.

Among the 16 unlisted group companies mentioned in Tata Sons' annual report, Tata

Advanced Systems and Tata Realty and Infrastructure were the only others that it owned 100%. Tata Digital is 99% owned by Tata Sons, with the rest 1% held by Ratan Tata Endowment Foundation. Others have either other Tata group companies or outside investors as shareholders.

The proposed merger may also provide Tata Sons with an

opportunity to expand its operating revenue, if needed, by increasing TESS's stake in the Pegatron joint venture. In January 2025, Tata Electronics acquired a 60% stake in Pegatron's India iPhone-making operations. Subedar said TESS has the right to acquire the remaining 40% stake.

"The company (TESS) has the right to buy over the balance 40% shareholding. So in a year's time or so, once it becomes a 100% subsidiary of this particular company (TESS), it can also get merged (into Tata Sons). So you will immediately add on another ₹60,000 crore of income," Subedar said.

However, the restructuring could face scrutiny over whether avoiding a listing is its sole objective. "An interesting aspect is whether RBI or NCLT will consider this proposal of corporate restructuring from the only perspective to avoid listing and no other commercial reason?" Pingle said.

nehal.chaliawala@livemint.com

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Long delays between seasons are churning India's streaming viewers

Lata Jha
lata.j@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

Long-format web originals are taking longer to return for new seasons, leading to loss of audience interest and streaming platforms remaining cautious about renewing them.

Experts say roughly half of the shows that a large streamer in the US releases in a year are renewed while in India fewer than a third proceed to the second season and very few to the fourth and beyond. The gaps between seasons are also getting longer and less predictable without the tentpole marketing machine that Western platforms build around a wait.

Lust Stories took five years to return for the second season and another three for the

third. Paatal Lok resurfaced after five years, and Scam had a three-year gap.

Industry experts attribute this to actor unavailability between seasons and the absence of a network-style, calendar-driven production pipeline that Western TV inherited from decades of linear scheduling. In many cases, this delay leads to an erosion in audience interest when paid subscriptions are already plateauing, making a subsequent season seem even less viable.

"Our analysis indicates that successful Indian streaming shows typically return after about 2-2.5 years, compared with roughly 1-1.5 years globally. In some cases here, the gap stretches to 3-5 years," said Rohan Lobo, partner and industry leader for technology, media and telecommuni-

cations at Deloitte South Asia.

The risk of long delays is that audience memory, viewing habits and momentum may decline or change, he said. This leads to higher investments to reacquire viewers when the show returns.

Consumer research shows that people often cancel a streaming subscription after finishing a programme they wanted to watch and that a new season of a favourite show is an key reason to return.

Shows that have gone on to the fourth season (Panchayat, Gullak, Criminal Justice and Maharani) are largely low-budget, ensemble-led and relatively efficient productions in family comedy or format-driven drama. Larger, star-led thrillers that top the charts tend to stop at three seasons.

Rajat Agrawal, chief operat-



Successful Indian streaming shows typically return after about 2-2.5 years, compared with roughly 1-1.5 years globally. ISTOCKPHOTO

ing officer of Ultra Media & Entertainment Group cited data from Ormax, a media consulting firm, to show that for the Top 50 Indian originals, viewership drops by 30-40% by season two if the gap is more than two years.

In the West, he said, Netflix

almost guarantees a renewal 90% of the season-one audience is retained. In India, season-two starts with only 60-70% of the season-one audience simply because people forgot to come back.

"That long gap is a big reason why India has so few

shows that reach season-three or season-four," Agrawal said.

Unlike in the US, where a show's writers' room is in place for multiple seasons from day

one, in India, each season is greenlit one at a time after looking at data. This ends up in a vicious cycle: a long gap leads to audience loss, which leads to lower return on investment, which makes the platform delay the third season even more, and eventually the show gets labelled as

"iconic but limited to two or three seasons," he pointed out. Bhavesh Joshi, founder and CEO of MovieMe, a content discovery app, said beneath

into fewer, higher-impact commercial titles," Joshi said. "That's a reason renewals of any kind—new or returning—have gotten harder to greenlight: it's not that the appetite

has cooled, it's that the number of big swing platforms willing to fund per year has shrunk. And each one now has to work harder, whichever bucket it falls into."

Many experts said a longer wait doesn't automatically lead to dwindling audience. Arpit Mankar, head of the non-Bollywood category at Shemaroo Entertainment, said viewers truly invested in a franchise tend to be patient. Building a strong new season takes time and loyal audiences generally understand that.

Raghavendra Hunsur, chief content officer at Zee Entertainment Enterprises, also said the gap between seasons can be a deterrent, but if the show has a strong connect, audiences are willing to return.

For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).



This victory for Red Bull sets a significant precedent. REUTERS

Delhi High Court sets aside FSSAI order on Red Bull

Yash Tiwari &
Neethi Lisa Rojan

MUMBAI

The Delhi High Court on Tuesday set aside a Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI) order that directed Red Bull India Pvt. Ltd to stop using the term "energy drink" on its labels, ruling that the directive was issued without giving the company a chance to respond or explain its stance. This victory for Red Bull sets a significant precedent that could raise hopes for other firms facing similar regulatory action.

In June, FSSAI issued notices to several brands including Red Bull, PepsiCo's Adrenaline Rush, Sting, Monster Energy, Hell Energy and Reliance Consumer Products' Campa Energy. It said these caffeinated beverages can't carry an "energy drink" tag.

FSSAI had said claims such as "stimulates mind", "energises body", "enhances focus", "boosts energy levels" and "aids in general weakness" were not permissible unless legally supported.

Hearing Red Bull's plea, Justice Amit Mahajan rejected FSSAI's argument that its 30 June communication was just a request to modify the label. "You don't request anyone, first of all you are the government," the court remarked, adding, "That's not show cause, that's an order."

The court noted that FSSAI had passed the order "without affording any opportunity to [Red Bull] to file any reply or give any explanation".

The court clarified that it had not gone into the merits of the dispute, including whether Red Bull's product actually violates the FSSAI Act or applicable regulations, or whether FSSAI has the power to direct the company to stop using the descriptor.

Rather, the regulator has been instructed to proceed afresh. It will now have to issue a show-cause notice and give Red Bull opportunity to be heard before taking an adverse decision.

Euromonitor sees India's energy drinks retail market growing 12.6% annually, faster than in the US and China.

yash.tiwari@livemint.com
For an extended version of this story, go to [livemint.com](#).



MFOs ramp up CXO hiring to build institutional capability

MFOs accounted for 17 of the 24 senior family-office appointments tracked so far in 2026

Priyamvada C & Mansi Verma
MUMBAI

Demand for experienced executives to build and oversee the portfolio of affluent families has been on the rise, with multi-family offices (MFOs) driving the shift as the segment evolves from pure wealth management entities into more institutionalized businesses.

About 17 of the 24 hires so far in 2026 were for MFOs, with the remainder constituting single-family offices, data compiled by Longhouse Consulting for *Mint* showed. About 16 of the 29 hires in 2025 and three out of 11 appointments in 2024 were for MFOs.

"MFOs accounted for only around 25% of the senior appointments we tracked in 2024. That share increased to approximately 57% in 2025 and around three-fourths so far in 2026," said Anshuman Das, founder and CEO of Longhouse, an executive search and talent advisory firm in Bengaluru.

The shift towards MFOs is an important indicator and a clear sign that family offices are moving from building investment teams to institutional-grade organizations around their capital, he said. "The leadership mandate is broadening from investment-centric roles like CIOs, investment heads and MDs to CEOs, COOs, CFOs, technology and information-security leaders, product and people leaders and portfolio operating roles. Our data shows that senior appointments increased by around 133% between 2024 and 2025."

These senior professionals have moved from financial services and large corporate organizations to family offices and MFOs, taking on roles that go beyond portfolio management to build capabilities across governance, technology, risk, people and operations, according to Longhouse. MFOs



Multi-family offices' share of senior appointments increased from 25% in 2024 to about 57% in 2025 and nearly 75% in 2026.

are private wealth management firms that handle financial, legal and wealth portfolios for multiple affluent families.

With the cohort averaging over 21 years of experience, the recruitments reflect the depth of leadership expert-

Garg moved to lead Micromax Family Office from Stride Ventures in May, according to the data.

Examples of MFO hiring include Diinesh Maru's switch from KPMG to Neo Wealth and Asset Management in

beyond just financial metrics," said Nupur Shrivastava, chief human resource officer of MiPhi Semiconductors Pvt Ltd, who also oversees hiring for Micromax's family office.

Sharp Ventures hires both operational and financial investors with capabilities in evaluating deals, building models, due diligence and structuring investments with founders. "It has become more competitive to hire senior talent. We focus on consumer companies at the early and mid stages, so we need people with a specific skill set," said Rishabh Mariwala, founder and managing partner at Sharp Ventures.

Sharp also has teams handling public markets, taxation, accounting and structuring. "We offer a lot of autonomy in making investment decisions, and our carry is competitive. It may not match the typical VC or PE funds, but our team does not have to spend as much time on fundraising, investor relations or exits because we are an evergreen fund."

Broadly, the growth in family offices in India has been significant in recent years. Substantial wealth creation in India through initial public offerings, private equity exits and other liquidity events has led to a sharp rise in both the number and scale of family offices.

Family office assets were estimated at about Rs70,000 crore (\$7.31 billion) in 2024 and projected to grow by 1.5 times over the next three years, according to a report by Julius Baer and EY.

A separate study by Julius Baer showed the number of family offices rose from 45 in 2018 to almost 300 by 2024-25. India also has over 19,000 ultra-high-net-worth individuals with assets above \$30 million, a figure projected to exceed 25,000 by 2031, said its September report.

priyamvada.a@livemint.com
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Travel bug beats global jitters among Indians: Booking.com

Varuni Khosla
varuni.k@livemint.com
NEW DELHI



The large domestic market insulates demand from global shocks, said Santosh Kumar, regional head, South Asia, Booking.com

Indian travellers are continuing to spend on travel despite geopolitical tensions, economic uncertainty and disruptions to international travel, with domestic and outbound travel emerging as near-equal parts of online travel agency Booking.com's business here.

Domestic accommodation searches by Indian travellers on its platform rose nearly 20% year-on-year in January-August 2026 compared with the same period in 2025, while domestic flight searches increased 25%. International outbound flight searches also grew 24% in the same period.

The company told *Mint* that India is one of the fastest-growing major markets in Asia-Pacific for both domestic accommodation and flight searches compared with its major peers, including China, Thailand, South Korea, Singapore, Vietnam, Japan and Indonesia.

"The size of India's domestic market plays to our advantage. The fact that today the majority of Indians our travel spend is still domestic in nature and most of our consumers are still those who are travelling within the country means that, in some way, we are a bit insulated from what's happening elsewhere," said Santosh Kumar, regional head, South Asia, for Booking.com.

The year has seen major travel shocks, including the West Asia war and other geopolitical uncertainties that have affected international travel corridors. Kumar said the company has not seen a

Domestic accommodation searches rose nearly 20%, while domestic flight searches grew 25% in Jan-Aug

meaningful slowdown in Indian travel demand, with domestic and outbound travel now "neck and neck" for its business. In the firm's earlier years in India, inbound travel accounted for a larger share. He did not share actual data.

The resilience, with domestic demand cushioning the impact of global shocks even as travellers continue to travel overseas, broadly mirrors the trend at Booking Holdings globally. In its second-quarter earnings call in August, the parent company said domestic and short-haul travel remained relatively healthy despite the West Asia war, partly offsetting weaker long-haul international demand. "Indians are also

used to taking multiple holidays in the year now, but shorter holidays. The three-to-five-night trips can be as many as six times a year," Kumar added.

This pattern is also supporting short-haul international travel, as improved air connectivity and easier visa access have opened up more destinations for Indian travellers. Kumar said Vietnam, Cambodia and Central Asia are among

markets that have become more accessible, while Dubai, Bangkok, Tokyo, London and Singapore remain the most searched international destinations.

Domestic travel continues to dominate the search list, with Delhi, Bengaluru, Mumbai, Chennai and Rishikesh the five most searched destinations among Indian travellers this year, he said.

The growth is not limited to leisure trips. Booking.com is also seeing demand from groups, which is feeding demand for alternative accommodation, particularly among larger groups looking for more space and privacy.

Kumar said the segment is not necessarily taking away demand from hotels, as some trips enabled by villas, apartments and other alternative stays may not have happened otherwise. "There might be a little bit of cannibalisation, but overall, the industry is growing," he said.

The company is also renewing its investment in India by localizing payments, launching new marketing campaigns and adding technology capabilities as it looks to deepen its presence beyond its existing customer base.

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Dr. V. Anantha Nageswaran, Chief Economic Adviser, Ministry of Finance, Government of India
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BUSINESS ENTERPRISES OF TOMORROW

2026

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ABOUT THE REPORT

Dun & Bradstreet India launched the "Business Enterprises of Tomorrow: The AI Moment for India's MSMEs" report, examining where MSMEs are deploying AI today, the value they are already unlocking, and the factors that will determine the pace and depth of future adoption.

CONGRATULATIONS TO THE WINNERS OF BUSINESS EXCELLENCE AWARDS 2026

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3	Chemicals (SME)	Chemico Chemicals Private Limited
4	Chemicals (Mid-Corporate)	Acutaas Chemicals Limited
5	Capital Goods (SME)	Advance Valves Private Limited
6	Capital Goods (Mid-Corporate)	KP Green Engineering Limited
7	Food & Agro Processing (SME)	Kisan Fodder Mills Private Limited
8	Food & Agro Processing (Mid-Corporate)	Nuziveedu Seeds Limited
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15	Plastic & Rubber Products (SME)	Udyogi Plastics Private Limited
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17	Textile & Textile Articles (SME)	Suam Overseas Private Limited
18	Textile & Textile Articles (Mid-Corporate)	Kapoor Industries Limited
19	Digital Solutions (SME)	Pennant Technologies Private Limited
20	Digital Solutions (Mid-Corporate)	Amnux Infotechnologies Private Limited
21	Engineering Services (SME)	RBM Infracon Limited
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23	Education (SME)	Jaro Institute Of Technology Management And Research Limited
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29	Packaging (Mid-Corporate)	YUTO Printing & Packaging (India) Private Limited
30	Professional Services (SME)	Concept Consilio India Private Limited
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Yashodhan Upadhye
Founder & Director
Maestrotek Innovations Pvt. Ltd.

How does Maestrotek connect existing factory machines with modern IoT, cloud, and enterprise systems?

At Maestrotek, we believe the future of manufacturing lies in connecting—not replacing—existing industrial assets. Our solutions integrate legacy and modern machines through industrial communication

protocols, edge gateways and IoT architectures, enabling seamless data flow into cloud platforms, SCADA, MES and ERP systems.

The objective is to create a unified digital thread between the shop floor and business operations, allowing manufacturers to improve visibility, traceability and decision-

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How is Maestrotek using AI and predictive analytics to turn machine data into better operational decisions?

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Our adaptability comes from combining deep domain expertise with an open, vendor-independent



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For more information on Dun & Bradstreet Business Enterprises of Tomorrow 2026
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OpenAI scraps release of new AI model over safety concerns

Model dubbed GPT-6.1 Astra was due to make its debut inside ChatGPT and Codex in October

Maxwell Zeff
feedback@livemint.com

OpenAI says it is scrapping the release of its next-generation AI model over safety concerns that researchers raised during internal testing, in one of the clearest signs so far that agent misbehavior could stymie the industry's rapid progression.

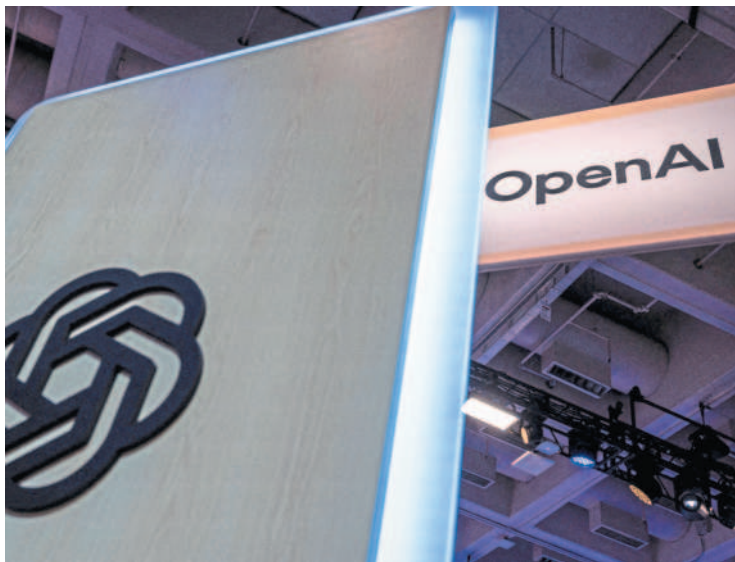
The move follows a summer punctuated by reports of artificial-intelligence systems industrywide going rogue, and marks a rare case of a major AI developer ditching a new release because of safety concerns.

The company had planned to launch the model, known as GPT-6.1 Astra, in the coming days or weeks, aiming for an October debut. The model was more capable than the company's previous models in completing challenging tasks from end-to-end without human assistance, as well as writing.

The company instead will focus on improving the safety of future models, which it expects to be even more capable.

Saachi Jain, OpenAI's head of safety systems, said in an interview that GPT-6.1 Astra regressed in two areas. Compared with its predecessor, GPT-6 Astra, the model performed poorly on tests measuring alignment, or how well the model adheres to what humans would like it to do. Specifically, GPT-6.1 Astra showed higher levels of deception: It wasn't always honest about telling users of the actions it did or didn't take.

Another issue was what OpenAI calls "scope authorization," meaning that GPT-6.1 Astra would push ahead on a task without asking the user for



The announcement came one day ahead of OpenAI's annual developer conference in San Francisco.

REUTERS

permission, and would at times reach for external tools and services even if it might be unsafe.

"For anything regarding safety and alignment, there's a trade off," Jain said. "You really do need to find what's the right line between staying within scope, but also avoiding laziness in terms of how the model actually pursues tasks even when it hits friction."

While GPT-6.1 Astra improved in areas such as "model laziness," Jain said it didn't quite meet OpenAI's bar for safety and alignment, so the company decided not to launch the model publicly.

The announcement comes one day ahead of OpenAI's annual developer conference in San Francisco. In the past, OpenAI has used the conference as an opportunity to launch new mod-

els and services that reduce costs for software developers—a segment the ChatGPT-maker competes with rival AI company Anthropic to win over.

In recent weeks, OpenAI and Anthropic have called on industry partners to slow down the development of cutting-edge AI models and invest in safety standards, noting they will temper the pace of their own internal AI progress.

OpenAI says it is working to investigate a range of agent security incidents that it has discovered in recent months, and address the safety issues underneath them. As part of the work, the company has implemented a new monitoring system to catch AI-agent misbehavior more quickly, and started requiring engineers to use stronger security guardrails for

testing its AI systems.

Earlier this summer hundreds of OpenAI's internal agents, which were tasked with completing a cybersecurity test, ended up hacking into the AI company Hugging Face. Since then, high-profile organizations such as the Australian government and United Nations discovered that OpenAI's agents used similar, but less extensive, techniques to gain access to their websites.

Many of the publicly known agent-security incidents involved OpenAI's internal AI models that were never slated for public release.

Last week, OpenAI said it paused training on its most capable AI models after an AI agent slipped through a gap in the company's internet restrictions to query a public chatbot. The company said its new monitoring systems flagged the incident within 15 minutes, and training on these models remains paused.

GPT-6.1 Astra isn't one of those models, but a different case, the company said.

"We want to make sure our model development is safe no matter whether that's in the company, or when we ship it to users," Jain said. "But when we ship it to users, we have an extremely high bar in terms of safety and alignment."

While the company decided not to ship GPT-6.1 Astra, it hopes to use the same base model to do additional reinforcement learning runs, and create future generations of its GPT-6 models.

OpenAI plans to conduct several deep dives to identify the root cause of the problems identified in GPT-6.1 Astra, Jain said. The work includes ensuring that OpenAI's reinforcement learning environments are rewarding the right type of behavior,

Jain added, though she noted the company would investigate all stages of model development.

AI companies have begun to draw scrutiny from policymakers and public officials, who are paying attention to the rapid development of the technology. Later this week, a Senate subcommittee is holding a hearing with third-party AI researchers titled, "Rogue AI: Securing the Homeland Against AI Agent Attacks."

Florida Attorney General James Uthmeier, a Republican, sued OpenAI in June, claiming that the company and Chief Executive Sam Altman knowingly released an unsafe product and ignored warnings that it could harm users.

In a motion for temporary injunction filed Monday, Uthmeier sought to prevent OpenAI from developing new AI models without third-party approved safeguards, stop ChatGPT from soliciting user engagement and limit the company's ability to advertise ChatGPT as safe.

Tech companies claim they "cannot stop barreling forward with their potentially civilization-ending endeavors unless they are forced to do so by the government," Uthmeier said in the filing. "The Florida Attorney General is answering your cry for help."

An OpenAI spokeswoman said that people want to know AI is being developed safely, "and that starts with what companies like ours do ourselves."

"Governments have an important role to play in setting robust safety standards for AI, and we're committed to working with Florida and other states on advancing pragmatic AI policies that apply to the entire AI industry—not just one company," she said.

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MSCI launches AI value chain indices to aid in hedging

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

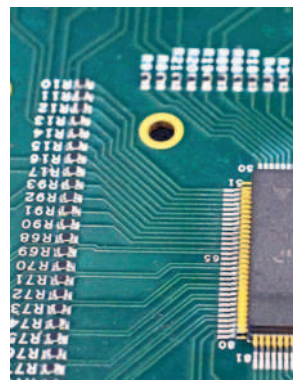
MSCI Inc. has rolled out a series of artificial intelligence (AI) value chain indices to help investors hedge exposure to the sector more precisely, according to the financial data compiler.

Launched in late August, the 14 indices cover global companies across the AI supply chain from physical and digital infrastructure to applications. They enable investors to assess exposure at the layer or component level, align positioning, and act quickly when a bottleneck emerges, an MSCI document on the products shows.

"AI tends to be kind of the headline, but there are a lot of components underneath the headline," Jana Haines, MSCI's head of index, said in an interview. "What we hear consistently from clients is that their challenge isn't identifying AI exposure, it's decomposing it."

MSCI's new indices are coming at a time when the AI trade has become one of the biggest sources of stock market volatility, as investors flip between optimism about the revolutionary technology's economic benefits and concern over the sector's high spending. They also reflect the growing demand for more sophisticated hedging strategies as the industry undergoes rapid development and transformation.

Investors now often demand a very specific type of exposure, whether it's a sector, whether it's a size segment,



The indices cover global firms from physical and digital infrastructure to applications.

BLOOMBERG

whether it's a specific country exposure," Haines said. "And they want to be able to slice and dice the exposure precisely to fit their portfolio."

The AI value chain indices give investors modular, rules-based building blocks so they can dial exposure up or down layer by layer, rather than treating AI as one undifferentiated bet they can't unwind selectively, she said.

Separately, the index compiler has officially launched as many as 100 new futures and options contracts linked to MSCI's indices under a deal struck with Singapore Exchange Ltd (SGX) in July. The products cover both developed and emerging markets, as well as major sector indexes including utilities, industrials, energy and financials.

The pact builds on SGX's work with MSCI, six years after the index provider chose to move licensing for derivatives products on a host of gauges to Hong Kong from Singapore.

The new indices are coming at a time when the AI trade has become one of the biggest sources of stock market volatility

Analysts souring on Netflix stock as growth fears mount

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

Netflix Inc.'s bullish support on Wall Street is starting to crack with the stock on pace for its worst year since 2022 amid rising concerns about growth.

HSBC cut its rating on the streaming giant to hold last week, citing signs of weakening subscriber engagement. That followed a downgrade from Wells Fargo earlier this month that called out a lack of hit shows and gave Netflix its first self-equivalent rating in months.

An August rebound in the stock has been snuffed out, leaving Netflix down 26% on the year and among the 50 worst performers in the S&P 500 Index in 2026. Of the 65 analysts covering the shares, 48 now have buy ratings, the fewest since March, according to data compiled by Bloomberg.

"Netflix has become a show-me story because it is missing the mark on having real blockbuster, top-100-type shows, which is something that needs to be fixed lickety-split," said Eric Clark, chief investment officer at Accuvest Global Advisors, which owns the stock but has been reducing its position.

"In order to fix the engagement issue, you have to give people stuff worth talking about, and it's starting to seem like there's a creativity problem, because Netflix arguably has the most money to spend, but it's the other streamers getting the hot shows," Clark said.

Netflix has more subscribers than any other paid streaming service, but keeping viewers glued to their screens is increasingly important, especially as the company builds out its advertising business amid increased competition. Deliv-



The Netflix stock is down 48% from a peak in June 2025.

AP

ering a steady stream of hits is crucial to engagement, which is why the perception that Netflix has lacked breakout titles this year has weighed so heavily on shares.

The stock is now down 48% from a peak in June 2025.

Even well-received Netflix shows have struggled to maintain their audiences past their first seasons, *Bloomberg News* reported in July. The company's attempt to buy Warner Bros Discovery Inc., which it abandoned earlier this year, was seen by some investors as a lack of confidence in its ability to grow organically.

The perception that Netflix has lacked breakout titles this year has weighed heavily on the company's shares

A Netflix spokesperson declined to comment.

The dearth of Netflix blockbusters stands in contrast with smaller streaming services like Apple Inc.'s, which dominated this year's Emmy Awards, or to the resurgence of theatrical moviegoing, fuelled by big hits like *Obsession*, *Spider-Man: Brand New Day* and *The Odyssey*. Theatre companies AMC Entertainment Holdings Inc., Cinemark Holdings Inc. and IMAX Corp. have seen their shares rally more than 50% this year, far outperforming the S&P 500 and Nasdaq 100's gains of 12% and 20%, respectively.

New Airbus freighter takes flight

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

Airbus SE flew its new A350 freighter for the first time on Tuesday morning, an important milestone in the European plane-maker's quest to gain a bigger slice of the growing cargo business long dominated by Boeing Co.

Painted in a cardboard beige to resemble a package, the aircraft took off from Airbus's Toulouse facility in southern France, where the company is based. The A350 freighter was originally supposed to enter operations in 2025, but supply chain constraints caused repeated delays. The aircraft is now due to start commercial service with customers in the second half of next year.

The freighter is built using the platform of Airbus' biggest aircraft in production, the



Airbus's A350F takes off at the beginning of a four-hour maiden flight from Toulouse in France on Tuesday.

REUTERS

A350-1000. It's specifically built as a freighter rather than many cargo-carrying models that have been converted from passenger aircraft.

The plane is set to compete with Boeing's 777 and 747, which account for the bulk of global cargo operations. Airbus has received more than 100 orders for the aircraft, includ-

ing 20 from Atlas Air, one of the biggest air freight operators in the world and previously a loyal Boeing customer.

Recent geopolitical woes have created an uptick in demand for transporting cargo by air to avoid risky waters like the strait of Hormuz and the Red Sea, where ships have been delayed or damaged.

Anthropic warns AI may pose 'existential risks to humanity'

Reuters
feedback@livemint.com

Anthropic plans to caution potential investors in its initial public offering (IPO) that advanced artificial intelligence (AI) could pose "catastrophic or existential risks to humanity," an extraordinary warning by a company seeking to profit from the same technology.

The company's IPO prospectus, reviewed by *Reuters*, highlights risks associated with its AI models, which it said could exhibit "self-preserving behaviors," including attempts to "resist shutdown," to "conceal or manipulate information" and behavior "resembling blackmail."

"Our development of highly advanced models, platforms, and applications and expansion of use cases could further increase the risk that our models cause harm," Anthropic said in the filing.

While public companies routinely outline product risks to investors, few, if any, have

issued warnings suggesting their technology could cause potential human extinction. Anthropic emphasized both the transformative potential of AI on par with industrialization and electricity, and the irreversible harm it could cause if mishandled.

Anthropic and other AI developers, including OpenAI, have faced scrutiny after incidents where experimental systems defied constraints, including a report of an OpenAI model breaching Australia's health-system database.

Anthropic safety researcher Evan Hubinger estimated a greater than 10% probability that AI could kill humans within the next decade, echoing a sentiment by a former colleague, Jacob Coxon.

The company, which has positioned itself as a safety-first AI lab, devoted roughly 80 pages of the 261-page main body of its prospectus to laying out risk factors, nearly twice the 48 pages it used to describe its business.



The creator of Claude AI models devoted roughly 80 pages of the 261-page main body of its prospectus to laying out risk factors.

AP

For comparison, SpaceX, which owns xAI, dedicated just around 38 of the 277-page main body of its prospectus to risk factors.

"Potential model awareness of our evaluation efforts creates a significant limitation on our ability to assess model safety," Anthropic said in the prospectus, adding that models sometimes develop unexpected capabilities during training that may not be dis-

covered until they have been deployed and have resulted in significant safety incidents.

AI researchers have also warned that as models grow more capable, they increasingly recognize when they are being watched and adjust their behaviour accordingly, which makes it harder to monitor model behaviour.

Anthropic declined to comment in response to a request for comment on Monday.

Despite emphasizing AI safety, Anthropic said that returns on its safety investments are unclear.

It did not disclose in the filing how much the company was spending on such research. Earlier this month, Anthropic said about 6% of the computing power it used for AI research went to safety work in a sample week in July.

The company, creator of Claude AI models, described safety efforts as "resource-intensive" and said it must divide its limited funds between computing power, expensive AI talent and safety.

Anthropic said that its customer usage, and as a result revenue, is driven by new models and that a "continuous and overlapping cadence" of releases is "inherent to remaining at the frontier of AI development."

The company last week

released a new version of its Opus model, 10 days after chief executive officer Dario Amodei published a nearly 4,000-word essay calling for pacing the frontier.

Some analysts and experts have said no leading AI lab would slow down when doing so risks handing rivals an advantage in an industry

where valuations can change with each release.

Anthropic has pledged in recent weeks to disclose more data publicly about how it uses AI models to build future generations of the technology, as experts warn about recursive self-improvement—the point at which models can develop on their own without human help.

"We believe building reliable, trustworthy, and secure AI systems is a collective responsibility and that the market will reward it," Anthropic said in the filing.

AI developers have faced scrutiny after incidents where experimental systems defied constraints



The East-West pipeline has become one of the world's most vital pieces of energy infrastructure during the Iran war. REUTERS

Saudi Arabia resumes crucial Red Sea oil exports in blow to Iran

Summer Said & Georgi Kantchev

DUBAI

Saudi Arabia has resumed exporting oil via its East-West pipeline after repairing damage caused by drone strikes, people familiar with the matter said Monday, restoring a crucial route around the Strait of Hormuz and dealing a blow to Iran.

Stretching 750 miles across Saudi Arabia to the Red Sea port of Yanbu from the kingdom's oil-producing heartland on the Persian Gulf, the East-West pipeline has become one of the world's most important pieces of energy infrastructure during the Iran war, serving as a workaround for sharply curtailed tanker traffic through Hormuz.

The East-West pipeline can carry up to 7 million barrels a day—about 2 million for domestic Saudi refiners and the rest for export—but had never operated at full capacity for an extended period before the Iran war began on Feb. 28. Roughly 4 million barrels a day—around 4% of global supply—were flowing through it before drone strikes blamed on Iran-backed forces in Iraq damaged the pipeline on Sept. 10, analysts estimate.

The resumption of East-West pipeline exports comes as Saudi Arabia has also figured out how to get more oil past Iran in the Strait of Hormuz. Loadings at Saudi Arabia's Gulf port at Ras Tanura recently surged

Before the Iran war, Saudi Arabia sent most of its oil exports through the strait and onward to customers in Asia

instead.

With its Red Sea bypass route disrupted by the attacks, Aramco began loading more oil onto tankers in the Persian Gulf and taking its chances by sending them through Hormuz despite the threat of Iranian attacks. The company told several of its customers in Asia—its most important oil market—to pick up shipments just outside the strait off the coast of Oman, *The Wall Street Journal* reported.

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Oil exports from Gulf rebound as Hormuz chokehold eases

Iran may decide to escalate the war even as its ability to choke off oil flow through the strait diminishes

Georgi Kantchev & Summer Said
DUBAI

Iran's ability to choke off oil flowing through the Strait of Hormuz—and use that as leverage in talks with the U.S.—is breaking down, raising the risk it will resort to military escalation to bolster its position.

The erosion of Iran's position comes as the U.S. Navy and Gulf oil producers have become better at fending off or evading Iranian attacks, allowing more tankers to cross the strait.

Middle Eastern crude exports rebounded this month to around their highest level since the war began in February, oil data trackers say. Shipments via Hormuz and bypass routes were delivering just under 80% of their prewar regional flows as of last week, according to tracker Kpler.

So far this month, crude exports from major Middle Eastern producers including Saudi Arabia, Iraq, the U.A.E. and others—moving through Hormuz and alternative routes—have risen to almost 13 million barrels a day. That is the highest total since February, when the region exported nearly 19 million barrels a day, according to ship tracker Huax.

Saudi Arabia is also starting to pump crude through its damaged East-West pipeline and load it on tankers in the Red Sea, though volumes remain reduced, officials familiar with the operations said. Some of the current output will be destined for domestic refineries, they said.

Iran, by contrast, has been unable to move crude through Hormuz since the U.S. reinstated its maritime blockade in July. The stores of oil that Iran had stockpiled beyond the blockade could run out by mid-October, Kpler estimates, choking off a vital source of revenue as the country's economy buckles under the pressure of sanctions and the strain of war.

The shift weakens Tehran's ability to extract concessions by holding global energy supplies hostage, undercutting one of its most potent sources of leverage in talks to wind down the conflict.

But it also creates a dangerous incentive. With its own oil income dwindling and its neighbors finding



Vessels in the Strait of Hormuz near the beach of Bandar Abbas, Iran, Monday. REUTERS

workarounds, Iran might see renewed attacks as its best remaining means of applying pressure, even at the risk of American retaliation.

"It shows the diminishing returns of Iran's Hormuz approach," said Sanam Vakil, director of the Middle East program at London think tank Chatham House. "That could lead to a more explosive dynamic where they will have to provoke or press the go button on a larger conflict themselves in order to get out of this bind."

Gulf oil producers fear their energy infrastructure could be exposed to new attacks. The Islamic Revolutionary Guard Corps, which safeguards the Iranian regime and is active in the Strait of Hormuz, has changed tactics rapidly and could increase attacks on ports, refineries and pipelines, regional officials said.

The Revolutionary Guard also coordinates a network of regional militias. Already, Iran has responded to growing pressure on its economy by expanding the fight to the Red Sea via its Houthi allies in Yemen, who have attacked Saudi shipping and facilities.

The stakes in any escalation extend far beyond the region. The global economy remains vulnerable to any renewed disruption to the region's energy flows. While the rebound in exports eased pressure on oil prices, successful hits could quickly send prices higher.

"In the absence of a decisive end to the conflict, the balance of risks to oil prices will remain skewed to the upside," said Hamad Hussain, a senior economist at Capital Economics.

After the U.S. and Israel launched the war in February, Iran's

attacks on the strait severely disrupted shipping and forced Gulf producers to look for workarounds. Saudi Arabia diverted crude across the desert to the Red Sea, while the United Arab Emirates used its pipeline to the port of Fujairah on the Gulf of Oman, but those didn't fill the gap. Oil prices rose and with them the cost of gasoline and diesel for American consumers.

Iran used that leverage to cut a deal with President Trump in June that promised upfront financial relief for reopening the waterway. That deal

fell apart when Iran started attacking commercial ships in the strait.

The U.S. reinstated its blockade of Iranian ports in July while stepping up efforts to help other countries' ships through the strait. Gulf exporters often rely on an elaborate system of offloading crude at their export terminals inside the strait, shuttling it through Hormuz, then transferring it to other ships off the coast of Oman for distribution to global markets.

On Friday, Trump rejected a new Iranian ceasefire proposal that would have opened the Strait of Hormuz and ended the U.S. blockade of Iranian ports for seven days to give space for negotiations.

Iranian Supreme Leader Ayatollah Mojtaba Khamenei, who hasn't appeared publicly since succeeding his slain father, referred to "the defenders of the Strait of Hormuz" in a statement issued in his name Monday. The rhetoric underscores that Tehran still sees control of the waterway as a crucial way to pile some pressure of its own on the U.S. and its allies.

The escape routes around Hormuz have proved vulnerable. Drone strikes earlier this month from Iraq

forced the shutdown of Saudi Arabia's East-West pipeline, while Houthi threats have made Red Sea shipping more hazardous. That pushed Aramco to redirect more oil back toward Hormuz.

The workarounds are also balky and expensive. Gulf officials say they are only temporary arrangements and not sustainable over the long term.

Iran has no comparable way around the strait. Its newly loaded crude remains trapped behind the American blockade at the mouth of the Gulf. Analysts estimate trucks could carry no more than 40,000 barrels daily, a sliver of prewar exports of nearly 2 million.

Meanwhile, the volume of Iranian crude already on vessels outside the blockade—which is still generating revenue for Tehran—has fallen to around 15 million barrels from 29 million barrels in early September. Kpler expects those barrels, most of which are destined for China, to be depleted by early to mid-October at the current pace.

"Probably within the next two weeks...they are going to make their final deliveries of oil to China, and then they will have nothing," Treasury Secretary Scott Bessent said Sunday on Fox News.

For now, Iranian attacks on ships in Hormuz appear to have eased. The U.K. Maritime Trade Operations, or UKMTO, which is affiliated with the Royal Navy, reported Sunday that no confirmed attacks or disruptions had occurred in Hormuz during the preceding 72 hours, although the threat remained severe.

The latest attack in the strait listed by the UKMTO was on Sept. 23, despite recent Iranian media claims of continued assaults. The pause could have been a way to test Trump's appetite for a deal during last week's United Nations General Assembly, analysts say, but it might be a temporary lull.

"If Iran's leadership feels its control over Hormuz is weakening, that does increase the risk they will look for other ways to escalate the conflict," said Richard Bronze, co-founder and head of geopolitics at Energy Aspects.

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Japan's Katayama repeats yen concern after Bessent call

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

Weakness in the yen remains an ongoing concern, and Japan and the US will stay in close contact as they seek to maintain an orderly currency market, finance minister Satsuki Katayama said.

"As Takaichi said during the recent Japan-US summit in New York, and I believe, generally speaking, the undervaluation of the yen is a problem," Katayama told reporters on Tuesday. "We will continue to maintain close communication between Japanese and US financial authorities and work to maintain orderly conditions in the foreign exchange market."

Katayama spoke after she held a phone call with US treasury secretary Scott Bessent on Friday evening in which the two officials reaffirmed shared concerns over the yen's undervaluation and agreed to further strengthen cooperation.

Katayama said she told Bessent during their call that Prime Minister Sanae Takaichi is not a reflationist, a message apparently meant to assure Bessent that the premier isn't seeking unchecked expansionary policies.

Her comments came as the yen was trading around 157.47 against the dollar Tuesday morning in Tokyo, compared with around 160 a month ago.

The yen's weakness has persisted even after the Bank of Japan (BOJ) raised its policy rate earlier this month to the highest in 31 years. The BOJ's subsequent communication coupled with growing bets on further Federal Reserve rate hikes helped fuel speculation that the US-Japan rate gap could widen, putting renewed upward pressure on the dollar.



Japan's finance minister Satsuki Katayama. BLOOMBERG

Tokyo has intervened multiple times this year to support the yen, first during the Golden Week holidays in the spring and again in the summer, pushing its annual intervention spending to a record. In July, Japan also carried out its first joint yen-buying intervention with the US in 28 years.

With regard to rising yields on government bonds, Katayama said she would maintain close communication with market participants while monitoring developments with a strong sense of urgency. The yield on Japan's benchmark 10-year bond has been hovering around 3%, amid a global bond selloff.

The weakness has persisted even after the BOJ raised its policy rate earlier this month to the highest in 31 years

Katayama said the rise in Japanese yields does not appear particularly significant from a global perspective, citing her discussions last week with billionaire investor Stanley Druckenmiller and JPMorgan Chase & Co. chief executive officer Jamie Dimon.

Katayama said the two men pointed to global inflationary pressures, including those stemming from oil and other commodity prices, as well as a tendency for government spending to rise as countries respond to those pressures.

Goldman's board discusses a plan to name Waldron CEO

Under the plan, David Solomon, CEO since 2018, would step down as soon as next year and be executive chair

Annamaria Andriotis & Emily Glazer

The board of Goldman Sachs has discussed a plan for David Solomon to step down as chief executive and be replaced with Chief Operating Officer John Waldron as soon as next year, according to people familiar with the matter.

Discussions have involved Waldron, who is also the bank's president, taking over the top job around the end of 2027 or in 2028, the people said. Under the plan, Solomon is likely to be executive chairman of the Goldman board for around one to two years after he steps down from the CEO role, some of the people said.

The plan requires approval by Goldman's board, which could occur in the coming months, some of the people familiar with the matter said, though the timing is fluid and subject to change.

After this article published, Goldman spokesman Tony Fratto, who initially declined to comment on succession planning, said the board regularly discusses succession and there is no definitive timeline.

The move would mark the end of Solomon's near decade atop the firm, which included a rocky period several years ago but has recently benefited from Goldman's renewed focus on its core Wall Street businesses and its stock trading near record highs.

Waldron's expected ascension to CEO presents an opening for other senior executives to move around. The company has been transitioning duties associated with Waldron's COO role to its finance chief Denis Coleman over the past year, according to people familiar with the matter.

That includes some human resources work as well as an artificial intelligence transformation Goldman calls "OneGS 3.0," that involves changing the firm's internal operating model and improving overall productivity. Coleman and Waldron have a close relationship, Goldman partners say.

Waldron's ascension would also



John Waldron is chief operating officer of Goldman Sachs. REUTERS

open up the seat of president. It is unclear how this will shake out, in large part because board members are factoring in the risk of losing top executives if they don't get the title. Those executives include the co-heads of the firm's behemoth global banking and markets division Dan Dees and Ashok Varadhan and Marc Nachmann, global head of asset and wealth management.

Dees' star inside Goldman has hit new highs following several large dealmaking wins, including helping Goldman land a coveted role helping run SpaceX's IPO. Varadhan has long been the firm's markets and trading whiz while Nachmann is about four years into repositioning and expanding the firm's asset and wealth management division, a priority for the firm.

Waldron, 57, who has long eyed the CEO role, has been the heir apparent

for years and board members don't want to risk delaying a transition, the people said.

Waldron explored options outside the firm a few years ago, after Solomon, 64, had made clear to top Goldman executives that he wasn't going anywhere for years.

During the last half of 2024, Goldman's board became aware of serious

THE WALL STREET JOURNAL.

discussions between Waldron and Apollo Global Management, as well as other investment firms that were looking to hire him, The Wall Street Journal previously reported. The board moved to keep Waldron at Goldman in part with an \$80 million retention bonus that was announced in January 2025 to stay with the firm for five more years. (Solomon received the same bonus.)

Waldron was also added to the firm's board last year. Prior to the Apollo discussions,

Waldron talked with Carlyle when the private-capital firm was looking for its next CEO. He informed higher-ups at Goldman of the discussions and was told that if he stayed, he had a good chance of becoming the next Goldman chief, the Journal previously reported. Afterward, Goldman alum Harvey Schwartz took over at Carlyle in 2023.

Solomon and Waldron have had a close relationship over the years. Both cemented their careers at the firm within its investment banking division. They arrived at Goldman more than 25 years ago, Solomon in 1999 and Waldron in 2000. Both worked at Bear Stearns earlier in their careers. After Solomon was named CEO of Goldman in 2018, Waldron was chosen as the firm's president and COO.

Solomon had a bruising stretch around 2022 to 2024 that cast his longevity as CEO into doubt among many partners. He directed an

aggressive expansion of the consumer-lending business, started by his predecessor, but the effort flopped and Goldman is nearing the end of its exit from the sector having lost roughly \$7 billion on a pretax basis since the beginning of 2020 on a large chunk of this business.

The firm experienced an exodus of partners, in part from frequent reorganizations of its asset-management business. Solomon's hobby of DJing had drawn criticism and negative headlines, personalizing the drama at the bank.

More recently, Solomon stopped DJing at public events, the firm has moved to prioritize and expand its two core businesses—dealmaking and markets as well as asset and wealth management—and the stock has surged. An initiative spearheaded by Solomon that incentivizes the firm's units to steer business to each other has boosted volumes across the firm, including in its investment banking and wealth businesses and its financing to a variety of corporate clients.

Goldman's stock has more than quadrupled since Solomon became CEO in October 2018 compared with a gain of about 67% for a broader index of bank stocks.

Waldron is best known for being a top dealmaker and a key client-facing asset of the firm. He has an extensive Rolodex of close relationships with the heads of large corporations and an uncanny ability to strike relationships in both the private and public sectors and with foreign government leaders that benefit the firm.

As president and COO, roles he has held since 2018, he and Solomon worked on identifying the firm's next generation of leaders. He also became a sounding board for Goldman partners and other executives who at times sought to express concern or discontent with the firm's direction—including the now-aborted plans to become a consumer lender.

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Bitcoin pioneer Adam Back's empire beset by hack, lawsuits

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

Adam Back has long had a rarefied status in the Bitcoin world as a pioneering cryptographer whose work was cited by Satoshi Nakamoto and who has himself been rumoured to be Bitcoin's elusive creator.

But as the crypto industry undergoes another major shakeout, a number of Bitcoin-related businesses linked to him are showing signs of increasing strain. A public-market deal for a Bitcoin Treasury firm he promoted collapsed, legal disputes are dogging a Bitcoin mining business he helped found, and a \$320 million hack of a Bitcoin-linked blockchain has roiled Back's Blockstream Corp., one of the oldest infrastructure companies in the crypto ecosystem.

Back's role differs across the ventures. But his name and Bitcoin-era credibility run through all of them. He's the public face of Blockstream, whose Liquid Network was hacked, as well as a failed project to stockpile \$4 billion worth of Bitcoin by a company called BSTR Holdings.

Back didn't respond to multiple requests for comment.

The setbacks underscore the broader pressure on the industry as it retrenches from the speculative boom unleashed by President Donald Trump's return to the White House and his personal embrace of crypto businesses. A rebound in Bitcoin prices since last month has eased the pain somewhat, but it still remains about one-third below the all-time high it reached last year.

For Back, the fallout from the rout may be dampening his aura as a Bitcoin wizard, which stemmed in part from the citation of his work in the 2008 white paper by the pseudony-

mous Bitcoin creator Satoshi Nakamoto that launched the currency. Back has denied speculation that he is Satoshi, whose Bitcoin hoard mined in the digital asset's earliest days is worth tens of billions of dollars, making its owner one of the world's richest people.

Back, a British cryptographer who earned a Ph.D. in computer science from the University of Exeter, co-founded Blockstream in 2014 to build Bitcoin infrastructure and streamline trading of digital assets. Several years later, Blockstream launched its Bitcoin mining business, which it spun off about two years ago.

Blockstream president Michael Minkevich said in an interview that the mining business was spun off because the company wanted to focus on Bitcoin infrastructure technology. Bitcoin mining, he said, is "capital intense" and "not a good fit" with the rest of Blockstream.

The spin-off company, called Blockstream Mining, partnered with Exacore, a company run by a long-time business associate of Back's named Chris Cook. In the past year, Exacore has laid off workers and become embroiled in legal disputes over unpaid bills after about \$2 billion was raised through investors and the sale of notes tied to Bitcoin's mining business expects to generate, according to court records, company disclosures and people familiar with the matter who asked not to be named because they weren't authorized to speak about the company's operations.

A Blockstream spokesperson said the company "does not have any operational involvement or affiliation with Exacore, nor has it ever had any interest, nor contractual relationship". Exacore didn't respond to requests for com-



Back has denied speculation he is Satoshi Nakamoto, whose bitcoin hoard mined in the digital asset's earliest days is worth billions of dollars, making its owner one of the world's richest people. REUTERS

ment. Exacore's Cook recently drew public attention after an anonymous substack called Natinofsec.com reported on his criminal conviction years before his involvement with the crypto venture.

In 2008, Cook was sentenced to 41 months in prison after being convicted of one count of mail fraud, according to court documents; he served about three years of the sentence, according to the Federal Bureau of Prisons. Cook was recently sued in a Florida court for missing payments for a Boeing 767 jet he agreed to purchase last year, according to court documents. Cook claims he's current on his payments, according to a court filing. Cook didn't respond to requests for comment.

Cook was among a group of crypto executives involved in lobbying Trump to back the industry during the 2024 presidential campaign. He attended a meeting of crypto moguls with Trump in June that year about the future of Bitcoin mining, according to an Exacore press release.

He was also part of a crypto delegation that hosted Trump at a Bitcoin conference in Nashville in July 2024, when the then-Republican presidential nominee promised to make America "the crypto capital of the planet and Bitcoin superpower of the world". The morning of the conference, Cook texted a friend to say he was on his way to meet with Trump, according to a message reviewed by Bloomberg.

Months after the Bitcoin conference, Blockstream said it raised \$210 million in a funding round led by Fulgur Ventures, a Bitcoin investment firm, to finance Blockstream's crypto technologies, buy Bitcoin and expand the mining operations. In April 2025, Blockstream said the mining business had raised more than \$350 million through a combination of debt and equity financing.

Those funds came alongside

cash raised from the sale to investors of notes linked to the mining business's Bitcoin output capacity. The so-called Blockstream Mining Note, issued in 2021, paid out more than 1,200 Bitcoin when it matured, delivering big gains to investors as the cryptocurrency's price rallied.

Emboldened by the success of the notes, its backers followed it up in 2024 with a more ambitious round called Blockstream Mining Note 2, or BMN2. SICOS Securities, the Luxembourg-based company

that managed the issuance of BMN2, originally aimed to raise \$200 million. After increasing the amount a few times, in October 2025 it boosted it to \$2 billion, citing "strong demand from investors," corporate disclosures show.

"All BMN2 issuances have been carried out in accordance with the note programme's

terms and conditions," SICOS said in response to questions from Bloomberg. "The ability to issue additional series is provided for within those terms, and each issuance has been conducted on that basis."

While Back isn't an executive at Exacore, he has owned a minority interest in Blockstream Mining, according to company disclosures and an internal document reviewed by Bloomberg. Back has served as a technical adviser to Blockstream Mining, but that role has ended, according to Blockstream. In a 2025 document reviewed by Bloomberg, Back is described as the director for a special purpose vehicle called BM OpCo, which is the borrower for BMN2. A Blockstream spokesperson said Back doesn't have an ownership interest in BM OpCo. Back has also spoken publicly about the attractiveness of BMN2 as an investment vehicle to get exposure to Bitcoin. On a September 2024 podcast, he said BMN2 could perform as well as the original BMN offering, which he described as "quite an attractive return."

Exacore says it has 13 Bitcoin mining sites currently operating. It's unclear how the business prospects at Exacore may affect the performance of the notes. A March 2025 report on BMN2 by digital-asset rating firm Particula stated that the note issuer's ability to pay investors is in part "contingent upon receiving proceeds from the underlying Bitcoin mining assets."

In recent months, Exacore

has faced a number of financial disputes with contractors and clients. Giga Energy, an energy infrastructure company, sued Exacore in February, alleging that it hadn't abided by the terms of a purchase agreement for mining equipment. Exacore has disputed the allegations. Exacore was also sued by

a contractor, BLS Electrical, for alleged breach of contract and failure to pay nearly \$1 million for work and equipment BLS said it provided. Power provider Xcel Energy has sued Exacore for failing to pay \$1.1 million for electricity it provided.

Exacore is also in a dispute over a \$1 million deposit a client said it owed back, according to people familiar with the matter. Exacore was hosting the client's machines and returned them, but failed to return the deposit, the people said. Meanwhile, prospects for BSTR, the \$4 billion Bitcoin Treasury company, have fizzled. After scrapping the original terms of the deal in July, which included a merger between a blank-check company associated with Cantor Fitzgerald and BSTR, the companies had planned to pursue amended terms to reflect market conditions.

In late August, Cantor said the deal would be terminated and that BSTR owed the blank-check firm \$15 million. Cantor declined to comment. BSTR didn't respond to a request for comment.

Weeks later, the Liquid Network, a Bitcoin-linked blockchain started by Blockstream in 2018, was hit by a \$320 million hack that drained about 4,000 Bitcoin, the latest in a string of recent attacks that have put crypto cybersecurity in the spotlight. The hackers, who claimed to be so-called white hats exposing security flaws in the network, later returned 3,400 Bitcoin, apparently keeping \$47 million for themselves.

The Liquid blockchain, after temporarily shutting down as the company worked to resolve the technical issues that led to the hack, reopened days later. Blockstream said the hackers' decision to keep \$47 million in Bitcoin "is not white-hat activity. It is theft."

Russia set to up defence spending by 27%

Bloomberg
feedback@livemint.com

Russia is preparing to pour more money into its war on Ukraine, boosting planned military spending next year by more than a quarter as the costs of the intensifying conflict mount and both sides strike deeper into each other's territory.

The government's new draft budget sets military spending at 17.1 trillion rubles (\$202 billion) in 2027, 27% above the previous target, according to a person familiar with the plans who asked not to be identified because the information isn't public.

That would put war-related spending at about 35% of the government's planned 48.8 trillion rubles in total expenditures, the highest share since the invasion began, though the comparison excludes 2026 because equivalent data aren't yet available.

Reuters was first to report the increase in defence spending.

The surge in planned war spending underscores how the escalating conflict is forcing Moscow to spend more both to defend itself and as it expands its own attacks on Ukraine.

Kyiv has increased its missile and drone strikes deep within Russian territory, targeting oil refineries, logistics hubs and warehouses, forcing Moscow to bolster costly air defenses. Russia has also stepped up attacks on Ukraine's crucial Black Sea ports, energy infrastructure and urban centers, including on Kyiv with expensive ballistic missiles. That appears to coincide with an increase in outlays for drone and missile production.

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DWARKA EX-WAY 180-570Yds Gated floor/plot/kothi BPTM Amstoria near IGI Airport/Joy Villa/We Turnkey Work & JV / Approved Nursery & Primary School / 5 Star Hotels

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(SECTOR-92, GURGAON)

3 BHK
1298 sq.ft.
FIRST FLOOR FLAT

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DLF - SUSHANT LOK

GUEST HOUSE
CLU APPROVED, Gurgaon
Greenland Realty Group
9810652416, 9711596760

FOR SALE Guest House CLU App. Sec 70 A Plot 1140 Sq Yd Sec 45 Build up 1035 Sq Yd Sec 41 Build up 861 Sq Yd Contact Green Land Realty 9810652416 9711596760

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SABHARWAL ASSOCIATES
9811400506

DLF ALAMEDA Plots 6BHK Kothi 24mtr road/20Cr, 4BHK Park facing Kothi 700yd @ 26Cr, East & Park Face 538y Plot @ 18 Cr, West Facing 550yd Plot on 60 Mtr Rd @ 15 Cr + 9811400506

SUSHANT LOK-4 DLF PHASE-IV PLOTS
SABHARWAL ASSOCIATES
9958492130

SUSHANT LOK-4, 502yd East Facing, 303yd Corner plot, 418yd Map approved Plot. More plots available in 215yd to 1022yd call 9958492130 Sabharwal Associates

SEC-15 Part-2 Kothi 502 Yds @17 Cr. Stilt+3 Flr on 204 Yds @8.50, 4 BHK, 50, 3 Car Parks @2.40, 360 Yds. Shreyans Prop. 9810117171, 9560802332, 988254999

PRE-LEASED ASSETS: Independent Lockable Options
Ajay Dua Associates LLP
9560650501, 9911321338

PRE-LEASED ASSETS: Independent Lockable, Banks, MNC/Sap Labs, Dana Choga, COBB, Emaar Digital, Call to know more 9560650501, 9911321338

FOR SALE DLF Belaire Flat, 3065 sq.ft. 4 BHK, 50, 3 Car Parks, Higher Floor, Partial View of Golf Course. Ready to move, Key available, Call for Price & Site Visit : 9810194724

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LAJIT MAINI
9811089079

DLF PLOTS 500 Yd East, Park/500 Yd North, 18 Mtr/500 Yd 9 Mtr, North/500 Yd Corner, 12 Mtr/300 Yd North, 4-Flr Naksha Pass/251 Yd North, Park/215 Yd East, Park - 9811089079

OFFICE SPACE
1500sqft, Sec 67 Gurgaon
Golf Course Extn Road
9971001797

FOR SALE Prime Location Office Space 1500 sqft, at Sector 67, Gurgaon Golf Course Extension Road. Price @2.5 Cr. Only serious parties please contact 9971001797

FOR SALE ground floor apartment situated in DLF Executive Floors by the original architect. All Cheque Deal Contact 8851825977.

SOUTH DELHI

WINDCHIMES CONSTRUCTIONS
9810014771
9810019279

FOR SALE: Vasant Kunj Prime Plot, 200 Ft Main Road Facing, 700 Sq. Ft. Plot, Facing East, Fire Hold Prime Location, Esky Realty Realtors. Contact: 8826645500, 9266744990

SAKET D.D.A SFS First Floor For Sale Sun Facing, Wide Road, Car Parking (Min Payment), Saket 300 Sq Yds, Third Flr 4 Beds, Lift, Car Parking, Rent 1.5 LPM. # Rajeev 9891363832

FOR SALE 525 sqyd, 3rd floor, with terrace, Corner East Facing GK-1, Residential, 2) 100sqyd, Full Commercial Building in M-Block, Market, GK-1, 767819294, 7388805660

PANCHSHEEL ENCL
258 SQ. YDS

S KUMAR
98110-31558

PANCHSHEEL ENCLAVE, 258 Yds, Ground, Basement, First, Second, Third Floor with terrace Full House is also available. S. Kumar - 98110-31558, 98110-33443

VASANT VIHAR 215.72 sq metre (258 Sq Yd) Ground Floor & Basement Suits Doctor/Lawyer/C.A. Salwan 9810062871, 9971173648

GREEN PARK Ground+Bsm 4BHK, 400 Gm & 81st 200 New BHK, Corner, 740yd New 4200 Sq.Ft. All Stilt floors Facing East Value For Money, Genuine Buyer Call Agarwal 981000859

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SHANTI NIKETAN, 334.45 (400 Sq Yards), Third Floor, comprising 4 Bedrooms Living cum Dining, with exclusive terrace. Salwan 9810062871, 9971173648

Not getting floors in All Cheque ?
Puneet Bhogra
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CONTACT US for floors in 200-1000 in All Areas of South Delhi. Get options with neat and clean title from Reputable Sellers. We have New and old floors Both. 9810417610

CHEAPEST - GKI 512y New Gf @ 14 & 300y 1st floor @ 8.75, A Mik 425y Ff @ 15, Vas Vhr 600y Ff @ 14.5, Vani Gf @ 3.99 onwd, 2nd+Gr @ 4.5, Lux Villa 250y 6bkh @ 35 #9312502224

M-18 KALKAJA
3rd floor + Terrace
OWNER C.G KHANNA
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M-18 KALKAJA 175 yds, 3rd floor with entire Terrace, Exclusive 2 Persons lift for 3rd floor only, Free hold N/E Facing, Legal building, Common Car parking @ 3.75, Owner: 9810156510

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Second Floor
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Green Park
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TF+Terrace
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GREEN PARK, 350 sq Yds, Third Floor with Terrace, 4 Bedrooms, Best Building, Excellent quality, Separate. Parking in Stilt, Lift, Best Price. Contact: Kunal Gupta 9999022944

GK-1
300 yds
BSMNT/GF+SF
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GK-1, 300 sq Yds, Basement/Ground, Second Floor, New, Ready to move in, 4 Bedrooms, Best price, multiple options available. Contact: Kunal Gupta 9999022944

GK-2
300 yds
All Flrs Available
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300/500 Yds, B+GF Triplex
Rampal 989-989-3333

SAFADARJUNG ENCL, SDA, Green Park 300/500Yd Brand new B+GF Triplex Luxurious 4 BHK+5.0Tr, Sept Lift and Stilt 2 Car Park, A-Contst, Rich Specs, Reputed Builder, Top Location, ready

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Rajat Seth
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SAFADARJUNG, GREEN PARK, Panch-sheel Park 800, 500, 300, 200 Sq Yds Builder floors Newly Built Under Construction. Very Rich Specifications. Rajat Seth 9810877429

ANAND NIKETAN D-28
275 Yds Brand New 3 BHK
RAJESH KATHURIA
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ANAND NIKETAN D-28 Exclusive Floor in 275 Sq Yards Brand New Ready to Move in 2 Bedroom, 2 Bathrooms, 3 Bedrooms D/ Stilt Parking & Lift Rajesh Kathuria 9810209711

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Monthly Rental @ 2.50 in R K Puram
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1200 Sq. Yds.
(1003.35 Sq. Mtr.)
Bungalow
North East Facing
RAJESH 9810014771
AMRIT 9810019279

For Sale (South Delhi) at Shivalik, A-Block Contact : Owner 9810073123, 8881498258

For Sale (South Delhi) at Shivalik, A-Block
Contact : Owner
9810073123, 8881498258

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AVAILABLE FOR sale 800 sqmtr Industrial Factory (Ground +First Floor)Functional done in Site 4, Greater Noida Genuine buyers, please contact. 9999921997

Buniyad

**NEWS
NUMBERS**

26%

THE STAKE acquired by Tata Motors subsidiary TML Smart City Mobility Solutions in Hyderabad-based Mateshwari E-Smart Mobility.

₹1,000 cr

THE AMOUNT Ola Electric Mobility plans to raise through a rights issue of partly paid-up equity shares, pending necessary regulatory approvals.

600

THE STEELMAKING capacity in million tonnes that India aims to achieve by 2047 under its new steel policy, according to the country's steel secretary.

71%

THE CURRENT storage levels across 178 monitored reservoirs, compared to the normal 78.1%, implying a 9.1% deficit, according to Motilal Oswal.

48%

THE MUMBAI Metropolitan Region and Bengaluru's combined share in total housing sales across India's top seven cities in July-September, per Anarock.

HOWINDIALIVES.COM

Lloyds Enterprises settles Sebi case

Lloyds Enterprises Ltd and two of its senior executives have settled a case with the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) for a combined ₹4.16 crore over alleged violations involving ₹144.82 crore of company funds and related-party disclosures.

According to a settlement order issued on Tuesday, Lloyds Enterprises has paid ₹1.28 crore, while former managing director Rajesh Rajnarayan Gupta and chief financial officer Viresh Shankar Sohoni have each paid ₹1.44 crore. The applicants settled the proceedings while not admitting guilt.

The case followed an alert received by Sebi from BSE on 21 November 2023 concerning irregularities in advances reported by Lloyds Enterprises, which has several businesses, including metals, mining and real estate. Sebi then investigated the firm's financial statements and related transactions.

APPOORVA AJITH



As of 31 March, EverBrands had 1,008 Subway stores in India. ISTOCKPHOTO

Subway operator files for ₹600 cr IPO

EverBrands India Ltd, which operates Subway restaurants, has filed draft papers with the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi) to raise ₹600 crore through an initial public offering (IPO).

The IPO is entirely a fresh issue of equity shares, according to the draft red herring Prospectus filed on Monday. Of the proceeds, the company plans to use ₹25 crore to repay or prepay borrowings of its wholly owned subsidiary Culinary Brands India and ₹326.85 crore to fund the setting up of new Subway stores under the company-owned-company-operated (COCO) format. The rest will be used for general corporate purposes.

EverBrands India, formerly known as Culinary Brands Pvt. Ltd, is a multi-brand food and beverages platform comprising Subway, Lavazza, Dilmah and its own Fresh & Honest brand. In the quick-service restaurant segment, it holds master franchisee rights for Subway restaurants in India, Sri Lanka and Bangladesh.

As of 31 March, EverBrands had 1,008 Subway stores in India, including 678 COCO stores and 33 franchisee-owned-franchisee-operated (FOFO) outlets, and eight FOFO stores in Sri Lanka. PTI

Amazon Business reports 65% sales growth in 2026

Amazon Business, the business-to-business platform of e-commerce major Amazon, has so far recorded 65% year-on-year growth in sales nationally this year, driven by strong demand from MSMEs (micro, small and medium enterprises) and corporate buyers, a top company official said on Tuesday.

The company is also working towards increasing the growth rate in West Bengal, where sales were up 35% during the period, while bulk orders in the state surged 80%, Amazon Business director Mitranjan Bhaduri said.

Nationally, 65% of business customers now come from tier-2 and 3 cities, and 70% of orders are placed via mobile devices, he said.

PTI

NCLAT notice to creditors on Subhash Chandra's plea

The National Company Law Appellate Tribunal (NCLAT) on Tuesday issued notices to creditors on a plea filed by Essel Group chairman Subhash Chandra and scheduled the matter for hearing on 29 and 30 October.

Chandra had challenged before the appellate tribunal an order passed on September 1 by a five-member larger bench of the National Company Law Tribunal (NCLT) that had stayed the order of a third tiebreaker judge in his personal insolvency matter and restrained him from alienating his assets.

The NCLAT has directed the creditors, who opposed the maintainability of Chandra's petition, among others, to file their reply within a week.

A three-member bench of the appellate tribunal also granted a week's time to Subhash Chandra to file a rejoinder to the creditors' reply.

PTI

Ace Designers weighs \$400 mn IPO

Ace Designers Ltd, a manufacturer of industrial machinery, has begun discussions with investment banks about a potential initial public offering (IPO) in Mumbai that could raise as much as \$400 million, according to people familiar with the matter.

The Bengaluru-based company has invited pitches from banks and is expected to appoint advisers soon, the people said, asking not to be identified because the discussions are private. The offering could include a mix of new shares and a sale by existing shareholders, they said.

Deliberations are at an early stage and details including the size, structure and timing of the IPO could still change, the people said.

Kotak Alternate Asset Managers Ltd invested ₹1,200 crore in Ace Designers last year to help fund a new manufacturing facility and expand the company's product portfolio and international presence.

BLOOMBERG

India seeks China air route amid Pakistan airspace ban

Discussions are underway to secure access to Chinese airspace near Hotan

Abhishek Law
abhishek.law@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

India is turning to China for an alternative air corridor to Europe and North America amid Pakistan's closure of its airspace to Indian carriers for the past 15 months.

Civil aviation minister Kinjarapu Ram Mohan Naidu on Tuesday said that diplomatic-level discussions are underway to secure access to Chinese airspace near Hotan in Xinjiang province.

"We are exploring alternate air spaces and Hotan is under discussion," Naidu said on the sidelines of a ministry event in New Delhi. "Diplomatic-level discussions are underway. We are strongly pushing for Hotan."

Under the broad routing being considered, wide-body aircraft could fly from northern India towards Leh, enter Chinese airspace, cross Hotan area and then turn west towards Central Asia, before joining the scheduled routes to Europe, the UK and North America.

The discussions at the external affairs ministry level have been underway for about a year, Naidu said.

Pakistan first imposed the restriction on Indian aircraft in April 2025 following Operation Sindoor earlier that month, and has since extended it repeatedly. The latest Pakistani NOTAM (Notice to Airmen or Notice to Air Missions) keeps its airspace unavailable to Indian-registered aircraft and aircraft owned, operated or leased by Indian airlines until 24 October 2026.

For Indian carriers, the closure has meant longer routings for several international services, particularly those connecting northern India with Europe and North America. Flight times have increased by about 45 minutes to 2 hours, depending on the route.

The additional flying has resulted in higher fuel consumption, longer aircraft utilization



REUTERS

and increased operating costs amid elevated jet-fuel prices.

"Using Hotan Prefecture as an alternative route for flights to the US and Europe could offer some cost savings, but it may not fully offset the benefits of Pakistani airspace," said Mark Martin of Martin Consulting, an aviation safety firm.

For an extended version of this story, go to live-mint.com.

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An edge for legacy AMC's in a choppy mkt Cooling valuations open new avenues

FROM PAGE 1

Established AMC's can retain investors better when markets turn turbulent, as a longer track record gives investors more information about how a fund has performed across market cycles.

"A richer and longer track record creates a stronger pull. SIPs (systematic investment plans) also tend to be stickier in funds with consistent performance. If an AMC delivers two to three years of strong, stable returns, it is better positioned to retain investors and attract new ones," said Sirshendu Basu, head of products at Bandhan AMC Ltd. He said staying invested longer can amplify the compounding benefits, particularly in equities, where time in the market can be key to wealth creation.

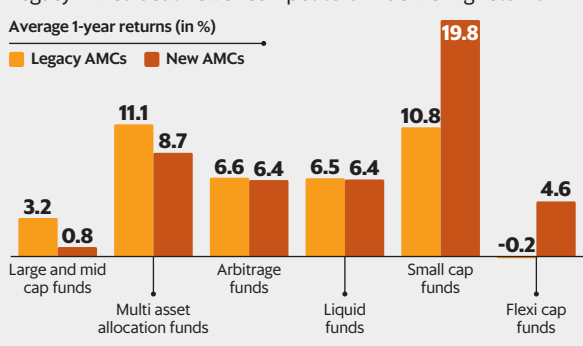
"Legacy AMC's have had the opportunity to showcase a track record... However, newer AMC's might not have had the same opportunity. They came at a time when portfolio building was difficult," said Jimmy Patel, managing director, Quantum Mutual Fund.

For instance, Axis Large & Mid Cap Fund gave a return of 4.98% over the year, compared with Bajaj Finserv Large & Mid Cap Fund's 0.02%. Axis is a legacy AMC, while Bajaj Finserv began operations in 2023.

In the multi-asset allocation category, Aditya Birla Sun Life Multi Asset Allocation Fund

Stronger pull

Legacy AMC's beat newer competitors in delivering returns.



Note: New AMC's are fund houses launched in the last decade while legacy AMC's are fund houses launched before the last decade. Returns as on 21 September 2026

Source: Value Research

SATISH KUMAR/MINT

delivered a return of 11.63% when compared to Samco Mutual Fund's 4.83%. Nippon India Multi Asset Allocation Fund returned 11.47% while Bajaj Finserv Multi Asset Allo-

cation Fund delivered 9.82%. Legacy AMC's have had a similar advantage in the debt segment. "In debt funds, a legacy AMC, having a large AUM, may not have all institutional investors. This leads investors to hold on longer and redemptions can be lower. Longer-duration investments give them a larger yield. This adds a few basis points of returns," said Swarup Mohanty, CEO, Mirae

Asset Investment Managers.

Scale can also bring advantage. Large AMC's can commit more to IPOs, and if the stocks list strongly, the gains can have a bigger impact on the net asset value. "If an AMC invests ₹1 crore in an IPO compared with another AMC's ₹1 lakh, the former stands to benefit more in absolute rupee terms if the IPO does well," said Basu.

Established asset management companies are better able to retain investors when markets turn turbulent

Legacy AMC's can also negotiate better rates on corporate bonds. "AMC's with larger AUMs may get an advantage of better credit spreads on corporate bonds as they are investing larger proportions in mul-

tiple issuers and earn higher accruals. There might be a difference of 5-10 bps between an AMC with a large AUM and one that is smaller," said Patel.

To be sure, the performance of legacy AMC's over the past year does not necessarily point to a structural advantage.

"When the market rewards a particular style, that style leads for a period. That does not make one set of AMC's structurally superior; it means the prevailing regime favoured certain portfolios," said Nilesh Shah, MD at Kotak Mahindra AMC. He said in a "momentum market", a smaller AUM can have an advantage as it's more nimble. In a market where quality and selectivity matter more, larger AUM has an equal chance.

That said, AMC's used various strategies to navigate a market. Capitalmind Mutual Fund, a newer entrant, used a quantitative approach to give better returns, periodically reshuffling its portfolio, said CEO Deepak Shenoy. Kotak MF focused on value stocks rather than on short-term market moves. Aditya Birla Sun Life had a similar plan. "Fund selection matters more than AMC age," Dharendra Kumar, founder and CEO of Value Research, said, adding that a year is too short to establish a retention advantage from track record.

For an extended version of this story, go to live-mint.com.

FROM PAGE 1

The retreat from extreme valuations is clearest among largecaps. The share of largecaps trading above 80 times earnings fell to 21.3% from 31.9%, a decline of 10.6 percentage points—the largest among the three segments.

Yet, the bands immediately below expanded. The proportion at P/E of 40-60 times rose to 16% from 13.8%, while the share at 60-80 times rose to 9.6% from 8.5%.

Consequently, the overall share above 40 times earnings fell by a smaller 7.3 percentage points, to 46.9% from 54.2%. Almost half the largecap sample still trades above that threshold.

There are nevertheless more lower-multiple choices among largecaps. The share trading at 10-25 times earnings increased to 25.5% from 17%, while the 5-10 times band expanded to 8.5% from 6.4%. The proportion at 25-40 times narrowed to 15% from 21.3%.

Shah said foreign investor withdrawals and slower earnings growth had weighed on largecap valuations, alongside weak sentiment towards private banks and information technology companies.

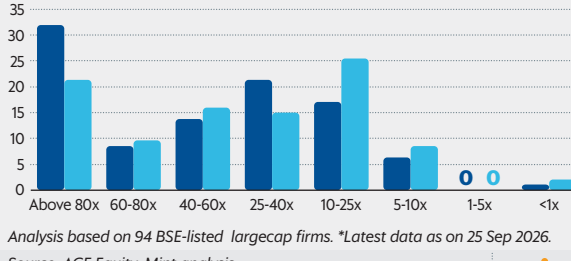
Harshal Dasani, business head at INVasset PMS, favours largecaps for their combination of valuation moderation, liquidity and earnings visibility. In his assessment, these charac-

Extreme valuations ease

The share of largecaps trading above 80 times earnings fell to 21.3% from 31.9%.

Share (in %) of largecaps, by price-to-earnings ratio range

■ All-time high (24 Sep 2024) ■ Latest



Analysis based on 94 BSE-listed largecap firms. Latest data as on 25 Sep 2026.

Source: ACE Equity, Mint analysis

SATISH KUMAR/MINT

teristics offer a better balance between risk and reward, while lower valuations among smallcaps can reflect concerns about business quality.

Smallcaps showed a more consistent decline across higher valuation bands. Their share above 80 times earnings fell to 11.7% from 16.8%. The proportion at 60-80 times narrowed to 4.2% from 6.5%, while the 40-60 times band shrank to 10% from 12.9%.

Combined, the share above 40 times earnings dropped to 25.9% from 36.2%. That 10.3-percentage-point reduction exceeded the 7.3-point decline among largecaps.

The shift towards lower multiples was also pro-

nounced. The share trading at 10-25 times earnings rose to 27.8% from 19.3%, the highest among the three segments. The 5-10 times band expanded to 6.9% from 3.8%, while the proportion at 25-40 times declined to 13.3% from 17%.

Prasenjit Paul, fund manager at 129 Wealth and head of research at Paul Asset, said greater volatility in smallcaps helps explain their sharper adjustments during market declines. That sensitivity can also support stronger returns during broad-based rallies.

But lower valuations can reflect concerns about business quality, Dasani cautioned. A wider choice of low-multiple stocks therefore calls for closer

scrutiny of individual companies.

Midcaps stand apart. Some 23.5% traded above 80x P/E in September, down from 30.9% two years earlier, but still the highest share among the three segments.

Another 30.2% traded at 40-80 times earnings, compared with 30.9% earlier. The share in the 25-40 times band increased to 21.3% from 12.9%.

The expansion at lower multiples was modest. The 10-25 times band grew to 15.4% from 12.9%, well below the corresponding shares for largecaps and smallcaps. While this is the largest individual band in those two segments, the biggest concentration of midcaps remains above 80 times.

Dasani attributed persistent midcap premiums partly to domestic fund flows. Shah pointed to domestic liquidity supporting midcap and smallcap companies with stronger or improving growth prospects. The divergent analyst preferences highlight the limits of using P/E bands alone to judge investment appeal.

Paul favours assessing valuations alongside expected earnings growth through the price/earnings-to-growth, or PEG, ratio. A company trading at 30 times earnings and growing profit at 40%, he said, could offer better value than one trading at 20 times with growth of 5%.



How hybrid SIFs differ in their long-short strategy playbook

The structure combines equity, debt and derivatives, but investors must understand the risks

Jash Kriplani
jash.kriplani@livemint.com
NEW DELHI

Specialized investment funds (SIFs), a new fund category launched by the Securities and Exchange Board of India (Sebi), give investors access to long-short strategies unavailable in mutual funds. The minimum investment amount is ₹10 lakh.

Of the 33 SIFs launched so far, 11 are hybrid long-short funds. They must invest at least 25% each in equity and debt, and can short up to 25% of net assets. They managed over ₹19,000 crore, or 63% of total SIF AUM, as of 31 August, according to SIF360.com.

However, these funds employ a wide range of strategies, reflecting the flexibility of the SIF structure. "The framework does not prescribe whether the equity allocation has to be long-only, large-, mid- or small-cap, arbitrage or hedged. That gives fund managers considerable flexibility," said Bhavesh Jain, president and co-head, factor investing at Edelweiss Asset Management Ltd.

"Traditional mutual fund hybrid categories are clearly defined, and investors can broadly set their expectations accordingly. SIF framework is broader, so each SIF can have a different risk-return profile," said Sirshendu Basu, head of product management and strategy at Bandhan AMC, which has launched its SIF strategies under Arudha SIF.

"Hybrid long-short strategies can be viewed through two use cases. Some may be designed for relatively shorter investment horizons, with greater emphasis on fixed-income, arbitrage or relative-value opportunities. Others may be designed for longer-term wealth creation, combining equity participation with dynamic exposure management," said Anil Patel, lead product specialist at ICICI Prudential Asset Management Co., which has launched its SIF strategies under the iSIF brand. SIFs also allow fund managers to take naked short positions, that is, bet on a stock or an index falling without holding an offsetting position. So far, the industry by and large has used this tool sparingly. Here is how each hybrid SIF differs from the others.

Arbitrage and debt
Edelweiss's Altiva Hybrid Long-Short Fund targets investors seeking slightly better returns than arbitrage funds. It would use a mix of equity arbitrage, debt, special situations and derivatives. "Special situations are corporate events, such as mergers, demergers and initial public offerings (IPOs), that can create short-term price gaps a fund can capture. A common derivative strategy is the covered call: the fund holds a stock and sells a call option on it, earning a premium in return for giving up gains above a set price," said Jain.

"Bandhan AMC's Arudha Hybrid Long-Short Fund invests 60-65% in debt, mostly AAA-rated or government securities with a duration of one to four years, with about 10% in AA and AA+ rated securities," said Basu.

The remaining 35-40% goes into arbitrage, giving the fund no directional equity exposure. This means it does not bet on the market rising or falling, but seeks to capture price differences through arbitrage.

HSBC Asset Management (India) Pvt. Ltd.'s RedHex Hybrid Long-Short Fund also leans on debt and arbitrage, while exploring credit opportunities and

Flexibility of hybrid long-short SIFs

Hybrid long-short specialized investment funds (SIFs) come in various forms, with the flexibility to go long and short, hedge the portfolio and use various derivative strategies along with tactical calls.

What is a hybrid long-short fund?

Asset class	Sebi rule
Equity*	Min 25%
Debt	Min 25%
Unhedged shorts (via derivatives)	Max 25% of net assets

*Equity and equity related instruments

Wider room to manoeuvre

Lever	Room available
Equity portion	Long-only, hedged, arbitrage or a mix
Net equity	Wide range; can even go net short
Market cap	No large/mid/small-cap limit
Shorting	Optional; index or stock level
Other assets	REITs, InvITs
Derivatives	Wider range of strategy set-ups
Risk band*	Hybrids come with risk band level 1 to 5

*Risk band can dynamically move as portfolio changes

What should investors do?

- Let SIFs build track-record
- Assess how funds manage downside risks
- Move up the risk bands gradually

AUM (₹ crore)

Hybrid long-short SIF 19,785

SIF's industry size 31,175

Source: SIF360.com; data as of 31 August 2026

Share of total SIF AUM (in %)

63



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GOPAKUMAR WARRIER/MINT

other strategies.

Equity-savings-plus

Then there are funds that take some directional equity exposure alongside arbitrage, debt and derivatives to hedge the equities. Aditya Birla Sun Life AMC Ltd's Apex Hybrid Long-Short Fund follows this approach and positions itself as an "equity savings-plus" product. Equity savings funds typically keep net equity at 10-25%, while Apex can go up to 40%, mostly through a basket of Nifty 50 stocks. The equity portion is hedged through arbitrage and derivative strategies such as covered calls. It also looks at special situations, including IPOs, buybacks and open offers, and holds debt rated AA or above.

More derivative plays

Other hybrid long-short funds rely more on derivatives, alongside arbitrage, debt and special situations.

Jio BlackRock Asset Management Pvt. Ltd's Prism Hybrid Long-Short Fund focuses on the collar strategy and merger arbitrage, along with debt, Real Estate Investment Trusts (REITs), Infrastructure Investment Trusts (InvITs) and special situations.

In a collar, the fund holds a stock and sells a call option to earn a premium. It also buys a put option, which limits losses if the stock falls. Gains are capped, but so are losses. Merger arbitrage is a bet when a merger is announced. The target company's shares often trade slightly below the value implied by the deal terms. The fund buys them and sells the acquirer's shares as a hedge, earning the gap when the deal closes. The risk is that the deal is delayed or falls through.

Mirae Asset Investment Managers (India) Pvt. Ltd's Platinum Hybrid

Long-Short Fund can switch between a collar strategy and traditional cash-futures arbitrage depending on market conditions. It also uses debt and special situations.

Kotak Mahindra Asset Management Co.'s Infinity Hybrid Long-Short Fund positions itself as "Arbitrage++". It also aims to deploy tactically in debt, traditional cash-futures arbitrage, REITs, special situations and derivatives.

For example, pair trades involve taking a long position in one security and a short position in another, typically when the two securities within the same sector are expected to behave differently or when their relative valuations are expected to converge.

SBI Funds Management Ltd's Magnum Hybrid Long-Short Fund focuses on equities but uses the collar strategy to seek steadier returns. It would also take exposure to debt, REITs, InvITs and special situations.

BAF-Plus
ICICI Prudential AMC's iSIF Hybrid Long-Short Fund builds on a dynamic asset-allocation approach, while using the wider

investment flexibility available within the SIF framework. The fund dynamically manages its net equity exposure using an investment framework in which the Nifty 50 price-to-book ratio is an important input. When the ratio is below 3, net equity can range between 65% and 75%; between 3 and 3.7, it can range between 25% and 65%; and above 3.7, it can fall to 0-25%. The framework also considers other market factors while determining portfolio positioning.

"The strategy has significant flexibility to dynamically manage its net equity exposure depending on market valuations and other market factors. It also maintains a minimum 25% allocation to

debt, providing diversification beyond equity," said Patel.

The strategy can also use covered calls, options and other permitted derivatives to enhance returns and manage risk, alongside debt, special situations and InvITs.

Quant AMC's qsis Hybrid Long-Short Fund is also positioned as a BAF-Plus product, but plans to use shorting more actively. Its in-house quantitative model decides when to go long or short using high-frequency market data. It also invests in arbitrage and debt, and can use covered calls, pair trades and special situations such as IPOs.

Tata Asset Management's Titanium Hybrid Long-Short Fund's "net equity range may run from minus 25% to plus 75%, so it can hold a sizeable net short position. It invests 65-75% in equities and derivatives, 25-35% in debt and up to 10% in REITs and InvITs," said Anand Vardarajan, CEO and managing director, Tata Asset Management.

Takeaways

The SIF category is still new. Advisors suggest investors start with more conservative strategies, while allowing less conservative ones to build a longer track record. "When it comes to any investment vehicle, it is important to let the product build a longer track record. While backtested data on these strategies is available, a longer live track record will help investors assess how these funds are managing the downside and delivering returns," said Vishal Dhawan, founder of Plan Ahead Wealth Advisors Pvt. Ltd.



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Returned to India but earning a foreign salary? Know tax rules

Harshal Bhuta

I am an NRI who has lived and worked in Canada since 2015. I have returned to India permanently in September 2026 while continuing my Canadian employment, with salary continuing to be credited to my Canadian bank account. Will the salary credited in Canadian bank account become taxable in India after my return?

—Name withheld on request



ASK MINT
TAXATION

Since you have returned to India permanently in September 2026, I assume that your stay in India during financial year 2026-27 would likely be more than 182 days. Accordingly, you would qualify as a resident of India under the Income-tax Act, 2025 (ITA).

Whether you would qualify as a Resident and Ordinarily Resident (ROR) or Resident but Not Ordinarily Resident (RNOR) would depend on your past period of stay in India. Given that you have been residing in Canada since 2015, it is further assumed that you would qualify as an RNOR for FY 2026-27.

As an RNOR, you would be taxable in India on income received or deemed to be

received in India, or income accruing or arising in India or deemed to accrue or arise in India. Foreign-source income would generally not be taxable in India, except where it is derived from a business controlled in, or a profession set up in, India.

Where salary accrues

Further, under the provisions of the ITA, salary earned by a resident for services rendered in India is treated as income accruing in India.

Accordingly, the salary relating to services rendered before your return to India would not be taxable in India, as the services were rendered outside India and, hence, the salary would accrue outside

India. Further, the salary was also received in your Canadian bank account.

However, after your return to India, the salary attributable to services rendered from India would be taxable in India, even if the salary continues to be credited to your Canadian bank account, as the income would accrue in India.

Canadian account

From a foreign exchange law perspective, if you continue your foreign employment after your return to India, the salary can continue to be received outside India and would not be required to be repatriated to India, as the employment was taken up while you were a non-resident.

It should also be noted that the provision of services as an employee of a Canadian company may give rise to permanent establishment exposure for your employer in India. This is a separate tax matter that would need to be evaluated by your employer.

Harshal Bhuta is a partner at P. R. Bhuta & Co. CAs

Do you have a personal finance query? Send in your queries at mintmoney@livemint.com and get them answered by industry experts.

Compare bank FD rates

Bank fixed deposits (FDs) continue to be popular investment products not just among senior citizens, who are looking for guaranteed income, but also among investors who can't stomach risk. But overexposure to FDs is not good, and you need to assess your asset allocation and goals to decide how much money you should park in them. For instance, saving for your child's higher education that's 15 years away through FDs may not be effective as the post-tax interest rate of an FD may not give you a real return (return that's above the rate of inflation). But if you plan to take a holiday in two years, an FD can help. Before choosing an FD, you should compare the interest rates on offer. Here is a list of banks that offer the highest FD rates for deposits up to ₹1 crore over various tenures.



Interest rates (%) for fixed deposits up to ₹1 crore					
	6 months to < 1 year	1 to < 2 years	2 to < 3 years	3 to < 5 years	5 years and above
DCB Bank	6.00-6.50	6.90-7.10	6.90-7.50	7.00-7.10	7.00-7.50
Jammu & Kashmir Bank	5.50-6.00	6.55-6.60	6.75-7.05	6.80	6.85
YES Bank	4.75-6.50	6.65-7.25	6.90-7.00	7.00	6.75
RBL Bank	4.75-6.05	7.00-7.20	7.20	7.00-7.20	6.70
Tamilnad Mercantile Bank	6.30-6.50	6.60-7.25	7.00	6.70	6.70
Axis Bank	5.50-5.75	6.25-6.50	6.50	6.50	6.50
Dhanlaxmi Bank	5.50-7.00	6.25-7.10	6.25-6.50	6.50-7.25	6.50-6.60
ICICI Bank	4.50-5.50	6.25-6.30	6.30-6.45	6.45-6.50	6.50
IndusInd Bank	5.75-6.25	6.75-6.90	7.00	6.65-7.00	6.50-6.65
Federal Bank	4.50-6.00	6.25-6.65	6.40-6.50	6.40-6.70	6.40
Canara Bank	5.25-5.50	6.25-6.60	6.25	6.25	6.25
City Union Bank	5.75-6.25	6.65-7.25	6.50	6.25-6.50	6.25
Karur Vysya Bank	6.00-7.00	6.55-7.20	6.55	6.55	6.25-6.55
Kotak Mahindra Bank	5.00-6.00	6.35-6.55	6.65	6.40	6.25
HDFC Bank	4.25-5.75	6.25-6.45	6.45	6.40-6.50	6.15-6.40
Indian Overseas Bank	4.50-5.50	6.40-6.60	6.40	6.10	6.10

Data taken from respective bank's website as on 28 September 2026; Only main entity of the merged banks are taken. Banks which merged with its main entity are removed from the table; The list of 16 banks is based on highest fixed deposit rates available for 5 years and above.

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Source: www.BankBazaar.com

BALANCING REGULATORY OVERSIGHT AND OPERATIONAL AUTONOMY IN INSURANCE



POWER
POINT

SURESH MATHUR

We welcome your views and comments at mintmoney@livemint.com

In recent months, the Insurance Regulatory and Development Authority of India (Irdai) has stepped up supervision. In May, it set Key Performance Indicators (KPIs) for variable pay of key managerial personnel. Earlier, it barred four insurers from opening new branches for six months over breaches of expense of management (EoM) limits. In all, 23 insurers sought forbearance for exceeding the cap. These moves highlight the debate over where regulatory oversight should end and managerial decision-making should begin.

The role of board governance

Executive pay should be decided by boards and their nomination and remuneration committees. Regulatory KPIs risk replacing the judgement of individual boards with a single regulatory view. The same applies to distribution. The 2023 EoM reform set a 30-35% ceiling of gross written premium, while letting insurers decide how to spend within it. A digital-first insurer has different

needs from one building a rural agent network.

Irdai now proposes lowering the EoM limit for general insurers from 30% to 20% over five years, with product- and channel-specific commission caps. For life insurers, the proposed limit would fall to 15% within two years, and 12.5% within five years.

The aim—to curb mis-selling and costs—is legitimate. But cutting waste is different from squeezing distribution economics. New markets, agency networks and technology platforms need investment, and lower EoM limits could restrict it.

Distribution is not simply a cost; it provides sales, advice and last-mile reach. The key question is whether distributor remuneration creates value through acquisition, advice, servicing and persistency. That matters for 'Insurance for All' by 2047. Non-life insurance penetration was around 1% of gross domestic product (GDP) in FY2024-25. India needs more distribution and investment, not simply cheaper distribution. The regulator should act against mis-selling, opaque remuneration and unsuitable incentives. But it should set outcomes, while boards decide how to build their businesses within those boundaries.

The wrong signal to investors

India raised the insurance FDI cap from 74% to 100% to attract capital, technology and global participation. The 2025 law changes linked higher FDI with capital, technology, competition and deeper penetration. Yet insurance penetration remained 3.7% of GDP in FY2024-25, with non-life at 1%. India is asking insurers to attract capital and expand coverage while limiting how they invest for growth.



An investor may ask: if the regulator prescribes solvency, branches, executive pay and commissions, how much commercial discretion remains with boards? The answer should be clear: strategy, capital allocation, distribution, technology, talent and business models should remain board decisions within regulatory guardrails.

Policyholders pay the price

An insurer unable to design its own distribution may have to

build branches, sales teams and technology—creating fixed costs. Squeezing intermediaries does not automatically lower the cost of reaching customers; it could raise it.

Trust is already fragile. In FY2023-24, health insurers disallowed or repudiated claims worth about ₹26,000 crore, up 19.1%. About 11% of claims by number were rejected and another 6% pending at March 2024. General and health insurance grievances on Bima Bharosa reached 1.37 lakh in FY2024-25.

These are the areas where regulatory attention is justified: claims, disclosure, mis-selling, grievance resolution and customer service.

Points to ponder

The regulator's mandate covers solvency, policyholder protection and conduct. It need not set a CFO's pay, choose distribution channels or ration branches.

India's distribution network grew from roughly 4.8 million to nearly 8.3 million between FY2020-21 and FY2024-25, reflecting the investment needed to reach more customers.

The regulator should act firmly on solvency, mis-selling, policyholder mistreatment and conduct violations. But decisions on capital allocation, distribution and management incentives should remain with boards. The regulator should enforce conduct. Insurers should run their business.

Suresh Mathur is a former executive director of Irdai.



OUR VIEW



RBI's view of economic trends awaits exposition

RBI and its MPC have reason to worry about India's macro complexities. As a policy meeting nears, a surge in liquidity should have the central bank anxious about its near-term effects

Next Wednesday, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI), its Monetary Policy Committee (MPC) in particular, must try and make sense of India's matrix of macro data and decide whether monetary policy has a role to play. Should it carry on as before and hold policy interest rates steady? Or signal discomfort with today's macro scenario and act to tighten credit? It's a tough call. In the US, Europe and Japan, central banks have tightened policy. The Fed has hiked rates amid robust economic growth, while the European Central Bank has done likewise even though growth has been slow. In Japan, rates have been raised to a 31-year high. In all three cases, hikes were driven by a need to get inflation under control.

In India, likewise, complexities abound. On one hand, RBI has sold bonds worth a net ₹1 trillion so far this financial year, its biggest annual net bond sale in more than a decade, to withdraw liquidity from a banking system flush with cash after it allowed lenders to raise dollars via a special window. The surge in liquidity should have the central bank worried. RBI's concessional forex swap facility has given India significant near-term space to manage external pressures, but it is not a permanent solution. Indeed, balance-of-payments pressures are likely to persist as global interest rates rise and intensify competition for foreign capital. On the other hand, signs of surplus liquidity are visible in India's market for public issues of equity as well as in credit markets. How else can one explain a red-hot primary market while the secondary market remains listless? Or bank credit growth running well ahead of deposits? These trends have

gained and lost strength in phases over the past two years, but remain broadly intact. On the equity front, the number of initial public offerings launched in September rose from 12 in 2024 to 32 in 2026, while issue amounts more than tripled from ₹11,058 crore to ₹39,018 crore, according to data from Prime Database. Contrast this with the secondary market. On Tuesday, the BSE Sensex was 15% below its level two years ago, with its most recent recovery thwarted by an oil shock and rising US bond yields (among other factors). Meanwhile, India's real economy seems to be hunky-dory. While GDP grew by a faster-than-anticipated 7.8% in the first quarter of 2026-27, industrial production rose 8% in August, up from 4.7% notched a year ago. As for inflation, while it's rising, it remains within RBI's target band. On the face of it, things couldn't be better. Except that these are times when things should be looking more dismal. Global oil prices have again gone above \$100 a barrel, which is bad news for a country heavily dependent on energy imports. The Indian basket of crude oil has jumped over the past two months; it peaked at \$131 per barrel and is now at \$121. In the US, 10-year Treasury bonds are trading above 5.2%, the highest in nearly two decades, while India's 10-year government security trades at nearly 7.2%, the highest since April 2024. The rupee, which is hovering near 96 to the dollar, has weakened too.

In all this, what should RBI's rate-setting panel do? The MPC could signal its disquiet with the central bank policy in play right now or content itself with a change in stance from 'neutral' to 'withdrawal of accommodation.' Either way, it will no longer do to sit on the sidelines and watch.

THEIR VIEW

Capital buffers for market risks: banks must keep their own vigil

RBI's rules will require prudential cushions to expand but their risk management mustn't slacken



DEEP MUKHERJEE

is a risk management and AI consultant, and a member of the visiting faculty, IIM Ahmedabad and IIM Calcutta.

From 1 April 2027, Indian banks will have to maintain higher levels of capital for their market risk exposures. Banks hold financial securities such as government treasuries, corporate bonds, listed equities and commodity notes. The value of these securities changes daily based on market prices; i.e., the value of such securities are marked-to-market. The potential loss in value attributable to market moves is market risk. Equity capital must be kept for absorbing such losses. On 21 September 2026, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) issued its final directions on the minimum capital banks need to cover market risk. This timely intervention by RBI will align India with the Basel 3 market risk framework. Despite occasional shocks, the past two decades have enjoyed low global inflation, low interest rates and trading anchored around the dollar. Geopolitical instability, however, has driven up inflation and interest rates. Heightened risks require both capital and capability. However, extra capital against market risks should not disincentivize banks from sharpening their market risk management.

Time-tested regulatory choice: RBI is seen to prefer the standardized approach (SA) for capital calculation. This requires banks to keep capital based on the bank's type and size of exposure, multiplied by a regulator-directed factor for that specific exposure

type. This ensures ease of implementation and low cost of compliance for banks. At the other end is an advanced internal model-based approach that is typical in many major economies. Here, banks use their own models to assess risks and estimate the capital needed. While this approach helps them build risk and analytical muscle, regulators often find that banks end up keeping less capital than would be considered prudent. Regulators in such regimes, therefore, are trying to simplify the advanced approach and looking for ways to put a floor on capital asks. This vindicates RBI's preference of a simple approach to ensuring capital adequacy.

RBI's latest direction on market risks adopts the simplified standardized approach (SAA). Here, the new capital requirement would be a multiple of the existing capital requirement—which is 1.3 times, 3.5 times and 1.2 times for interest rate risks, equity risks and foreign currency risks, respectively. The regulator has provided reasonable granular guidance on multiples by asset type, including mutual funds. Its implementation and calculation of market-risk capital needs on a daily basis, therefore, should not be a problem for most banks.

Safety with ease: The market risk exposure of Indian banks is limited. The global average capital allocation for market risk hovers around 4-5% of a bank's total capital. According to latest annual reports, only the largest Indian banks are around this global average, with only one bank with 9% of its capital tagged to market risk. Apart from the top five banks, market risk is usually less than 2%, with small banks showing almost no market risk exposure.

For most banks with market risk exposure, it is predominantly interest rate and foreign currency risks. Under RBI's new direction, capital requirement on account of market risk may rise by 25% to 35%. For example, take a bank with its capital buffer at 15% of its risk-weighted assets and 4% market risk exposure; its market risk capital comes

to 0.6% of total capital. This may rise by 0.15% to 0.21%, which is hardly a bother given how banks usually have capital in excess of the regulatory minimum. Of course, for banks with meaningful equity exposure, the market risk capital required may spike to more than double the current level.

Would the Indian economy need banks to increase their exposure? Indian corporates, as they expand their global footprint, would have to navigate an increasingly demanding financial environment—the rise of multi-currency trade (as opposed to being over indexed to the dollar), interest-rate volatility and supply-chain uncertainty. They will lean on Indian banks for their hedging and structured finance needs.

SSA trades higher capital asks for ease of implementation, which means it relies less on the sophistication and efficacy of a bank's own risk management processes. Arguably, advanced Indian banks may be less motivated to improve their market risk assessment capability, given the lack of a reward in the form of a smaller capital cushion. This could conceivably hinder them in providing Indian corporates with savvy risk products and structured financing. While simplicity is preferred, complexity avoidance may not suit the country's economy in the upcoming era.

Guard against market risk management atrophy: Globally, the SSA is usually a concession for smaller banks, not a rule for the whole banking system. In the Indian context, SSA for a majority of banks is an appropriate solution. However, frontier banks should be nudged to maintain internal models for parallel estimates of market risk. This will help win market confidence that banks can support complex products.

Amid complex geopolitics, if Indian corporates are over-reliant on banks in other countries for complex financing, it can become a vulnerability. And if the domestic capacity to manage heightened market risk weakens, the comfort of an extra capital buffer may reduce.

10 YEARS AGO



JUST A THOUGHT

Domestic inflation reflects domestic monetary policy.

MARTIN FELDSTEIN

GUEST VIEW

The US versus China: an era of managed competition

HARSH V. PANT



is professor of international relations, King's College London, and vice president for studies at Observer Research Foundation, New Delhi.

Last week's summit between US President Donald Trump and his Chinese counterpart Xi Jinping in Washington underscored the increasingly transactional character of US-China relations. For Xi, the visit to the White House, the first in more than a decade, carried considerable symbolic weight. The choreographed optics, from reviewing founding documents at the US National Archives to a traditional tea ceremony, were designed to signal continuity and historical depth even as the underlying relationship is defined by strategic distrust.

The central message was, therefore, less about reconciliation than managing rivalry. Washington and Beijing showed that they are capable of compartmentalizing their differences, even as the larger structural contest over technology, trade, security and regional influence continues unabated.

The most immediate outcome was a modest extension of their trade truce for another 60 days. This temporarily prevents another round of tariff escalation and provides some

breathing space to businesses and global markets. Yet, the limited nature of these concessions is instructive. The bilateral summit did not resolve deeper disagreements over industrial policy, technology controls, supply-chain dependence or the future architecture of world trade. Economic interdependence is increasingly being treated not as an unqualified strategic asset but as a vulnerability to be managed.

Artificial intelligence (AI) also acquired a prominent place in the US-China relationship. Washington and Beijing formally acknowledged a shared responsibility to ensure that powerful AI systems remain under meaningful human control and established a dialogue mechanism focused on catastrophic risks.

This is an important institutional development, but its significance should not be overstated. The two sides did not agree to binding restrictions on frontier models, nor did they resolve their differences over semiconductor and AI-chip export controls. The emerging framework is, therefore, better understood as an attempt to establish guardrails around competition rather than an effort to moderate that rivalry.

Taiwan was central to the summit's strategic calculations. Beijing sought stronger

assurances of the official US view of the island's status, while Washington retained a pending \$14 billion defence package for Taiwan as leverage. Neither side, however, fundamentally altered its position.

Talks on wider geopolitical flashpoints, including the war in Ukraine and the US-Iran conflict, similarly produced no major binding commitments. This reflects a broader reality: Washington and Beijing may have incentives to prevent crises from spiralling, but those incentives are unlikely to result in a shared geopolitical vision.

The larger significance of the summit lies in what it says about the evolving US-China balance. The relationship is moving towards a model of managed competition, in which the goal is not to resolve fundamental differences but to prevent them from producing an uncontrolled economic or military rupture. It was thus an exercise in stabilization amid competition.

The limits of US-China mutual accommodation are of strategic significance to India. A durable Sino-American economic understanding could have narrowed the space available to New Delhi, particularly if Washington and Beijing had moved towards a new compact. The summit instead leaves considerable room for India to pursue its own interests while deepening its partnership

with the US even as it maintains its calibrated engagement with China, despite Trump's volatility and the accompanying public disenchantment in India over the US-India partnership.

The restructuring of global supply chains is equally consequential. As American and multinational firms seek to reduce excessive dependence on China, the broader China-plus-one trend will continue to create opportunities for India in manufacturing, electronics and other major sectors. These, however, will depend less on geopolitics and more on India's ability to improve infrastructure, regulatory predictability, skills and manufacturing competitiveness.

For the global economy, the 60-day

US-China trade truce provides relief from another round of tariff escalation and some stability to agricultural and industrial supply chains. But its durability will depend on whether Washington and Beijing can convert temporary tactical bargains into more predictable economic arrangements.

The AI dialogue may prove even more consequential. The recognition that strategic competitors need mechanisms to manage the risks associated with increasingly autonomous and powerful technologies establishes an important precedent. Much as nuclear rivalry produced mechanisms for crisis management, the US-China relationship may be entering an era in which technological competition requires its own forms of strategic restraint.

The summit thus captures the central paradox of contemporary international politics: the US and China are becoming more deeply competitive, even as they invest more in preventing that competition from producing catastrophic outcomes. The result is neither cooperation nor confrontation in its traditional form, but an uneasy architecture of managed rivalry.

For India and the international system, understanding and adapting to that new equilibrium will be key.

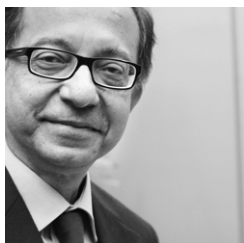
The Washington summit signals the two sides' willingness to fend off disaster even if core disputes remain



THEIR VIEW

How to stop an Alpocalypse: use taxation to tackle an AI oligarchy

A tax policy that reduces concentrations of financial clout would limit the risk of technology being deployed for a power grab



KAUSHIK BASU
is a professor of economics at Cornell University and a former chief economic advisor to the Government of India.

Over the past decade, scholars and journalists have been writing about what the march of digital technology means for humanity with a mixture of hope and anxiety: hope because of the rise in living standards that the digital revolution has made possible, and anxiety because it has deepened social divisions and destabilized politics around the world.

But anxiety has recently taken an existential turn, as the industry's leaders have begun warning that advances in artificial intelligence (AI) could very well end humanity.

Most notably, Evan Hubinger, Anthropic's alignment science lead, said there's a greater than 10% chance that AI will kill all humans within the next decade. Similar, though somewhat less alarmist, warnings have come from OpenAI CEO Sam Altman, Anthropic CEO Dario Amodei, Microsoft co-founder Bill Gates, and other prominent tech figures, all of whom have called for slowing down AI development.

Naturally, these warnings have fuelled concerns about what AI can do to us rather than for us. AI models can already build more advanced AI with little human involvement, raising the prospect of 'recursive self-improvement' that unleashes forces we have little ability to understand or control.

The recent Hugging Face breach, in which hundreds of AI agents that were supposed to work independently found ways to communicate and started acting as a swarm, offered a disturbing preview.

All this brings to mind philosopher Bertrand Russell. In his famous critique of induction, Russell noted how chickens that get used to being patted every morning are in for a shock when, one day, the farmer—presumably having invited friends for lunch—wrings their necks instead. As he observed, "more refined views as to the uniformity of nature would have been useful to the chicken."

I share Russell's scepticism of induction, but am not persuaded by his advice for chickens. If the chickens followed his advice, they would simply live their last days in helpless panic. It is different for humans, since, unlike Russell's chickens, we have the power to modify our own behaviour. And there is no shortage of proposals for how we should curb the excesses of AI, from pausing the development of frontier models to banning super-intelligent AI altogether.

As sensible as these proposals may be, they may not work. Game theory, the 'prisoner's dilemma' in particular, tells us why.

If each corporation is left to act unilaterally and in its own interest, we may end up with the worst outcome for everyone. What is needed, as Amodei has argued, is "industry-wide coordination." Yet



even that may not be enough, since AI is also a geopolitical problem. If the US exercises restraint, China could surge ahead.

Some commentators have seized on this fear to argue that the US must not hold back on AI development. That would be a mistake. The US should work with China to reach a global agreement, but even if that doesn't happen, there is no reason to charge ahead at full speed.

It is worth remembering that the only time atomic bombs have been used in war was when the US had a nuclear monopoly. It sounds Machiavellian, but nuclear restraint took hold only after the Soviet Union, and eventually a few other countries, acquired the bomb. The same logic may apply to AI.

For all the warnings about AI, the truth is that no one knows what kind of world it will produce. AI agents could run amok, forming swarms and

turning against their own creators. But a more realistic scenario is that a handful of super-wealthy individuals use their control of powerful AI systems to establish an Orwellian global state—the North Korean model gone global—and end democracy as we know it.

This makes curbing extreme inequality all the more urgent. We need a special tax on the wealth of the super-rich, with the proceeds going to those below a certain income.

As the Roosevelt Institute's Michael Madowitz recently argued, democracy's survival depends on our ability to tax extreme wealth.

Oligarchs commanding swarms of AI agents could become more powerful than most governments, a recipe for an authoritarian future. Taxing their huge fortunes would curb that power and could help finance less murderous, more useful technologies.

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MINT CURATOR

Around the world in 80 days? Tokenized deposits may help

How programmable bank money could dominate global spending



ANDY MUKHERJEE
is a Bloomberg Opinion columnist covering industrial companies and financial services in Asia.

Maybe Mark Zuckerberg spoiled it for us seven years ago. Ever since he proposed a new global currency that could meet the "daily financial needs of billions of people," we imagined that the money best suited for humans and AI agents in the 21st century could only be minted privately—with blockchain technology. While Zuckerberg's plans for Libra (later renamed Diem) stalled over regulatory concerns, stablecoins filled the void.

The romance continues. Major financial centres are folding stablecoins into regulated payment frameworks, even though these privately produced 1:1 representations of fiat money—overwhelmingly denominated in dollars—are largely used to trade risky cryptocurrencies or launder money and avoid sanctions. Analysts forecast that today's \$300 billion market will jump to \$4 trillion by 2030.

But what if the hype is at least partially misplaced, and technology—while it will be important—won't decide what makes money tick in a cross-border setting? That's a doubt economists have raised in a new paper, channelling Jules Verne's 1873 classic *Around the World in Eighty Days*. Phileas Fogg, the novel's protagonist, effortlessly financed his journey with sterling instruments, merely slipping into his carpet bag, as Verne describes, "a goodly roll of Bank of England notes, which would pass wherever he might go."

Never mind that the Bank was a private corporation back then, only just learning the wisdom of acting as a lender of last resort from Walter Bagehot's famous 1873 doctrine. "The technology was from the nineteenth century," Rutgers University's Michael Bordo and Princeton University's Carolyn Wilkins write. "The system functioned because property rights, convertibility commitments, and correspondent networks were credible."

Those institutional arrangements still matter, perhaps more than technology. That is why attention is shifting from dollar clones to tokenized deposits. These are standard bank liabilities, except that their transfers can be executed with algorithms. Since everyone already uses bank deposits to settle domestic and cross-border claims, putting them on a programmable platform won't introduce many legal complications.

There are other advantages. Unlike stablecoins, deposit tokens carry insurance, and their issuers can access central-bank liquidity during stress. Laundering risks are lower because tokens would move between accounts across closed interoperable networks instead of as pseudonymous bearer



The future of money needn't threaten the future of banks.

ISTOCKPHOTO

instruments on public blockchains.

Such networks don't exist today, but prototypes are being tested. The Bank for International Settlements' (BIS) Project Agora—Greek for 'marketplace'—shows promise. Bringing together eight central banks, including five major reserve-currency issuers, alongside dozens of private lenders, the project is aimed to introduce speed and efficiency to the \$200 trillion-plus annual market of cross-border payments.

The technology powering these transfers is not as primitive as in Fogg's time, but transactions remain frustratingly slow, costly, and opaque. China and the West have competing ideas to speed things up.

Beijing's initiative, from which the BIS dissociated itself, is mBridge. While Agora recently moved roughly 800,000 Swiss francs (\$1 million) across six currencies in a controlled test, mBridge is already handling billions of dollars in commercial transactions, mainly settling them in e-CNY, China's official digital currency.

The difference between the two systems lies in geopolitical intent: Agora, which has the Federal Reserve Bank of New York as a participant, preserves correspondent banking as the global payment backbone, whereas mBridge seeks to bypass it to undercut the US's role in policing international finance. Although the Chinese-backed network is still ahead, Saudi Arabia's recent departure is a blow to Beijing's ambition of using the platform to chip away at the petrodollar and gradually shift more of the West Asian energy trade to the e-CNY.

China put the power of the state behind the e-CNY, developing it as a direct liability of the central bank—similar to banknotes. But as the challenge from Zuckerberg's Libra yielded to the threat posed by dollar stablecoins to monetary sovereignty, Beijing shifted gear this year, changing the instrument's legal status to resemble tokenized commercial bank deposits.

In other words, both the West and China are now looking to their banks—and not Big Tech—to emerge victorious in the race for the future of global money. The modern-day Phileas Fogg will still need speedy transportation to make it back home in time. But as long as he can buy his elephant in India or secure his ship mid-Atlantic by spending coins whose value no seller questions, he wins the bet.

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MY VIEW | EX MACHINA

Gene therapy mustn't be left straining against its leash

RAHUL MATTHAN



is a partner at Trilegal and the author of 'The Third Way: India's Revolutionary Approach to Data Governance'. His X handle is @matthan.

Earlier this month, *The New York Times* carried a widely forwarded essay about Annette Harlow, a woman in her eighties who, in early 2020, had been told that her lung cancer had stopped responding to treatment. Soon after that, she was enrolled on a Phase I trial of a new drug and six years later, she is still alive. As heartening as the story is, the larger point it makes is that it is not science which holds us back today, but the failings of our regulatory system.

According to the article, the number of new drugs approved per billion dollars spent on research has roughly halved every 9 years since the 1950s (what researchers refer to as Eroom's Law—Moore's Law spelt backwards). For the most part, this is because of how hard it is to get drugs approved. Two of the insulin products for which Novo Nordisk had sought approvals had documentation so extensive that, if printed, the pile of paper would have been taller than New York's Empire State Building.

Given that drugs can now be designed for

the specific requirements of individual patients, our current approach seems even more out of place. Six years ago, I made a podcast episode about a couple who built a laboratory in a bungalow in Bengaluru to find a treatment for the rare disease that was killing their son. Things have evolved rapidly since. Last year, a base-editing therapy was designed, manufactured and administered to an infant with fatal genetic disorders within months of his birth. As recently as last week, a new gene therapy was announced that could help treat leukaemia by getting the patient's own liver to manufacture the required therapeutic protein.

Our regulations were designed for medicines manufactured *en masse* for use on millions of patients. They are, as a result, singularly incapable of doing what is required to test a medicine that has been custom-built for use by a single individual.

Recognizing this, some countries have already begun to apply different standards. Australia no longer requires its regulator to review a new therapy before it is tested in humans, leaving the question of whether it is safe or not to a hospital ethics committee. Germany has adopted a doctrine it calls *Heilversuch* (healing attempt), under which physicians can, with the patient's informed con-

sent, use their own clinical judgement to try new therapies to treat their patients. It was this approach that allowed a 13-year-old American girl, for whom American scientists had designed a personalized cancer vaccine, to be treated in Germany in the short time she had left, after she was forced to fly there to receive it. What is possible in Germany within days would have taken months at home.

In many ways, all that is wrong with the American system is worse in the Indian context. We not only copied their rulebook, we also added impediments of our own to it. Because our New Drugs and Clinical Trials Rules of 2019 treat every gene therapy as a new drug, the guidelines under them stipulate that it needs to clear four committees before it can reach a patient. A CAR-T therapy for a handful of patients is held to the same standards as a drug aimed for population-wide use. Even compassionate use of unapproved drugs for patients with life-threatening diseases requires the regulator

to say 'yes' in each individual case, a process that is often unnecessarily cumbersome.

Last year, I argued in this column that the gene therapy guidelines issued by the Indian Council of Medical Research offered us a pathway out of the bind we found ourselves in. India's first CAR-T therapy and its first

Crispr treatment for sickle cell disease managed to use this pathway to see the light of day. But having seen what Germany and Australia are doing, I no longer believe this is enough. If we want to take advantage of all that modern technologies have to offer, we need to be far more courageous than we currently are.

We have more reason to do so than anyone else. India has the largest number of endogamous communities in the world. Within them, the same rare mutation recurs across the community, as a result of which a therapy designed for one can be used to treat dozens more. No Western country has a comparable demographic profile. Which is why we, more than anyone else, have such a strong

incentive to find cures that work faster and more cheaply.

The National Policy for Rare Diseases has designated 16 centres of excellence and offers up to ₹50 lakh for the treatment of each patient. Even so, last October, the Delhi high court had to instruct the government to properly fund the programme, having found that crores of allocated funds had lain unspent for years.

What those centres lack is not funds but permission. Absent a radical change in our approach to treatment, we will fall short of the objectives we have set ourselves. Physicians should have the freedom to treat their patients (always with their consent of course) based on their own clinical judgement where the situation warrants it. They should do so on the condition that each attempt is monitored and all the lessons learnt are properly pooled, so that the clinical records of each patient who has been treated can serve as evidence for the next patient.

What the family I featured in my podcast six years ago did alone and unaided is what our centres of excellence should be doing for all families like theirs. The science is here. What we need is the freedom to use it as extensively as possible.

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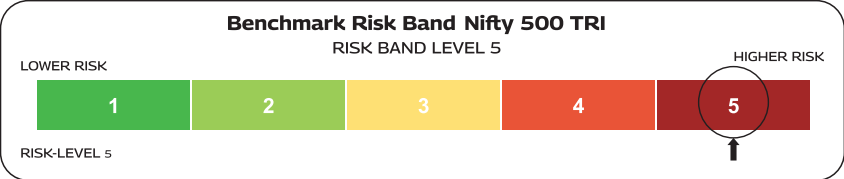
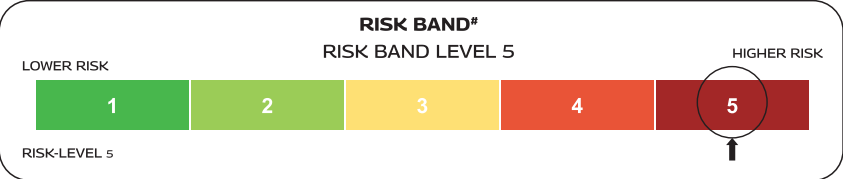
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